

Sunday Pioneer

TRUSTED SINCE 1865

RNI No. 53466/91. Vol.36 Issue 219

NEW DELHI | SUNDAY, AUGUST 9, 2026 | PAGES 12+4 | ₹6.00

PUBLISHED FROM: DELHI LUCKNOW BHOPAL RAIPUR BHUBANESWAR RANCHI CHANDIGARH DEHRADUN HYDERABAD VIJAYAWADA THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

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Padikkal seals spot with stylish hundred as Jaiswal, Pant fail

AGENDA



The chart depicts an major maritime routes and the potential impact of a conflict in the Gulf region. It shows the flow of oil and other commodities through the Hormuz Strait, which is a critical chokepoint for global energy supplies. The map highlights the strategic importance of the region and the potential for disruption.

Keep curiosity alive, PM tells students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Reaching out to the young generation, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday urged students to keep national interest at the centre of their decisions and ask themselves how their actions can benefit the country and address their needs.

This exhortation came in the aftermath of the Jantar Mantar protests and Modi's renewed efforts to connect with Gen Z and gain their confidence. The appeal on Saturday was made to the graduating students of the premier Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi. He laid special emphasis on the achievements and breakthroughs made by the young professionals, indicating that the Government is determined to go all the way to retain its appeal amongst the new generation.

The Prime Minister told them to question things that are accepted without a thought, and stressed that they should not stop at questioning but have the courage to also find their solutions. He asked students to keep



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressing the 57th Convocation Ceremony of Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) in New Delhi on Saturday PTI

curiosity alive in life and keep their learning instinct awakened. Modi made these remarks while addressing the 57th Convocation of IIT Delhi. Over 3,000 students and 587 PhD scholars were present.

PM also said challenges will become opportunities for those who dare to find new solutions to challenges. He

stressed that the more empowered the youth of the country are, the more empowered the entire country will be. He said India is now working towards becoming self-reliant in every sector; whether it is economic self-reliance, technological self-reliance, or industrial self-reliance; this forms the strong foundation of 'Viksit Bharat'.

Reflecting on the whirlwind journey of the students, the Prime Minister vividly recalled their transition from orientation day to convocation, acknowledging the diverse aspirations, from landing first salaries and building startups to pursuing further competitive exams that fill their minds.

Encouraging the students

to deeply cherish their current moments, Modi humorously referenced beloved campus memories, including inter-hostel rivalries across Kumaon, Ara, Kara, Vindhy, Nilgiri, Kailash, and Himadri, alongside local culinary favourites like Jia Sarai's Poha and Satpura mess Parathas. "In the coming times when you will have massive responsibilities, the memories of this place will definitely energise you," remarked PM.

Highlighting the profound emotional resonance of the ceremony, he reflected on the vibrant, dream-filled atmosphere of the campus.

Congratulating the students and their families on their academic achievements, the Prime Minister emphasised that their degrees represent much more than academic success, serving as a mandate to contribute to the nation.

He extended special praise to the medal recipients and celebrated the launch of new AI initiatives at the institute. "You are stepping out from here with a dream of doing a lot for the country," he said.

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Govt vs Meta: Can it still be called an 'Intermediary'?

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Indian Government and Meta are currently engaged in discussions over the company's status as an intermediary under Indian law. What began as calm talks has turned into a major legal question that could reshape the digital world: Can a platform that influences content and promotes paid posts still be called an "intermediary"?

Government sources say recent meetings have focused on Meta's recommendation systems and paid content promotions. The main question is whether these features mean Meta is no longer a neutral messenger but is acting as a publisher. Section 79 of the Information Technology Act gives intermediaries a "safe harbour," protecting them from being held responsible for third-party content. This protection is based on the idea that they only carry user content without controlling or choosing what appears.



Now, sources say the Government is asking a tougher question. If Meta's algorithms decide what content users see and give paid posts special placement, is the platform still neutral, or is it shaping what people see? If a company chooses what information users see, it is not just a passive channel. It is acting as a publisher. Unlike intermediaries, publishers are responsible for the content they share with the public. This is not just an old legal idea.

Safe harbour has protected platforms from lawsuits over user content, which has helped them grow. Without

this protection, they could face serious legal risks. Intermediaries that do not follow Section 79 and the IT Rules 2021 could lose this exemption. If that happens, they could be fully subject to the IT Act or the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), making even one viral post a serious issue. At the same time, another concern is being discussed: deepfakes. In recent meetings, officials have asked Meta to do more to stop fake digital images and voices that can impersonate people, create false scandals, or quickly spread misinformation.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

GREAT OFFERS!



3,323 Indians deported from Canada in six months

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ottawa

Canada deported 3,323 Indian nationals in the first six months of 2026, putting the figure on track to surpass the last six years' record, according to official data.

According to data from the Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA), the number of Indians removed from the North American country in the first half of this year is already nearly 88 per cent of the 3,779 removed during the whole of 2025, which was itself a record high.



The data comes at a time when Canada has been tightening its immigration system and reducing the number of temporary residents, including international students and temporary foreign workers.

Canada routinely deports Indian nationals primarily due to non-compliance with immigration rules, rejected asylum or refugee claims, visa overstays and visa fraud scams.

Indians emerged as the largest nationality among those removed from Canada in the first half of 2026, overtaking Mexicans with 1,573 deportations.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi interacts with students on stage during the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' program in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh PTI

Indian youth potential unparalleled: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj (UP)

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Saturday said India's youths are the country's greatest strength, and their potential is unparalleled in the world. Addressing the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' programme at KP Ground, Rahul Gandhi said, "You are the power and pride of India. When I say this, I am talking about every Indian citizen."

He added, "This evening I want to speak to you about *dard* (pain), *data*, and *daulat* (wealth)." The Congress leader said India's 40 crore youths constitute its "greatest strength." He

said that while there is much talk about America, China and Russia, "India's youths are unparalleled."

He also raised his concerns about the debasement of educational credentials in the country. "Today, education certificates have no meaning in India because they cannot give you a job," he said.

Rahul said all doors of employment are "closed" in the country. He said that a decline in manufacturing, difficulties in securing loans, exam paper leaks and artificial intelligence replacing jobs were hurting the youths' prospects.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

SAD backs Delimitation Bill, signals BJP alliance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A day after meeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) president Sukhbir Singh Badal announced the party's support for the Women's Reservation Bill and the Delimitation Bill. The SAD, at a meeting of its senior leaders in Chandigarh on Saturday, demanded the immediate implementation of the Women's Reservation Bill, SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal said in a post on X.

The support for the Delimitation Bill is a clear indication that an SAD-BJP alliance for the



upcoming Punjab elections is in the works.

"The Shiromani Akali Dal draws inspiration from the teachings of the Sikh Gurus, who championed the dignity, equality and equal rights of

women. The Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (@SGPCAmritsar) has already set an example by providing for women's reservation in its House," he said. The party also extend-

ed its support to the Delimitation Bill. According to Badal, after detailed deliberations on key issues before the Parliament, the SAD demanded a fair and equitable delimitation process that ensures equal representation to all States.

The Shiromani Akali Dal supported the proposal put forward by the Government of India on the floor of the House for a uniform 50 per cent increase in the number of seats for all States. The party emphasised that both women's reservation and delimitation should be implemented immediately.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

MHA bans new renewable projects near borders

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has issued comprehensive national security guidelines that prohibit any new solar, wind and hybrid renewable energy projects within one kilometre of the Line of Control (LoC), Line of Actual Control (LAC), and the International Border.

The internal security division has set strict rules for hiring workers from countries that share a land border with India and added extra clearance steps for projects in larger sensitive zones. Any area within 50 km of the LoC, LAC, or International Border is now called a "sensitive area."

All new solar, wind, and hybrid pro-



jects in these zones must get security clearance from the MHA before starting.

No project work is allowed within the first kilometre of these borders. Proposals for projects between 1 km and 50 km will be reviewed by both the MHA and the Ministry of Defence

on a case-by-case basis. Projects within 20 km of the International Border also need a separate No-Objection Certificate from the Defence Ministry. The guidelines say applicants "should not engage engineers, staff, employees and labour from land border countries, especially Pakistan, Bangladesh and China," for project work unless they have permission from the Central Government.

This is not allowed without Central approval, including a new security clearance from the MHA. Officials said these "uniform transparent guidelines" were finalised after a memo on June 5 and discussions with stakeholders.

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PANT SLAMS RED TAPE OVER UTTARAKHAND LAND PURCHASE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Star wicket-keeper and explosive batter Rishabh Pant wants to return to his roots in Uttarakhand. He is trying to purchase land in the State but has been deterred by red tape for the last three years. At last, the gritty cricketer who recov-



ered from a near-fatal road mishap a few years back took to social media to vent his frustration.

Currently touring Sri Lanka with the national team, Pant has sought Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami's help in purchasing land to build his first home in the State, saying procedural difficulties and a lack of clarity have stalled his efforts for nearly three years. Responding to Pant, Dhami described him as "the pride of Uttarakhand" and assured him of all possible assistance in accordance with the law.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Pasta, pizza, momos: Kanwar camps serve a fusion of modern flavours

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Meerut (UP)/New Delhi

Undertaking the arduous Kanwar yatra calls for perseverance besides devotion. Regardless of the demanding schedule, Kanwariyas take part in this journey every year, and they are provided nourishing and tasty vegetarian fare along the route.

During the ongoing yatra, from pasta and pizza to momos and shahi paneer, and from traditional *puri-roti-sabzi* to contemporary snacks, all prepared without onion and garlic, are being served at several Kanwar camps between Meerut and Delhi — a striking blend of the traditional and the contemporary.

As per the menu, early morning snacks include tea, biscuits, *poha*, and *jalebi*. The breakfast spread includes *samosas*, *kachoris*, bread *pakor*as, vegetable hakka noodles, and honey chilli potatoes. Lunch features dishes like *shahi paneer*, *kadhai paneer*, *paneer lababdar*, *dal makhani*, and mixed vegetables, served with *chur-chur naan*, butter *naan*, jeera rice, and *rotis*. Sweet dishes such as *rabri-jalebi*, rasmalai, rasgulla and *gulab jamun* complement the main course. For evening snacks, pilgrims are served spring rolls, chilli paneer, manchurian, white and red sauce pasta, vegetable pizza, momos, macaroni, soup, and burgers.



Kanwariyas' carry Ganga water during the holy month of Shravan in Indirapuram PTI

The dinner spread has *chhole-puri*, *matar paneer*, *pulao*, *dal and rotis*, along with *kheer*, *halwa*, fruit custard, and *gulab jamun*. The camps also ensure a continuous supply of lassi, buttermilk, juice, tea, coffee, and cold drinking water. At the Kankarkheda Vyapar Sangh camp in Meerut, a machine capable of kneading 20 kg of dough at once and an automatic roti-making machine have been installed, said coordinator Neeraj Mittal and operations manager Rajesh Khanna.

The machine produces approximately 16 *rotis* per minute and around 900 per hour, with a daily output of 6,000 to 7,000 *rotis*. Machines are also being used to chop

vegetables and prepare spices in bulk to help prepare meals for thousands of devotees in a short span of time.

Sudhir Rastogi, a member of the organising team at the Modipuram camp, said that special fasting-friendly meals (*falahar*) have been arranged for Kanwariyas who are fasting. Dishes made from buckwheat (*kuttu*) and water chestnut (*singhara*) flour, potato curry, seasonal fruits, and other fasting-appropriate foods are being provided.

After their long journey, devotees are also served hot *kesar doodh* (saffron-infused milk) in traditional *kulhads* (clay cups) to help them replenish their energy.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



Lakshmi Yojana receives 5.14 lakh registrations in 7 days: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Lakshmi Yojana has received over 5.14 lakh registrations within seven days of its launch, with more than 2.18 lakh applications finally submitted so far. The scheme, launched on August 1, provides financial assistance of ₹2,500 per month to eligible women, according to the Delhi Government.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta described the response to the scheme as unprecedented, saying the number of registrations reflected the women's trust in the initiative

to provide financial support and promote savings.

As of Saturday afternoon, 5,14,460 women had registered under the scheme, while 2,18,728 applications had been finally submitted, according to data shared by the Chief Minister's Office.

Of the total registrations, 4,36,316 beneficiaries had entered their district or assembly constituency details, while 78,144 were yet to provide these details, the statement said.

The North-East district has recorded the highest number of registrations, with 73,676 registered users having

entered their district details, of whom 38,579 applications have been finally submitted.

This is followed by the North-West district, where 34,545 out of 55,700 registered users have finally submitted their applications; the West district, where 18,967 out of 44,358 have done so; the South-West district, where 23,994 out of 44,149 have finally submitted their applications; the Outer North district, where 23,694 out of 39,401 have done so; the South-East district, where 18,725 out of 38,979 have finally submitted their applications; the North district,



where 16,074 out of 37,263 have done so; the East district, where 14,771 out of 30,621 have finally submitted their applications; the South district, where 11,000 out of

26,316 have done so; the Central-North district, where 6,332 out of 14,279 have finally submitted their applications; the Central district, where 4,208 out of 13,715 have done so; the Old Delhi district, where 6,038 out of 12,286 have finally submitted their applications; and the New Delhi district, where 1,801 out of 5,573 have finally submitted their applications.

The Government said the verification of applications is underway and added that it aimed to release the first instalment to eligible beneficiaries on Raksha Bandhan.

Under the scheme, benefi-

ciaries can choose between two options — ₹1,000 to be made available through a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) wallet for daily expenses and the remaining ₹1,500 deposited in an RD/FD, or the entire ₹2,500 being deposited in an RD/FD.

The statement said the application, document verification, eligibility assessment, approval, PFMS integration, banking and payment processes were being carried out digitally.

Each application undergoes a four-level scrutiny and approval process to ensure that the benefits

reach eligible beneficiaries, it said. The Chief Minister said the scheme was aimed not only at providing financial assistance but also at encouraging savings, digital financial inclusion and greater financial security among women.

According to the statement, the Chief Minister has appealed to all eligible women who have not yet applied to visit the official Delhi Lakshmi Yojana portal www.dly.delhi.gov.in and apply online to avail themselves of the benefits of this historic initiative of the Delhi Government.

NDMC to take over maintenance of Central Vista roads

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) will now take over the maintenance of major roads in the Central Vista area, including Janpath, Rafi Marg and Man Singh Road, from the Central Public Works Department (CPWD), according to officials.

An order issued by the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry on August 7 said the NDMC would be responsible for the upkeep, resurfacing, cleaning and other municipal works on the roads, while Kartavya



Path would continue to be maintained by the CPWD.

The move changes an arrangement that had been in place since March 2007, when the maintenance of roads in the Central Vista area was transferred from the NDMC to the CPWD through a 2006 min-

istry order, officials said.

According to officials, the move marks a shift towards a more localised system of civic management in Lutyens' Delhi, with the council taking over the upkeep of roads in the Central Vista area from the CPWD, except Kartavya Path.

"The arrangement will bring road maintenance, cleaning, sweeping and other civic works under the NDMC, which already manages utilities, drainage and street lighting in the area. The CPWD will continue to be responsible for the ceremonial stretch of Kartavya Path," an official said.

The handover will bring the maintenance of the prominent stretches back under the civic body's existing road network in Lutyens' Delhi.

The NDMC currently manages about 1,280 km of roads, along with 372 km of footpaths, 52 major rotaries, 16 subways, three underpasses and two flyovers, according to official civic data.

With the addition of the Central Vista stretches, road repairs and routine upkeep of the key avenues will now be handled through the NDMC's road maintenance system, officials added.

Delhi FSL cuts case pendency by 72%: Sood

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) has reduced its case pendency by 72 per cent over the past year, with the pending cases falling from 27,585 in June last year to 7,178 as of July 31, 2026, Home Minister Ashish Sood said on Saturday.

Sood, while inspecting the laboratory, its infrastructure, forensic investigation facilities and functioning, said timely forensic examination was important for reducing delays in trials and ensuring speedy justice.

According to a statement, the laboratory disposed of 3,49,519 exhibits over the last 12 months and has been examining and disposing of more than 3,000 cases every month since November 2025.

The minister said the laboratory had taken several measures to improve its capacity, including strengthening its manpower, mod-



ernising scientific equipment and streamlining workflows.

In 2025, the laboratory recruited 247 scientific personnel on a contractual basis to strengthen examination and reporting of cases.

The FSL has engaged 90 M.Sc-qualified interns for investigation and crime-scene-related work, the statement said, adding that six mobile forensic vans have also been procured and made operational for its teams across different ranges.

Sood said forensic experts had been deployed across all six ranges and 15 districts of the Delhi Police in accordance with the provisions of the new criminal laws to provide scientific assistance at crime scenes.

The laboratory has also introduced e-reporting through the e-Forensic 2.0 (Integrated Criminal Justice System) portal. Twenty-five video-conferencing facilities are operational for recording evidence before courts, according to the statement. The FSL has also implemented iGOT Karmayogi, an online learning platform for government employees, the minister said.

He added the laboratory's National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories (NABL) accreditation has been extended for four years, while its International Laboratory Accreditation Cooperation-Mutual Recognition Arrangement (ILAC-MRA) recognition has been extended for one year.

LG Sandhu seeks market traders' feedback on encroachments, traffic, parking issues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has sought feedback from representatives of major markets on issues including unauthorised encroachments, traffic congestion and parking management, while stressing the need to keep commercial hubs accessible and orderly.

Sandhu interacted with representatives of market and traders' associations from several prominent markets, including Sarojini Nagar, Lajpat Nagar, Connaught Place, Mori Gate and Chandni Chowk,



where issues affecting traders, shoppers and daily business were discussed.

During the meeting, the lieutenant governor also sought first-hand feedback on the effectiveness of 'Jan Sunwai' being

conducted by the Delhi Police at police stations across the city.

He said direct interaction with traders and residents was important to assess whether public grievances relating to safety, traffic, encroachments

and other local issues were being addressed promptly.

The meeting brought together trade leaders and commercial representatives to deliberate on long-term, actionable solutions to ground-level bottlenecks, including unauthorised encroachments, persistent traffic snarls, chaotic parking management, and the functioning of public grievance mechanisms.

The representatives raised concerns regarding encroachments, traffic snarls and parking arrangements in busy commercial areas, according to a statement issued by the lieutenant governor's office.

DAMB registers over 95 encroachment cases at Azadpur Mandi, collects ₹20,900 in fines

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Agricultural Marketing Board (DAMB) has registered over 95 encroachment cases and collected fines totalling more than ₹20,900 from Azadpur Mandi during its anti-encroachment drive from the last week of July to the first week of August.

The encroachment drive aims to streamline commercial activity, improve traffic flow and minimise public inconvenience. Besides, in coordination with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, around 75-80 stray animals were removed from market premises and transferred to *gaushalas*.

In a press statement, the APMC said illegal structures, temporary shops, and



unauthorised street vendors were removed on a large scale from the prominent markets in the national Capital. It said that from Ghazipur markets including the FMC and Fish & Poultry Market-more than 4,100 sq ft of pavements, entry routes and parking spaces have been cleared.

Authorities confiscated numerous illegal wooden planks, iron boxes, tables, umbrellas and freezers and imposed fines on dozens of violators during consecutive days of action. At Okhla Mandi, enforcement teams issued special challans to halt unauthorised trade and maintain road cleanliness. Approximately 140 kg of illicitly sold fruits and vegetables, including potatoes, pumpkins, bananas, bottle gourds and cucumbers, were seized, and ₹18,700 recovered in fines.

In APMC Shahdara, temporary shops and street carts operating within the mandiyard were removed. Officials seized about 215 kg of assorted produce — such as garlic, green chillies, pointed gourd, taro

root, brinjal and mangoes — along with 11 illegal weighing scales. License holders and mashakhors found violating rules were sternly warned; authorities said persistent offenders could face legal action, including licence cancellation.

At Keshpur APMC, the path blocking the main exit and entry gates (Exit to Entry Gate) was cleared by removing more than 25 illegal street carts and temporary stalls. On the other hand, regular monitoring was maintained at APMC Najafgarh and APMC Narela, where no new encroachment was found this week, and the situation in Narela remained completely under control.

DAMB officials said the drive will continue as needed to ensure orderly market operations and reduce congestion in the national capital's wholesale produce hubs.

CHANDRA PRABHU INTERNATIONAL LIMITED

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INFORMATION REGARDING DISPATCH OF NOTICE OF 41st ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, CUT-OFF DATE, AND REMOTE E-VOTING etc.

In continuation to our newspaper advertisement on 5th August, 2026, Notice is hereby given that (41st) Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of Chandra Prabhu International Limited, scheduled to be held on **Monday, August 31, 2026 at 11:30 AM (IST)** via Video Conferencing ("VVC") / Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM"), in compliance with provisions of the Companies Act, 2013, rules framed thereunder, SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, read with Circular(s) issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs or SEBI in this regard, to transact the Ordinary and Special Business as set out in the Notice of 41st AGM without the physical presence of the members at a common venue. The venue of the AGM shall be deemed to be Registered Office of the Company.

Notice of 41st AGM and the Annual Report of the Company for the financial year 2025-26, have been sent on Friday, 7th August, 2026, through electronic mode to the members of the Company who are holding shares as on Friday, 31st July, 2026 and whose email addresses are registered with the Company Depository Participant(s). Additionally, a letter providing the web-link, including the exact path of the Notice of 41st AGM and Annual Report being sent to those members whose email address is not registered with the Company/DP. Further, hard copies of the Annual Report will be provided to those members who request for the same at cs@cpil.com.

Members holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialized form, as on the cut-off date for e-voting i.e. Monday, 24th August, 2026, may cast their vote electronically through electronic voting system ("Remote e-voting") provided by National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL"). All members informed that:-

- i. The remote e-voting shall commence on Thursday, August 27, 2026 at 9:00 am IST.
- ii. The remote e-voting shall end on Sunday, August 30, 2026 at 5:00 pm IST.
- iii. The cut-off date for determining the eligibility to vote by electronic means or at the AGM is August 24, 2026.
- iv. Any person, who acquires shares of the Company and become member of the Company after dispatch of the Notice of AGM and holding shares as of cut-off date i.e. August 24, 2026, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.com. However, if a person is already registered with NSDL for e-voting then existing user ID and password can be used for casting vote. A person who is not a Member as on the Cut-off date should treat the Notice of AGM for information purpose only.
- v. Members may note that: a) the remote e-voting module shall be disabled by NSDL after the aforesaid date and time for voting and once the vote on a resolution is cast by the member, the member shall not be allowed to change it subsequently; b) the facility of e-voting system shall also be made available during the AGM; c) the members who have cast their vote by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again in the AGM; and d) a person whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date only shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting before/ during the AGM.
- vi. Members who have not registered their e-mail address/Bank account are requested to register the same in respect of the shares held in electronic form with the Depository through their Depository participant(s) and in respect of shares held in physical form by writing to the Company's RTA i.e. M/s Alankit Assignments Limited, 4E/2 Jhandewalan Extension New Delhi-110055 at rta@alankit.com and;
- vii. In case of any queries, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") for Shareholders and e-voting user manual for Shareholder available at the Downloads section of <https://www.evoting@nsdl.com> or contact NSDL by email at evoting@nsdl.com in case of any clarification(s)/grievance(s) connected with the electronic voting, you may contact Ms. Pallavi Mhatre, Manager, NSDL at the designated email Ids: evoting@nsdl.com or pallavi@nsdl.com or at following Telephone Nos.-022-4886 7000. Member who require any technical assistance before/ during the AGM to access and participate in the meeting may contact Ms. Pallavi Mhatre, Manager, NSDL at pallavi@nsdl.com or at following Telephone Nos.-022-4886 7000

Further the board of Directors of the Company has appointed Mr. Krishna Kumar Singh proprietor of M/s KKS & Associates, Company Secretaries for scrutinizing the remote e-voting process as well as voting during the AGM in fair and Transparent Manner. The result of remote e-voting and voting during the AGM shall be declared not later than 2 working days from the conclusion of the AGM. The declared results along with Scrutinizer's Report shall be place on the website of the Company at www.cpil.com and also the website of the Bombay Stock Exchange on which the shares of the Company are listed i.e. www.bseindia.com

Those Members who have not yet registered their email addresses are requested to get their email addresses registered by following the procedure given below:-

- (a) For Members holding shares in physical form, please send scan copy of a signed request letter in form ISR-1 mentioning your folio number, name of shareholder, copy of share certificate (front and back), complete address, email address to be registered along with scanned self-attested copy of the PAN, to M/s Alankit Assignments Limited, 4E/2 Jhandewalan Extension New Delhi-110055 at rta@alankit.com.
- (b) For the Members holding shares in demat form, please update your email address through your respective Depository Participant(s).

Members are requested to carefully read all the Notes set out in the Notice of the 41st AGM and in particular, instructions for joining AGM, manner of casting vote through remote e-voting or voting at the AGM.

By order of the Board
Chandra Prabhu International Limited
Sd/-
(Gajraj Jain)
Chairman Cum Managing Director (DIN- 00049199)

PARIJAT PAPER MILLS LIMITED

CIN: L21012UP1989PLC010589
Reg. Off: 10.6 Km Stone Bhopa Road, Vill-Jat Mujhera, Muzaffarnagar - 251308, (U.P)
Website: www.parijatpapermills.com, Email: parijatpapermills@yahoo.com

STATEMENT OF STANDALONE UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026 (Rs. in Lacs except EPS)

Sr. No.	PARTICULARS	Quarter Ended	Year Ended	
		30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
1.	Total income from operation (Net)	3117.79	3262.75	12738.20
2.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extra ordinary items)	8.93	(56.74)	211.38
3.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	8.93	(56.74)	211.38
4.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	7.44	(56.74)	70.81
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)]	7.44	(56.74)	70.81
6.	Paid-up Equity share capital (Face value Rs. 10/- each)	329.00	329.00	329
7.	[Other Equity (Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserves)	1147.70	1072.29	1140.26
8.	Earnings per share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)	0.23	(1.72)	2.15
	a) Basic b) Diluted			

Notes:

1. The above results were reviewed by an Audit Committee and thereafter taken on record by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on 07.08.2026. An unmodified opinion has been issued and the same is filed with the stock exchange with the above results.
2. The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly & year to date financial results filed with the stock exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarterly & year to date financial results are available on the Stock Exchange website (www.mseil.in) and the company's website (www.parijatpapermills.com).

Date: 07.08.2026
Place: Muzaffarnagar

For and on behalf of Parijat Paper Mills Limited
Sd/-
Amit Mittal
Whole Time Director
DIN:00754471

दि बाज़पुर को-आपरेटिव शुगर फेक्ट्री लि०, बाज़पुर, जिला-ऊधमसिंह नगर (उत्तराखण्ड)

ई-निविदा सूचना दिनांक: 08.08.2026

पेरार्ड सत्र 2026-27 हेतु विभिन्न सामग्री की आपूर्ति एवं कार्या हेतु उत्तराखण्ड अधिग्रहण (प्रीक्वैलिफिकेशन) निष्पत्ति-2025 में निविदा प्रक्रियाओं के अन्तर्गत निविदा प्रणाली (Two Bid System) के अन्तर्गत www.uktdenders.gov.in पर ई-निविदाये आमंत्रित की जाती है। www.uktdenders.gov.in पर प्राप्त निविदा ही मान्य होगी, अन्य माध्यम से प्राप्त निविदा स्वीकार्य नहीं होगी। आवश्यकता होने पर L-1 (न्यूनतम) दरवाला से मेनोशोरिशन किया जायेगा। L-1 से दरी के सम्बन्ध में सहमति न होने पर अन्य निविदाकारों से वार्ता की जा सकती है। विस्तृत निविदा सूचना मिले की अवसर पर www.bazpursugar.com तथा विस्तृत निविदा सूचना एवं निविदा प्राप्त www.uktdenders.gov.in से डाउनलोड की जायेगी। निविदा में किसी भी प्रकार से संशोधन की दस्ता में संशोधन का प्रकाशन केवल www.uktdenders.gov.in पर www.bazpursugar.com के माध्यम से ही प्रकाशित किया जायेगा। प्रधान प्रबंधक

STATE BANK OF INDIA, Home Loan Centre, First Floor, Main Branch Building, Neelam Chowk, NIT, Faridabad-121001.

PUBLIC NOTICE

STATE BANK OF INDIA, Home Loan Centre, First Floor, Main Branch Building, Neelam Chowk, NIT, Faridabad-121001, hereby declares that the **Original BBA dated 13.03.2011 and the Receipt pertaining to Plot No. GH-05, Tech Zone-IV, Unit F6-1107, 11th Floor, Amrapali Centurian Park Pvt. Ltd., Greater Noida, G.B. Nagar (U.P.), deposited under SBI HL A/c. No.62289364405 in the names of Mr. Sougat Mitra and Smt. Moomita Mitra Sinha**, have been lost/misplaced during transit while shifting the documents from SBI RACBP Branch, Sector-16, Faridabad to SBI Home Loan Centre, First Floor, Main Branch Building, Neelam Chowk, NIT, Faridabad-121001 on or around 25.01.2024 at about 11:00 A.M.

The person who finds the above-mentioned documents is requested to contact the above-mentioned branch immediately.

Dated: 08/08/2026 **Place: Faridabad** **Home Loan Centre, First Floor, Neelam Chowk, NIT, Faridabad**

(Chief Manager, State Bank of India)
Mob No. 7011712950
Off. At: N-1/B, Jungpura Extension, New Delhi-14

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public that Smt. Sunder Devi W/o. Santil Kumar is the absolute owner and in peaceful possession of the property bearing Property/Plot No. 135, Sector-2, Phase-I, Industrial Estate Growth Centre, HSIDC IMT Bawal, District Rewari, Haryana 122501 ("Said Property"). The title of the said Property is derived through various title and ownership documents, including some previous chain i.e. Original Allotment Letter (RAL) dated 28.01.2002 and Original Conveyance Deed executed by Haryana State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd. in favour of Sh. Pawan Kumar Sharma, Vaska No. 437, dated 06.07.2009, and Original Sale Deed executed by Shri Pawan Kumar Sharma in favour of Shri Sukbir Singh, Vaska No. 445, dated 06.07.2009. It is hereby notified that the aforesaid original are stated to have been lost/misplaced. Certified/photocopies of the aforesaid documents are available and form part of the title records. The loss/non-availability of the aforesaid original documents is being publicly notified so as to invite objections, if any, from any person having any right, title, interest or claim in respect thereof. Any person, bank, financial institution, company, authority or entity having any knowledge of the original aforesaid documents or having any claim, right, title, interest, charge, lien, mortgage, lease, license, tenancy, attachment, litigation, etc. proceedings or any other objection whatsoever in respect of the said Property or the aforesaid title documents is hereby called upon to intimate the undersigned in writing, in support of such claim, within 15 (Fifteen) days from the date of publication of this notice. In case no objection or claim is received within the aforesaid period, it shall be presumed that no person has any objection, claim or interest in respect of the said Property and the aforesaid documents. Any objection or claim shall not be entertained and the objector shall be deemed to have waived any right or claim, if any, in respect of the said Property and/or the aforesaid documents.

NAVNEET TRIPATHI ADVOCATE
Mob No. 7011712950
Off. At: N-1/B, Jungpura Extension, New Delhi-14

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client is, Sarawat Co-op Bank Ltd. that Mrs. Subhashini Nijawan is claiming to be the owner of Entire Property No. A-33, area measuring 234 Sq. Yds. Situated at Shanker Garden, New Delhi vide Release Deed Dt. 19.12.1999 (Doc. No.10628) executed by Mrs. Pushpa Rani in favour of Mrs. Subhashini Nijawan in respect of other Half Undivided share in the said property it has been informed to us by our client that Owner has sent Original Release Deed dt. 19.12.1999 (doc. No.10628) & it is not traceable. All persons are hereby informed that above mentioned owner (through Mr. Vishal Nijawan) wants to mortgage the said property and intends to obtain loan from our client (ie. Sarawat Co-op Bank Ltd) against the said property if any body has any objections upon the ownership of above owner over the said property its sale mortgage/ Cligation & any other objections kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present, **Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)** 200, Indira Flr. 23, Shivaji Marg, Mohi Nagar, N. Delhi-15 Regd.Indira@kumar.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

"Be it informed to the General Public at large that my client Sh. Chander Bhan, S/O Late Sh. Ram Rikh Singh R/o Plot No. 74, First Floor Block B, Bhagwati Garden Extension Uttam Nagar New Delhi 110059, have severed all their relations with his son Tarun Kumar daughter-in-law Simran and their Grandson Priyush and also debar and disown all from his all movable and immovable properties due to their disobedient, rude and quarrelsome nature. Any person dealing with them will be doing so as his/her own risk and responsibilities. My client shall not be responsible in any manner."

JOGINDER SINGH SEHWAT (ADVOCATE)
Ch. No. 1403, 14th Floor, Rohini Courts, New Delhi-110085

GOVERNMENT OF MANIPUR

EDUCATION ENGINEERING WING, EDUCATION (S) DEPARTMENT, MANIPUR
Babupara, Near D.C. Office (Old), Imphal West

NOTICE INVITING OPEN TENDERS

No. EE-E/EW/T-33/Open/T-2026-27/02: The Executive Engineer, Div. No. 1, Education Engineering Wing on behalf of the Governor of Manipur invites item rate tender in single cover/bid through open tender from approved and eligible contractors holding Civil registration (appropriate class) and Electrical registration (valid licence) under any Government Engineering Department of Manipur State for 3 (three) numbers work under the scheme of PM-USA in Senapati District. The tender details and documents shall be available from 10.08.2026 to 18.08.2026 at the office of the undersigned during office hours.

IMPORTANT DATES:
Bid submission latest date: 10.08.2026.
Bid submission end date & time: 18.08.2026 up to 1:00 P.M.
Date and time of bid opening: 18.08.2026 at 2:00 P.M.

VENUE: Office of the Executive Engineer, Div. No. 1, Education Engineering Wing, Education (S) Department, Manipur.
Sd/-
Executive Engineer, Div-1, EEW, Edn (S) Dept, Manipur

PUBLIC NOTICE

A notice of intended marriage has been received from Mr. Rohit Babu S/O Mr. Babu Koshy R/o Flat No-G-0001, Homes-121, Tower-G, Plot No.-GH-01, Sector-121, Noida, Gautambudh Nagar, (U.P.) and Ms. Tamarapalli Vanshshikha Sharma D/o Mr. Tamarapalli Venket Ravi Sharma R/o B-1201, Rajnagar, Residential, Rajnagar Extension, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201017 in the office of The undersigned, any person interested Therein, may file objections to it on any day upto 02-09-2026 in The office of The undersigned.

Deputy Collector/ i/c City Magistrate, Marriage Officer Noida

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to all that my clients Smt. Jyoti Bala Munjal W/o Sh. Mahesh Munjal & her husband Sh. Mahesh Kumar Munjal S/o Sh. Narayan Das both R/o C-12, Third Floor, Street No.2, Chander Nagar, Laxman Park, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051 presently residing at L-20 (MPL, No.886) Kedar Building, Subzi Mandi, Delhi-110087 have disowned & severed their relation with their son Sh. Khushal Munjal (UID: 8837-7229-9128). My clients have also debarred him from their all movable & immovable properties & if any body dealing with him, then they shall be solely responsible & my clients shall not be held responsible for his acts, deeds and things whatsoever.

SANJAY AGGARWAL (Advocate)
Ch.No.25, Old Court, Kashmere Gate, Delhi-6

COURT NOTICE

Notice In The Consideration of Justice Rajan Gupta
Chairman Haryana Real Estate Appellate Tribunal
Rakesh Manocha Member (Technical)

Archana Goel, Ram Sharan, Manju, Sardar Parminder Singh, Sudesh Sharma Vs.
TDI Infrastructure Ltdt. HREAT (Chandigarh) Appeal Nos. 176 to 180 of 2025 respectively

vide order dated **21.07.2025**, notice was issued upon the respondent TDI Infrastructure to appear on the next date of hearing. Please take note that the above cases are now listed on **10.08.2026**.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Sonali Sharma alias Seema Singh D/o Rameshwar Choudhary W/O Vivek Kumar R/o 235/236, Ground Floor, Pocket-7, Sector-24, Rohini, North West Delhi, Delhi-110085, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as **Seema Singh**.

I, Khaing Za Maung S/O Zake R/O A-1/16, Chanakya Place Part-1, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi-110059, have changed the name of my minor Son Van Bawi aged 16 Years and he shall hereafter be known as **Va By Hna**.

LOST & FOUND

I, Shalini Chaudhry W/o Rahul Chaudhry, R/o 21/404, Heritage City, MG Road, Sec-25, DLF-II, Gurugram, Haryana, have lost/misplaced my original Allotment Letter of issued by Uniworl Resorts in Sector 33 and Sector 48, Gurgaon, Haryana. I have also lodged an FIR vide LR No. 0505/2026 dated 07/08/2026. The finder is requested to kindly contact me at the same address.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that Late Ms. Neha Gupta, D/o Late Sh. Girish Babu Gupta, expired on 29 January 2026. Her surviving family members are Mrs. Kamlesh Gupta (Mother), aged 75 years, and Mr. Anshul Gupta (Brother), aged 49 years, both residing at 560, Gali Loohan, Kucha Pati Ram, Bazar Siy, Ram, G.P.O. North Delhi-110066. Any person having any claim or objection in respect of the assets/affairs of Late Ms. Neha Gupta may intimate the same with supporting documents within 30 days of publication of this notice. Sd/ Mrs. Kamlesh Gupta/Mr. Anshul Gupta

DU college student dies by suicide in Rajouri Garden area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 19-year-old college student reportedly died by suicide near a shopping mall in the Rajouri Garden area of West Delhi on Saturday, according to police sources.

The incident was discovered when a head constable on routine patrol observed the young woman's body near the Mall of Rajouri, close to the Rajouri Garden Pink Line Metro station.

The information was promptly reported to the Rajouri Garden police station. A police team arrived at the scene, where they conducted a preliminary inspection in the presence of the crime scene investigation team and forensic scientists. During the investigation, the deceased's family reported that she had been experiencing depression following the death of her mother in 2021. Relatives indicated that this loss had significantly affected her mental health.

A handwritten note was recovered from the scene in



which the individual expressed her intention to take her own life voluntarily.

Authorities confirmed that no evidence indicating foul play was found during the investigation of the location. The deceased has been identified as a third-year Bachelor of Arts student at Aryabhata College in Delhi. Senior police officials announced that proceedings under Section 194 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) have been initiated, and further legal actions and investigations are ongoing.

The family has been notified and is cooperating with authorities. The body was transferred for post-mortem

examination as part of standard procedure. Statements from family members and others who had recent contact with the student are being collected to elucidate the circumstances surrounding the incident.

Police officials emphasised that the recovery of the note and the absence of signs of external interference at this preliminary stage support the investigative team in concluding that the incident was self-inflicted.

Mental health experts note that the loss of a parent, particularly a mother, during late adolescence or early adulthood can lead to prolonged or complex grief,

which significantly increases the risk of clinical depression.

Dr Rajesh Kumar, a psychiatrist specialising in bereavement at a prominent Delhi hospital, explained that unresolved grief often interacts with identity development and academic pressures typical of college students.

"When a primary caregiver is lost, young adults may experience persistent longing, emotional numbness, or difficulty finding meaning, which can develop into major depressive episodes if unaddressed," he stated. Research consistently demonstrates that parental loss before age 25 correlates with higher incidences of long-term mental health issues, including anxiety and depression, underscoring the importance of sustained support beyond brief counselling. Counsellors emphasise the importance of early intervention through university mental health services, peer support networks, and family involvement to facilitate constructive processing of such losses.

Four days of rain leave Delhi with wettest August day in two years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Marking a four-day streak of showers, the national Capital on Saturday recorded its wettest August day in two years, with the month's rainfall total nearly reaching the monthly average in just the first eight days.

With 98.7 mm of rain till 8.30 am, Delhi marked the highest rainfall in the month of August since 2024, when 107.6 mm of rain was recorded on the first day of the month. Notably, despite the rain, the real feel temperature or heat index is above 44 degree Celsius, as soaring humidity combined with above-normal temperatures made outdoor conditions extremely uncomfortable. The record took Safdarjung's cumulative rainfall for August to 225.7 mm till 8.30 am on Saturday, just a few



People cover themselves amid rainfall in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

mm short of the month's long-period average of 233.1 mm.

Traffic snarls were reported at several stretches across the national capital amid incessant rain, with heavy congestion at the Kalindi Kunj border, ITO, Press Enclave Marg, Geetanjali Marg and Mehrauli-Badarpur Road.

Traffic was also affected in parts of east Delhi, including stretches of GT Road.

Meanwhile, several weather stations recorded light to moderate rain on Saturday.

Safdarjung recorded 16.6 mm of rain between 11.30 pm on Friday and 2.30 am on Saturday, and 1.6 mm of rain

in the subsequent three hours.

The station recorded a total of 4.4 mm of rain between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm.

Pushp Vihar recorded 165 mm of rain in 24 hours till 8.30 am on Saturday; 38.5 mm of rain between 8.30 am and 11.30 am; 18.5 mm of rain till 2.30 pm and 8.5 mm of rain in the subsequent three hours.

During the first eight days of the month, Safdarjung recorded 188.4 mm of rain against a normal of around 60 mm, making it 214 per cent above normal. Palam recorded 155.4 mm against a normal of 57.9 mm for the eight-day period, making it 168 per cent above normal. Lodhi Road received 198.5 mm against a normal of 60 mm, 231 per cent above normal.

The Ridge logged 184.4 mm as opposed to the normal of 56.7 mm, bringing it to 225 per cent above normal, while Aya Nagar received 239.3 mm

Narela: Elderly woman dies in Mercedes-WagonR crash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 70-year-old woman lost her life in a road accident in Delhi's Narela area on Saturday morning. A speeding Mercedes crashed head-on into a WagonR outside Himalaya Apartments in Mamurpur. The victim, Urmila, who was the wife of Satyanarayan and lived in Mamurpur, was on her usual morning walk when she became trapped between the cars and died at the scene.

The accident happened at about 8 am. Police say that Shubham, the son of a Haryana Police sub-inspector, was driving the Mercedes when it hit the WagonR with great force. The impact pushed the WagonR backwards into a parked three-wheeler loading van. Urmila was caught between the vehicles and suffered fatal injuries. The WagonR driver had only minor injuries and was treated at the scene.

Eyewitnesses alleged that Shubham was speeding and may have been drunk. Police found a beer bottle inside the Mercedes and arrested him at the scene. The car did not belong to Shubham; he had borrowed it from a friend the



day before. He was taken for a medical test, and police are waiting for the results to confirm if he was intoxicated.

A case of causing death by negligence has been filed, and Urmila's body was sent for post-mortem. Police are still investigating, checking CCTV footage and talking to witnesses. She left her family devastated. As the wife of Satyanarayan and a long-time resident of the Mamurpur locality, she was known in the neighbourhood for her daily morning walks.

Family members are in deep mourning following the unexpected loss of the older woman who had stepped out for her usual stroll.

Relatives gathered as news of the accident spread, grappling with the shock of the fatal outcome of what began as an ordinary Saturday

morning. People nearby heard the loud crash and rushed to the scene. They described seeing damaged cars and the woman trapped between them.

One resident said they heard a sudden bang and saw the wrecked vehicles with the woman caught in between, which led them to call the police right away.

The area outside Himalaya Apartments, where many people walk and commute, was briefly closed off while emergency teams worked.

Police said they will look into all details, such as how fast the Mercedes was going, whether alcohol was involved, and exactly how Urmila became trapped. The second crash with the parked loading van made the first collision even worse. There was no large crowd at the scene,

and police kept things orderly while they gathered evidence. This incident has once again highlighted concerns over road safety in Delhi's outer areas, particularly involving high-speed driving and drunk driving.

People in Narela are mourning the loss of someone they knew well and are asking for stricter action against reckless driving in their neighbourhoods.

Shubham is still in custody while police wait for the medical report and check the vehicles. The Mercedes was badly damaged at the front, showing it was a high-speed crash. To mourn privately while awaiting the formal completion of post-mortem procedures and further updates from investigators.

The death of the 70-year-old woman on her morning walk underscores the human cost of such collisions. As the probe continues, the focus remains on establishing accountability and providing a full account of the events that unfolded outside Himalaya Apartments in Mamurpur on Saturday. Police officials said the investigation was ongoing and more sections could be added to the FIR.

Faridabad records 120 mm rainfall in 24 hours; traffic, daily life hit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Faridabad

More than 50 places in Faridabad were waterlogged on Saturday as relentless rain over the past 24 hours caused massive traffic jams and widespread disruption to daily life, while a large section of a culvert on Surajkund Road, between Sidhdhata Ashram and MVN Road, caved in.

According to the district administration, Faridabad received 120 mm rainfall from Friday 8 am till Saturday 8 am, exceeding initial estimates.

From 8 am to 5 pm on Saturday, light to moderate rainfall was recorded at several locations across the Faridabad district.

Dayalpur recorded the



highest rainfall at 21 mm, while Mohna and Gaunchi received 15 mm each. Ballabgarh recorded 10 mm of rainfall, while Badkhal recorded 6 mm of rainfall.

On Friday, a school bus and a Fortuner car got stuck in deep water at the Old Faridabad railway underpass. Fortunately, no children were on board the bus,

and the driver and staff climbed onto the roof to save themselves, while a 60-year-old man was stuck inside the car. Upon receiving information, police immediately rushed to their rescue. Friday's rain was so intense that water entered homes in Dayal Bagh, Sector 16, Sector 14, Vinay Nagar, and Old Faridabad areas.

Delhi Government invites public comments for Bihar bus proposal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Moving ahead with its plan to start special long-route buses to Bihar before the Chhath this year, the Delhi government on Saturday released the draft agreement for public comments before finalising it. The initiative was announced by Transport Minister Pankaj Singh some time ago.

The project is part of the next phase of the rollout of the inter-state buses, with Delhi and Bihar set to sign a Reciprocal Transport Agreement. The public has time till September 5 to submit suggestions.

"We have a target to launch these buses before the Chhath this year; these will be AC luxury buses, and initially, we plan to roll out around 50-plus buses to seven locations in Bihar. The buses will not (be) limited to just the festival



but will operate round-the-year," Singh said.

According to the proposal, the buses will connect the national capital with Patna, Gaya, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Buxar, Purnia, Kishanganj, Madhubani, Champaran, Biharsharif and Bhagalpur in Bihar.

All buses would traverse Uttar Pradesh in Noida, Lucknow, Mathura, Azamgarh and other areas before entering Bihar, travelling a distance of nearly 1,000 kilometres.

"Buses shall originate and terminate at designated bus terminals to be allocated by the concerned parties.

The timetable for stage carriages plying on the routes shall be fixed after mutual consultation," the draft proposal states.

The agreement between Delhi and Bihar is likely to be signed in September, soon after which the services will commence and depending on the response, the number of buses could also be increased.

According to officials, Volvo buses would ply on these longer routes.

"The long-route buses will be 12 metres long, air-conditioned, and equipped with luggage space. It is not feasible to ply electric buses to far-off locations because of the lack of charging infrastructure.

"We plan to take buses on a wet-lease model, wherein a concessionaire will come on board and operate the buses for us. These will be BS-VI compliant buses," an official said.

Govt's proposed drone policy aims to create over 1,000 jobs: Pankaj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi IT minister Pankaj Singh said on Saturday that the Delhi Government's proposed drone policy aims to create over 1,000 jobs in the city.

The policy, currently under development, will emphasise establishing drone research clusters, dedicated flight testing facilities, utilising drones for traffic manage-



ment, and providing subsidies to enhance the drone ecosystem.

"A comprehensive drone policy is being planned to ensure safe and regulated drone operations, along with job opportunities. The policy is ready; we plan to table it for cabinet approval in a month," Singh said.

The policy is being developed by the government's information and technology (IT) department.

According to officials, the policy's key objectives include

regulating drone usage to prevent misuse, enabling government agencies to use drones for surveillance and mapping, and strengthening integration with the DGCA's Digital Sky platform.

The government plans to allocate a separate budget for implementing the scheme and creating the necessary supporting infrastructure.

"The policy is focused around five focus areas,

including public awareness and enforcement under these events, outreach, zoning signage, sensitisation workshops, safety framework and counter-drone standard operating procedures will be worked out," an official said.

Earlier this year, the Government set up a committee under the chairmanship of the IT department secretary to examine the feasibility of the Delhi drone policy.

Interstate drug syndicate operating in NCR busted, five held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has arrested five alleged drug traffickers, including three foreigners, and claimed to have busted an interstate syndicate operating in the Delhi-NCR region, recovering heroin and MDMA worth around ₹12 crore, an officer said on Saturday.

The accused have been identified as Nigerian nation-

als Moris Okalie (52) and Ibegbu Chigozie Samuel (50), Ghanaian national Emmanuel (38), and Delhi residents Sameer (28) and a woman identified as Lady (36), police said.

The Crime Branch said the team was developing intelligence on drug traffickers when it received specific information that Okalie, allegedly involved in wholesale and retail trafficking of heroin and MDMA, would



arrive near a hospital in Shahdara during the intervening night of July 19 and 20 to deliver a drug consign-

Sadar Bazar decks up in tricolour as Delhi's flag-making legacy gears up for Independence Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

There is barely enough room to walk. Rolls of cloth lean against walls, sewing machines hum without pause and freshly stitched tricolours are packed into bundles, ready for dispatch across the country. At the centre of it all is Bharat Handloom Cloth House, one of Delhi's oldest flag-making shops in Sadar Bazar.

Here, a family that has been making the national flag for generations is working through a rush ahead of the 80th Independence Day.

Established in 1962, the year of the India-China war, this tiny shop has supplied

flags to Government officials, households and institutions through some of the country's defining moments, including the war. The family's association with flag-making, however, goes back even further, to Ghaffar's grandfather and father, who made flags during the freedom movement.

Abdul Ghaffar later carried that legacy forward, spending more than six decades making flags. Fondly known as the "Flag Uncle" after Prime Minister Narendra Modi mentioned him during the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign, Ghaffar died on December 29, 2025, at the age of 81. Today, his younger brother Abdul Malik and the

family's third generation continue the work from the same shop. For Malik, the business is less a trade than a family legacy which has passed through generations.

"My father and grandfather made flags during the freedom movement. It was their small contribution to the country. Khadi cloth used to come from Bengal then, and they would prepare the flags here. After Independence, the work continued and in 1962, our family established Bharat Handloom Cloth House here in Sadar Bazar," Malik said.

"That was also the time of the China war. We sold flags to government officials and households when there was a need for patriotism. Since



then, we have seen the demand for the tricolour rise whenever the country has gone through an important moment," he said.

Malik said his elder brother Ghaffar joined the family business when he was around 15-16 years old and

spent more than six decades making the national flag.

"He started working with our father when he was very young. For more than 60 years, he remained associated with this work. Today, our children are learning the same craft," Malik said.

The workshop has witnessed changing demand for the tricolour through some of the country's defining moments, he said.

"We have seen the demand during the 1962 China war, the Emergency, the Kargil conflict, the Anna Andolan and later the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign. Whenever the country comes together, we feel it here first," Malik said.

The rush ahead of this Independence Day has been particularly large. The family has so far prepared and sold around 25 to 30 lakh flags for the season, with several large government orders already dispatched.

"Most of the government orders have already gone

out. Now we are supplying to local schools, shops, housing societies and other customers. The rain has slowed the demand a little in the last few days, but we have a large stock ready," Malik said.

During the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign, the workshop had produced more than one lakh flags a day, he said. Step outside the shop, and almost every lane in Sadar Bazar has taken on the colours of the tricolour.

National flags hang from awnings, and flagpins fill display trays, while badges, dashboard flags, bunting and wristbands crowd shopfronts. Traders say patriotic merchandise becomes a major draw in the weeks

leading up to August 15.

"These two weeks are completely different from the rest of the year. Normally, flags are just one of many products we keep. But before August 15, they become our main business. Around 60 to 70 per cent of our sales come from flags, flag pins and other patriotic items," said Rajesh Gupta, who has been selling patriotic merchandise in Sadar Bazar for more than 20 years.

"Schools, government offices, RWAs and families all come looking for them," he said. A few shops away, trader Irshad Khan said demand begins building nearly two weeks before Independence Day.

IN FOCUS



A man gathers freshly harvested water lilies in the waters of the Borir Beel (lake) in North 24 Parganas district, West Bengal on Saturday

PTI

3rd suspect held in Batala grenade attack, BKi-ISI link probed

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Chandigarh

The Counter Intelligence (CI) wing in Jalandhar, in coordination with Batala Police, has arrested the third suspect in the August 1 grenade attack on the Urban Estate Police Post in Batala. This development highlights the ongoing challenge posed by transnational Khalistani terror networks in Punjab's border areas.

Police say the arrested person is part of a terror group backed by ISI and led by a Babbar Khalsa International leader based in Portugal. Punjab's Director General of Police, Gaurav Yadav, said early investigations show the group followed orders from their handler in Portugal.

No one was hurt in the August 1 attack, when a grenade was thrown at the police post. Soon after, BKi

members claimed responsibility on social media, which matches a pattern seen in other attacks on police sites in border areas.

Earlier this week, police detained two juveniles linked to the attack during increased operations under Operation Prahar 4.0, which was started before Independence Day to tackle possible threats. Deputy Inspector General Harmanbir Singh Gill confirmed that three people took part in the attack and that the last suspect has now been caught.

After the attack, the third suspect went into hiding and was reportedly planning more attacks on police sites in Punjab, officials said. Investigators are now working to uncover the full terror network, find foreign handlers and local helpers, and understand how they are connected.



Security agencies have seen this pattern before over the past two years. Small local groups, often made up of young or financially struggling people from border areas like Batala and Gurdaspur, are recruited or paid small amounts by handlers living abroad. These handlers, often tied to the banned BKi and reportedly supported by Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence, organise low-cost but attention-grabbing attacks on police posts to spread fear

and propaganda.

Previous operations in the region have shown similar setups. In earlier cases in Batala and Gurdaspur, groups were directed by people based in Pakistan, like Harwinder Singh, also known as Rinda, as well as operatives in the US, Armenia, and Europe.

Portugal has often been a base for BKi-linked handlers, such as Maninder Billa, mentioned in past investigations. Young people have been recruited through social

media, promises of money, or offers to help them travel abroad, and then asked to pick up grenades from hidden spots or carry out attacks. Investigators noted that using the BKi name makes regular crimes seem like organised terror, which increases fear even if the actual damage is small. DIG Gill said that anti-national groups use social media stories and money to attract vulnerable youth.

This arrest comes at an important time, with Independence Day approaching. Punjab Police have stepped up surveillance, raids, and preventive arrests as part of Operation Prahar. While these groups rarely cause large-scale harm, the frequent grenade attacks on police sites in border areas keep security forces alert and put pressure on resources. Investigators are trying to identify the

handler in Portugal, track how instructions and explosives are sent, and see if the group had bigger plans.

The two juveniles and the newly arrested adult are the main members of the local group, and questioning them may reveal more about logistics, funding, and other members. Punjab Police have repeated their promise to break up these networks both locally and internationally.

The Batala case shows both the persistence of ISI-backed, Europe-based support for Khalistani violence and the success of coordinated, intelligence-driven policing in stopping attacks before they happen.

As the investigation goes on, Punjab Police officials urge the public, especially young people in border areas, to stay alert to online radicalisation and offers of money from handlers abroad.

Jharkhand Govt, students standoff continues over exam irregularities

SURENDRA SOREN ■ Ranchi

The standoff between the Jharkhand Government and students protesting alleged irregularities in JPSC and JSSC examinations continued on Saturday, with talks between a high-level ministerial committee and another group of agitating students ending without any breakthrough.

Students staging a prolonged protest at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in Ranchi remained firm on their demands and decided to continue their agitation.

During the meeting with the Government committee, student representatives



Students representing a group led by Devendra Nath Mahto hold talks with the ministerial panel formed to address students' issues in Ranchi on Saturday

PIONEER PHOTO

placed a list of immediate and long-term demands. Their immediate demands included cancellation of the 14th JPSC examination, 2023 and 2025 JPSC examinations, FRO, ACF, Assistant Public

Prosecutor and JET 2026 examinations, among others.

The students also demanded that cases related to JPSC and JSSC pending before courts be resolved within three months. They sought

transparent and error-free recruitment rules, improvements in the standard operating procedure (SOP) governing examinations and clear accountability of officials and employees involved in the recruitment process.

Meanwhile, the controversy surrounding alleged irregularities in the JPSC Combined Civil Services Preliminary Examination-2025 has reached the Supreme Court. Social activist and political leader Harisharan Devgan has filed a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) seeking an investigation into JPSC and JSSC examinations.

Keep curiosity alive, PM tells students

Referring to the rapidly shifting geopolitical and strategic global landscape, the prime minister identified the relentless speed of technological advancement as the primary catalyst for these massive global transformations. He framed this era of rapid change as a dual landscape of unprecedented challenges and vast new opportunities. "Amidst all this rapid change, remember my words: the one who continuously learns is the one who will win," he said.

Redefining the true value of an IIT degree, PM Modi emphasised that the qualification goes far beyond a high CGPA (cumulative grade point average) or a lucrative placement offer, acting instead as a definitive global certification of advanced problem-solving capabilities. "Your degree tells the entire world that you know exactly how to solve highly difficult problems," he said.

He challenged the current generation to define their own legacy by aligning their career trajectories directly with the nation's developmental goals over the next three decades. "The basis of every decision of yours should absolutely be what the benefit to the country will be and which national need will be fulfilled," affirmed PM.

"If difficulties inevitably come in life, entirely new opportunities will also emerge; you just have to remain completely alert," he said.

Contrasting structured academic environments with unpredictable real-world scenarios, Modi told the graduates that unlike their university exams, life's most critical challenges operate entirely 'out of syllabus'. He stressed that true success lies not merely in answering pre-defined questions, but in identifying and solving the problems that society has complacently accepted. "The fundamental reason for the success of many alumni was that they boldly identified those crucial questions which the world had stopped considering as questions," he said.

Reflecting on the historical burdens carried by past generations, PM Modi recalled how the singular goal of achieving independence defined an entire era marked by immense sacrifice and penance. He urged the current generation to define their own legacy by aligning their career trajectories directly with the nation's developmental goals over the next three decades.

"The basis of every decision of yours should absolutely be what the benefit to the country will be and which national need will be fulfilled," he said.

Detailing the Government's aggressive push toward comprehensive self-reliance across economic, technological, and industrial sectors, Modi underscored that youth empowerment is the foundational bedrock of a developed India. He celebrated the administration's strategic policy decisions to democratise and open traditionally restricted sectors to young innovators.

Referring to the "explosive growth" of the space sector and "rapid domestic advancement in semiconductor manufacturing" in India, the prime minister said, "somewhere a youth is proudly saying with full self-confidence: 'First in my bloodline to make a chip in India'".

Crediting the current generation for powering India's Startup Revolution, he hailed the massive economic momentum generated by unicorns, digital payments, and the FinTech boom, which have provided unprecedented

entrepreneurial platforms for millions.

"All these revolutions have given millions of youths of the country an incredible opportunity to do something completely new for the first time," he said.

Mapping out the frontiers of future technological dominance, Modi highlighted critical emerging sectors such as artificial intelligence, data centres, critical minerals, deep-sea exploration, quantum computing, and energy security. "Many such cutting-edge fields are eagerly waiting for your immense talent, your bold innovation, and your strong leadership," he said.

Detailing initiatives to democratise academic resources, he highlighted the 'One Nation One Subscription' programme, which ensures that prestigious global research journals are accessible even in the smallest cities without extra costs. The Prime Minister also inaugurated Param Pragma, an AI-powered high-performance supercomputing facility established at the IIT Delhi's Sonipat Campus. The state-of-the-art facility is expected to significantly enhance the institute's capabilities in AI, data science, advanced computing and interdisciplinary research.

Govt vs Meta: Can it still be called an...

Technology is advancing faster than old moderation tools, and the government wants platforms to treat this as an urgent problem, not a distant one. The Government's focus on this issue is clear.

Sources say this is not just regulation for its own sake. The government wants to know if the current legal rules for intermediaries still apply to platforms that control what content is seen. When some voices get more attention, the claim of neutrality becomes questionable. If Meta is already acting as a director instead of staying in the background, the impact will go far beyond one company. Other platforms that use ranking and promotion will face the same scrutiny.

Safe harbour, which once seemed permanent, could become a conditional privilege given only to platforms that prove they are true intermediaries and not publishers. For millions of Indians who get their news and entertainment from these platforms, the outcome matters. More accountability could mean faster removal of harmful content and clearer rules for paid posts. But it could also make platforms more cautious and slow the flow of information because of legal concerns. No final decision has been made yet.

Talks are ongoing, and Meta has been asked to respond about its status as an intermediary and its approach to deepfakes. In a country where online discussion is bigger than any physical gathering, the outcome will shape public conversation for years. The law still protects true intermediaries, those who only deliver messages. The question is whether Meta has already moved from being a messenger to taking on the greater responsibility of a publisher, deciding whose voice is heard and whose is not.

Indian youth potential unparalleled: Rahul

Congress Media publicity wing chief Rajya Sabha Member Pawan Khera was also present on the occasion besides top party leader of the State.

On the recent student protests all over the country, Gandhi said the youth "lit a light in the darkness" by confronting their fears and, in

doing so, helped change the country. "We will never resort to hatred or violence. We will change the system with love and affection," Rahul said, and urged the youth to follow suit.

Rahul spoke before a large gathering of students and competitive exam aspirants, who turned up despite waterlogging and muddy patches at the venue. Dance performances by rappers from Mumbai were staged ahead of Gandhi's arrival.

In the run-up to the much-publicised event, the Congress on Friday took out a motorcycle rally in the city, led by the party's Uttar Pradesh president Ajay Rai. Students at the event complained of problems in hostels and concerns with competitive exams, which they said they hope to raise before Rahul Gandhi.

SAD backs Delimitation Bill, signals BJP alliance

The Akali Dal had earlier taken a different stand on the Delimitation Bill. When the Centre introduced it in Parliament in April, the party voted against the legislation with the Opposition, calling it unfair to Punjab. The party had argued that Punjab would get only a small increase in seats, while neighbouring States would benefit much more. Speaking after the meeting, SAD leader Daljit Singh Cheema said that the decision on the two pending issues was taken at the meeting attended by all senior leaders. Echoing Badal's views, he urged Parliament not to delay the implementation of the women's quota. He said the proposal to increase seats will benefit Punjab. "Both the bills should be passed in Parliament and should be implemented."

Party senior leader Naresh Gujral said the decision was "a very logical thing" for the party to do. "We have one member in the Parliament, and we cannot just oppose the two bills for the sake of it," said Gujral, party vice-president and former Rajya Sabha member.

"We have been supporting women reservation in the Parliament, and delimitation is the need of the hour," he further said.

Akali Dal had left the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) six years ago citing differences over the three farm laws, which now stand repealed. The Shiromani Akali Dal then announced its exit from the NDA.

Since then, both parties contested the 2022 Punjab Assembly elections and the 2024 Lok Sabha elections independently. In the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, the BJP failed to win any seats in the State, while the Akali Dal managed to secure only one.

Badal's meeting with the Prime Minister at Parliament on Friday had set the speculation buzzing around the two parties reviving their old alliance. The Government is making a fresh attempt for the passage of a Constitution Amendment Bill to implement 33 per cent reservation for women in legislatures in 2029 and redraw the Lok Sabha constituencies to increase their number to 816 in the ongoing Monsoon session by reaching out to opposition leaders and NDA allies. The Constitution Amendment Bill was defeated in the last session.

MHA bans new renewable projects...

The ministry said the new rules are meant to balance national security with making it easier to do business. Projects that already received MHA security clearance or a Defence Ministry NOC before these rules do not need to apply again. This change follows a big increase in applications for renewable energy projects in border districts like Jammu and

Kashmir, Ladakh, Punjab, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Arunachal Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand.

While large solar and wind parks help India reach its clean-energy goals, they can also create surveillance risks, offer vantage points for hostile mapping, and make it harder for security forces to move and respond quickly.

Recent drone activity near large projects along the western border has highlighted these issues. To address these risks, the guidelines require a strong security plan for approved projects. Developers must install anti-drone systems operated by the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) and state police. Internal roads should be built so the military can use them if needed. Building heights will be limited based on how close they are to the border, and projects that could attract large crowds, such as hotels or permanent housing, are discouraged. The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy has been asked to ensure that land allotments do not create long stretches of infrastructure along the international border. By mid-2026, India's renewable energy capacity exceeded 288 GW, with most new growth coming from solar and wind. Border areas like Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Ladakh have strong solar and wind potential, which attracts many developers.

The new rules do not stop development. Instead, they create a process that puts national security first without banning projects beyond the one-kilometre zone. By setting up a clear and uniform process, the MHA aims to reduce confusion between state land allotments, central security clearances, and defence needs. States still manage land allocation, but the Central government has the final say on security clearance in these sensitive areas.

The guidelines acknowledge that building energy infrastructure near the borders now involves security concerns, not just economic or environmental ones. With new threats like drone attacks and cyber warfare, projects near disputed borders can pose risks for both civilian and military use. Still, India remains committed to its energy transition and renewable goals. Projects outside the restricted zones, or those that meet the new clearance rules, will continue to support the national grid.

Now that the guidelines are in place, developers with pending applications for projects in the 1-50 km zone must send their proposals to the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy. The ministry will then forward them to the MHA and, if needed, the Defence Ministry.

3,323 Indians deported from Canada in six...

Mexico topped Canada's list of nationalities for deportations in each of the last five years, with India ranking second during that period.

India had last topped the list in 2020, when 1,424 Indian nationals were deported from Canada.

In 2021, as many as 603 Indians were deported from Canada, followed by 786 in 2022. In 2023, the number rose to 1,132, and further to 2,004 in 2024, according to CBSA data.

The CBSA maintains a separate database on reasons for deportation, but that does not have a country-wise breakdown.

Indians also accounted for the largest group in Canada's "removal in progress inventory", with 7,669 people awaiting removal, CBSA data showed.

Canada enforces three broad categories of removal orders. Under a departure order, a person is required to leave Canada voluntarily within 30 days, failing which it automatically



Delhi Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra, Greater Kailash MLA Shikha Roy and other dignitaries were present at the event. On the occasion, the Chief Minister said the Government was continuously encouraging such events to further enrich Delhi's diverse cultural identity. Platforms such as Dilli Haat,

she said, play an important role in showcasing the city's folk art, handicrafts, traditional cuisine and cultural heritage to people across the country and the world.

Greeting all Delhi residents on the occasion of Teej, the Chief Minister said such festivals provide an opportunity to reconnect with one's roots, preserve traditions and take them forward to future generations.

The two-day Teej Mahotsav, organised by the Delhi Government, is being held at Dilli Haat in Pitampura and INA on August 8 and 9. The festival aims to present women's empowerment, love for nature and traditional values through the celebration of Teej, while connecting Delhi residents and tourists from different parts of the country with Indian culture.

Pasta, pizza, momos: Kanwar camps...

This time, many camps have been made completely plastic-free. Stainless steel utensils are being used to serve food instead of plastic or thermocol plates.

Overall hygiene at serving stations and a clean environment aim to convey a message of environmental conservation during the Kanwar Yatra.

Amit Murti, organiser of the 'Maa Kanwar Seva Camp', said that their objective is not merely to provide food, but to make the journey of the Shiv devotees safe, pleasant, and memorable. Camp organisers noted that standards regarding food quality, hygiene, and safety are being strictly followed in accordance with the UP Government's guidelines.

On Saturday, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath welcomed Kanwariyas in Meerut by showering them with flower petals, and said the devotees of Lord Shiva who are walking hundreds of kilometres present an example of social and national unity. Standing on a specially erected platform, Adityanath, along with BJP leaders, showered rose petals on the passing Kanwariyas near the Dulhera police outpost in the Modipuram area.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited the Kanwar Seva Camp near the Delhi-Uttar Pradesh (Apsara) border at Dilshad Garden, where she welcomed Shiv devotees and honoured them by showering flower petals. During her visit, she interacted with the devotees to inquire about their journey and camp arrangements, wishing everyone a blissful, safe, and successful Kanwar Yatra.

She inquired about essential facilities such as food, drinking water, sanitation, healthcare, rest, and other basic amenities provided to the devotees, while also interacting with the dedicated camp organisers and volunteers. She stated that the ongoing efforts across various locations in Delhi to serve and welcome Shiv devotees reflect a beautiful example of community service and religious devotion.

Pant slams red tape over Uttarakhand land...

The wicketkeeper-batter, one of Uttarakhand's prominent sporting icons, appealed posts early on Saturday. "I have been trying for the past three years to find suitable land in Uttarakhand, but I have not been able to understand the process clearly," Pant said, tagging the CM.

"Dear Rishabh, you are the pride of Uttarakhand. With your splendid performances and achievements, you have illuminated the name of Devbhoomi across the country and the world. Your love for your motherland and your desire to return and contribute here are truly commendable," Dhani posted on X.

Pant later clarified that he was not seeking any special favour or free allotment from the Government. Instead, he said he was willing to purchase the land at the Government's prescribed rates if the administration could facilitate the process.



Ministry of Culture
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Prime Minister



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NIA files chargesheet in cross-border terror case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has filed a chargesheet against two people accused in a cross-border terror plot. The case involves the alleged smuggling of an Improvised Explosive Device (IED), a firearm, and heroin across the India-Pakistan border. The plan was meant to enable attacks that could cause mass casualties and disrupt public order in India.

The chargesheet, filed in the NIA Special Court in Mohali, names Shubham Kumar, who is in custody, and Jasvir Chaudhary, who is still at large. Both are charged under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Explosive Substances Act, the Arms Act, the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and the Railways Act.

These charges include terrorism, illegal possession of explosives and firearms, drug trafficking and threats to transportation infrastruc-



ture. The case started in February 2026 when the State Special Operations Cell (SSOC) in Amritsar arrested Shubham Kumar. He was found with a live IED in a metal case, a remote-control device for detonation, a foreign-made .30 bore pistol with a magazine, 20 live cartridges, a mobile phone and some heroin.

These seizures gave investigators their first major lead, which later pointed to a larger, organised conspiracy. In March 2026, the NIA took

over the case because it involved both interstate and cross-border elements. Their investigation uncovered a network led by a handler in Pakistan with several associates in India. According to the NIA, the main goal of this network was to obtain and smuggle arms, explosives and drugs through cross-border routes. These operations used weak spots along the border to support terrorist activities in India.

The investigation found that Kumar was tasked with

planting a timer-activated IED on a passenger train. The aim was to cause civilian casualties on the railway. The larger plan included coordinated attacks at several locations in Punjab and Delhi, aiming to cause loss of life and property, disturb public peace and threaten national security.

The NIA says the investigation has produced a large amount of oral, written and digital evidence. This material supports the alleged conspiracy and shows the roles of each accused person. The chargesheet was filed on time, showing the agency met legal deadlines and was thorough.

At the same time, authorities are working to find and close the routes used to move explosives, weapons and drugs across the border. Officials say stopping these supply lines is key to preventing future plots. This case highlights the ongoing challenges of cross-border terrorism and the need for constant vigilance, teamwork between agencies and strong legal action to protect national security.

Cross-border smuggling networks: Persistent threat to India's security

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Cross-border smuggling networks operating along the India-Pakistan frontier continue to pose a significant challenge to national security, combining the illicit movement of narcotics, arms and explosives with elements of terrorism. These networks, often directed by handlers based across the border and supported by local associates in India, have been repeatedly highlighted in investigations by agencies such as the National Investigation Agency (NIA), Border Security Force (BSF) and Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB).

A recent example came on August 7, 2026, when the NIA charged two people with smuggling an improvised explosive device, a firearm, and heroin across the border. The plan included attacks in Punjab and Delhi and an attempt to target a passenger train. This case shows how these networks mix drug trafficking with gathering materials for violence. The NIA says its investigation is still ongoing to find more members and



the routes used to move contraband.

These networks often use Punjab and Rajasthan as main entry points because they are close to the border. Much of the heroin comes from the Afghanistan-Pakistan region, and the money from this trade often funds terrorist activities in Jammu and Kashmir and Punjab. Parliament has confirmed that foreign groups use drug smuggling to raise money for terror groups in these areas.

In recent years, authorities have seen the problem grow. NCB data from 2025 shows a big increase in cases, especially in Punjab, where most aerial deliveries of contraband happen. Each year, hundreds of kilograms of drugs are seized in Punjab and nearby areas, showing

both the scale of smuggling and the strong response from law enforcement. At the same time, foreign-made weapons are also being found, highlighting how arms and drugs often move together.

The effects go beyond security. Large amounts of narcotics entering border states cause public health problems, especially in Punjab, where addiction is a major issue. The illegal trade also hurts the economy by undermining legal businesses and creating hidden funds that support organised crime and extremism. These networks also threaten national security by enabling attacks that disrupt public order and important infrastructure.

Indian agencies have increased their efforts. The

NIA, BSF, state police, and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) are working together and have made several arrests, seized large amounts of goods, and disrupted money trails. They are trying to find handlers in Pakistan, local contacts, and distribution networks in different States. They are also checking other possible routes, such as those on the western coast. Using technology and sharing intelligence are important parts of their work, with the main goal of breaking up the smuggling networks.

Even with these successes, the networks keep adapting, so the problem continues. Cases like the recent NIA investigation show that ongoing vigilance, inter-agency cooperation, and strong legal action under laws like the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act remain essential.

Tackling the connections between smuggling, organised crime, and terrorism is vital to protect India's borders and internal security, security experts say.

Govt to take measures to rebuild breached embankments: Himanta



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday visited Bengabara and Naharbari under Mangaldai Assembly constituency in Darrang district to take stock of the recent flood situation and assess the condition of the affected areas.

The Chief Minister inspected the breached portion of the embankment along the Noa River near Bengabara village and reviewed the ongoing repair works. The breach in the river embankment a few days ago had inundated several villages in the area.

Sarma also visited the relief camps set up at the under-construction Anganwadi Centre at Bengabara village and Outala HS School and interacted with flood-affected people taking shelter there. He enquired about their well-being and assured them of all possible assistance. He subsequently

inspected the breached embankment along the Kulsi River at Naharbari.

Chief Minister Sarma said that the recent floods had caused considerable hardship to the people of the area following breaches in the embankments. The Chief Minister said that the Government would take special measures to rebuild the breached embankments with enhanced strength. He also assured that all flood-affected families would be provided the necessary assistance at the earliest as per Government norms.

Health and Family Welfare Minister and Guardian Minister of Darrang Ashok Singhal, Animal Husbandry and Veterinary Minister and local MLA Nilima Devi, MLA Paramananda Rajbongshi, District Commissioner and officials of the district administration and concerned departments were present during the visit.

Par panel flags OBC quota deficit in Posts dept

AMIT KAUSHAL
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary committee chaired by Lok Sabha MP Ganesh Singh has expressed concern over the shortfall in Other Backward Classes (OBC) representation in the Department of Posts and urged the Union Ministry of Communications to strictly adhere to the mandated 27 per cent reservation quota across all cadre levels.

The report of the Committee on Welfare of Other Backward Classes was presented in the Lok Sabha on Thursday, laying out six major recommendations aimed at addressing backlog vacancies, boosting rural infrastructure, and ensuring social equity.

Highlighting a sharp deficit, the



Lok Sabha MP Ganesh Singh

parliamentary panel noted that OBC representation in Group 'A' stands at a meager 7.2 per cent at the Junior Time Scale level. In Group 'B', OBCs constitute only 19.5 per cent of Inspectors of Posts and 21 per cent

of Stenographers. The figures are marginally better in Group 'C', where representation stands at 25.2 per cent among Postal Assistants and 26.1 per cent among Postmen — yet still below the prescribed threshold.

Expressing dissatisfaction that representation remains incomplete even after three decades of the policy's rollout, the panel urged the department to immediately initiate Special Recruitment Drives to clear 207 Group 'C' backlog vacancies, the majority of which (204) are in the West Bengal Circle.

Taking note of the financial hardship faced by over 2.5 lakh Gramin Dak Sevaks (GDS) who perform essential doorstep postal and payments bank services in rural areas on a basic monthly remuneration of ₹10,000 to ₹12,000, the panel recom-

mended an immediate upward revision in their regular pay.

Among other key observations, the committee directed the department to strictly enforce reservation rules for temporary and contractual appointments lasting 45 days or more, as per DoPT guidelines. It also advocated for operating more rural post offices from Gram Panchayat Bhawans to deepen financial inclusion and cut rental overheads, while recommending that basic facilities be granted to recognised OBC Employees' Welfare Associations.

Emphasising the vision of inclusive development, Shri Ganesh Singh stated that reservation must extend beyond mere percentage fulfillment to deliver real socio-economic empowerment and equal opportunities for eligible youth.

CPI(M) slams E20 fuel policy, cites vehicle damage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Friday expressed serious concern over the implementation of the Union Government's Ethanol Blending Policy (EBP), demanding that consumers be given a choice between blended fuel and unblended petrol at all retail outlets.

Taking a strong stance against the mandatory roll-out of E20 fuel, the CPI(M) alleged that the policy prioritises corporate profits over public interest, food security, and consumer rights.

In a statement issued from the party's central committee office, the Left party highlighted a recent

communication by the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) to the Union Petroleum Ministry. The party noted that SIAM had raised alarm over vehicle damage caused by ethanol-blended fuel before withdrawing its letter. "The subsequent withdrawal of the letter, obviously under pressure, does not negate the concerns raised therein," the Polit Bureau stated.

Critiquing the pricing structure of E20 fuel, the CPI(M) pointed out that despite initial assurances that ethanol blends would be cheaper, E20 is currently sold at rates comparable to regular petrol. This comes despite blended fuel offering lower mileage and causing increased wear and tear on engine components, leaving motorists with no alternative options.



Raising concerns over agricultural impact and food security, the CPI(M) warned against the diversion of food crops for fuel production in a nation struggling with hunger and malnutrition. The party highlighted that maize is being imported to boost ethanol output, leading to distortions in cropping

patterns and the over-extraction of groundwater due to water-intensive cultivation.

The CPI(M) further cautioned the Centre against the potential import of Genetically Modified (GM) corn from the United States, warning that it risks contaminating local crops and being diverted for human consumption.

Calling for an immediate review of the fuel strategy, the CPI(M) demanded that ethanol blends be priced proportionately lower than unblended petrol to compensate consumers for reduced fuel efficiency. It also urged the government to cap ethanol blending at 20 per cent and warned of widespread public protests if the policy is not rectified.

Improved connectivity drives Ladakh tourist surge

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Better air and road connectivity has boosted tourist arrivals in the cold desert region of Ladakh this season.

The Union Territory has already recorded 3,30,332 tourist arrivals between January and July this year, accounting for 98.35 per cent of the total footfall for the entire year of 2025.

Ladakh became the most sought-after destination this season, with a rapid surge in June and July. More than 2.12 lakh tourists visited Ladakh, accounting for nearly 65 per cent of the total 3.30 lakh tourist arrivals recorded so far this year.

According to official sources, Ladakh received 1,05,046 tourists in July 2026, compared to 67,273 in July 2025, registering a growth of 56.15 per cent. The July arrivals comprised 95,416 domestic and 9,630 foreign tourists.

June also witnessed a significant increase, with 1,07,740 tourists visiting Ladakh compared to 75,089 in June 2025, representing a growth of 43.48 per cent. Of the June 2026 arrivals, 1,01,060 were domestic and 6,680 foreign tourists.

Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena attributed the growing tourist footfall, particularly domestic tourism, to the sustained infrastructure development in Ladakh.

LG Saxena said Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to our citizens to explore the beauty and diversity of our own country has given a further impetus to domestic tourism.

LG Saxena said the trend reflects the growing popularity of Ladakh as a destination for adventure, nature, culture, spirituality and high-altitude tourism.

The fact that Ladakh has crossed the one-lakh mark in tourist arrivals for two successive months and has already achieved more than 98 per cent of the entire 2025 footfall by the end of July is a very encouraging milestone, LG Vinai Saxena added.

Of the 3,30,332 tourists who visited Ladakh during January–July 2026, 1,57,371 (47.64 per cent) arrived by air, while 1,16,523 (35.27 per cent) entered through the Kashmir route and 56,438 (17.09 per cent) arrived through the Manali route.

Ladakh and India are among the safest places for tourists, and we welcome vis-



itors from across India and abroad. Our priority is to ensure that this growth translates into sustainable livelihood opportunities for our people while protecting Ladakh's fragile ecology, rich culture and heritage," said LG Saxena.

According to a spokesman of the Ladakh Tourism department, the surge in tourist arrivals during June and July has also been supported by a vibrant calendar of cultural, spiritual and experiential events organised across Ladakh. Major attractions during the period included the Hemis Festival, Pratham Sindhu Kumbh, Ladakh Astro Week 2026

(held in the last week of May), Phyang Tsedup and several other local monastic festivals, which brought together visitors interested in Ladakh's rich Buddhist heritage, culture, spirituality and unique high-altitude experiences.

The rapid growth in the Tourism sector assumes greater significance and coincides with a major and rapid transformation in Ladakh's connectivity infrastructure since the formation of the Union Territory. The total road network has increased from 1,799 km in 2019 to over 4,200 km in 2026, while the number of bridges has increased from

19 to 72. According to experts in the Tourism sector, the period of seasonal disruption on key routes has also reduced substantially. Zoji La, the gateway to Ladakh from Kashmir, which earlier remained closed for around 127 days annually, now remains closed for only 16 days. Similarly, the annual closure of the Kargil–Zaskar Road has declined from 154 days to 11 days, significantly improving near-year-round connectivity for tourists. The number of homestays has increased from 128 in 2019 to 2,275 in 2026, creating new livelihood opportunities for local households.

The tourism surge has further been supported by a series of reforms in the tourism sector, creating tourist-friendly infrastructure and amenities under the guidance of LG Vinai Saxena. Initiatives like tourism sector reforms to reduce compliance burden, simplification of cumbersome documentation, and granting of Industry Status to hotels and guest houses have strengthened confidence among tourism stakeholders, including hoteliers, guest house owners, tour operators, etc.

AIKS calls for mass farmer protests on August 10

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) on Saturday called upon farmers and their families across the country to participate in mass protest actions on August 10, including 'Jail Bhao', 'Rasta Roko', and 'Rail Roko', targeting the Central Government's agrarian and labour policies.

The call for the nationwide agitation was declared by the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM) during its All-India Convention on July 28 and subsequently endorsed by the National Convention of Farmers and Workers convened alongside the Central Trade Unions (CTU) in New Delhi on July 29.

According to AIKS leadership, the upcoming action serves as a prelude to a longer, sustained agitation set to launch on November 26, 2026 — marking the anniversary of the 2020–21 farmers' movement — under the banner of 'Save Agriculture, Save Industry, Save India'.

In a press statement, the farmer body emphasised



Representative image

that the August 10 action aims to project a united front of workers and peasants against corporate encroachment and the denial of fair remuneration. The outfit highlighted key charter demands, including a statutory guarantee for Minimum Support Price (MSP) calculated at the C2+50 per cent formula with guaranteed State procurement across all crops.

Additionally, the unions are demanding the repeal of the four Labour Codes, an increase in the minimum

wage for workers to ₹42,000, and a daily wage of ₹700 for 200 days of work under MGNREGA for agricultural labourers. Other major demands raised by the body include complete agricultural loan waivers, ₹25 lakh compensation for families affected by peasant suicides, an explicit rejection of free trade agreements, the withdrawal of the proposed Seed Bill 2025, and a halt to the privatisation of electricity and installation of pre-paid smart meters.

Alcohol ban in Bihar failed to prevent violence against women: NCAER study

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Bihar should revoke the ban on alcohol as it failed to prevent violence against women from rising, and anecdotal evidence suggests that legal drinking was substituted by an increase in the consumption of illicit drugs and alcohol, a research paper by economic think tank National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER) has said.

The paper, titled 'Macro Perspective of Bihar's Development Achievements, Unfinished Agenda, and the Way Forward', further said that the reinstatement of the liquor excise tax to the pre-ban levels would increase the state's own revenues by 14-15 per cent and decrease spending on enforcement and anti-smuggling operations.

The paper, prepared by a team of economists led by Ratna Sahay and presented at the 'India Policy Forum', noted that the primary motivations for introducing the ban in April 2016 were the belief that alcohol consumption was a significant contributor to domestic violence and that household resources



could be better spent on more productive activities.

It added that women's groups and activists strongly supported the prohibition, arguing that it would lead to a decrease in alcohol-related abuse. "We now have sufficient data and information to assess if the ban was effective. Reported crimes against women in Bihar have not declined following the introduction of prohibition. Instead, total reported crimes against women increased over the post-2016 period," it said.

According to the paper, overall, the available evidence does not indicate a broad-based reduction in crimes against women following prohibition.

At the same time, it pointed

out that the prohibition regime has been accompanied by concerns regarding the expansion of the illicit liquor trade, increased enforcement challenges and corruption, and the growing use of alternative intoxicants, including illicit drugs.

"In tandem, there was a significant rise in illegal liquor trade leading to higher alcohol consumption, increased crime and corruption, and an increase in the use of alternative additive substances, such as illicit drugs," it said.

The paper said the economic consequences of the liquor ban were significant; before the ban, excise duty on alcohol was an important source of state revenues (14

per cent in the 3 years leading up to the ban).

"Moreover, enforcement expenditures on monitoring and anti-smuggling operations increased, widening the fiscal deficit further," it said, adding that, in short, the introduction of the ban has not served its intended purpose; instead, it has coincided with higher violence against women, loss of state revenues, and higher expenditures.

The authors of the paper said they believe it's time to reintroduce the excise duty at historical levels to achieve 14 per cent of state revenues.

The restoration of law and order was critical in Bihar's post-2005 recovery.

Following decades of corrupt practices, violent crime, and weak administrative capacity, the state government under Nitish Kumar began to emphasise policing, criminal prosecution, judicial reforms, and administrative accountability. Bihar's development is central to India's ambition of Viksit Bharat to become a developed economy by 2047, given that Bihar has the second largest population and remains the poorest state.

Railways approves merger of Chitrakutdham Karwi-Kanpur, Pratapgarh-Kanpur Express trains

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Railways has approved the merger of the 14109/14110 Chitrakutdham Karwi-Kanpur Central Express and 14123/14124 Maa Belha Devi Dham Pratapgarh-Chitrakutdham Karwi Express. The merged service will operate as the 14123/14124 Maa Belha Devi Dham Pratapgarh-Chitrakutdham Karwi Express. The merger is aimed at improving direct rail connectivity between Maa Belha Devi Dham Pratapgarh and Chitrakutdham Karwi, while strengthening connectivity between major destinations including Kanpur Central, the Lucknow region and Chitrakoot.

Passenger capacity to double to 24 coaches

As part of the merger, the combined train service will have an enhanced passenger carrying capacity. The existing 12-coach composition will be increased to 24 coaches, significantly augmenting seating capacity and helping address overcrowding and rising passenger demand on the Kanpur-Pratapgarh section.

The enhanced capacity is



expected to provide greater convenience to passengers travelling between Kanpur, Banda, Chitrakoot, Pratapgarh and other stations along the route.

Direct connectivity between Chitrakoot and Pratapgarh-Lucknow region

The merged service will provide improved direct rail connectivity between Chitrakoot and the Lucknow-Pratapgarh region. Passengers will have a more convenient travel option without the need to change trains at Kanpur Central.

The service is expected to particularly benefit passengers travelling for pilgrimage, tourism, education, employment and other purposes

between the important religious and regional centres of Chitrakoot, Pratapgarh and the Lucknow region.

Major stations to remain connected

The merged service will continue to serve several important stations along the route, including Maa Belha Devi Dham Pratapgarh, Chhibila, Maa Chandrika Devi Dham Antu, Amethi, Gauriganj, Kashimpur, Jais, Fursatganj, Rae Bareilly, Harchandpur, Bachhrawan, Nigohan, Lucknow, Manak Nagar, Unnao and Kanpur Central.

Beyond Kanpur Central, the train will serve Bhimsen, Kathara Road, Patara, Ghatampur, Hamirpur Road, Yamuna South Bank, Bharwa

Sumerpur, Ragaul, Banda, Atarra and Chitrakutdham Karwi.

The merger is expected to ease overcrowding on the Kanpur-Pratapgarh section and provide improved connectivity for passengers across the region.

The new merged service will strengthen passenger connectivity across Uttar Pradesh and improve accessibility to important religious and cultural destinations, while also supporting more efficient utilisation of railway resources.

The service will create a seamless rail corridor connecting Bundelkhand and Awadh, providing direct connectivity from Chitrakoot to Lucknow, the state capital, as well as to Pratapgarh.

The augmentation of the train composition from 12 to 24 coaches will double passenger carrying capacity at an affordable price and substantially improve rail services on the corridor.

Besides facilitating pilgrimage and tourism to Chitrakoot, the service is expected to strengthen connectivity for education, healthcare, employment, business and administrative travel.

Young, aspiring innovator wins Gold at IRIS National Fair

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shaurya Patel won Gold for the second consecutive year at the Initiative for Research and Innovation in STEM (IRIS) National Fair 2025-26 Cohort 2, India's leading platform for school-level scientific research and innovation.

A class X student at Adani International School, Ahmedabad, Shaurya Patel's research aimed at developing a unified, longitudinal metabolic data that integrates clinical biomarkers with lifestyle and wellness factors to improve early risk stratification and AI enabled preventive intervention.

This year 120 projects by 152 students were evaluated at the IRIS National Fair.

Having won the Gold at the IRIS in 2025 as well, Shaurya represented India at the prestigious Regeneron International Science and Engineering Fair (ISEF) 2025 which was held in Columbus Ohio, USA, in May 2025.

BEML Q1 loss narrows to ₹27 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned BEML has narrowed its consolidated net loss to ₹27.01 crore in June quarter FY27, helped by increased revenues.

It had reported a net loss of ₹64.11 crore in the first quarter of preceding 2025-26 fiscal, the company said in an exchange filing on Friday.

During the quarter, the total income increased to ₹821.19 crore from ₹642.56 crore a year ago.

In a separate statement, BEML said it secured orders worth ₹1,181 crore in Q1 FY27 as compared to ₹435 crore a year ago.

With this, BEML's total order book stood at ₹16,284 crore as on June 30, 2026 providing strong revenue visibility and a robust foundation for sustained growth.

"Our performance in the first quarter reflects the strength of our business fundamentals and the progress we are making in our transformation journey.



Our focus remains on sharper execution, operational excellence, technology-led innovation and building deeper capabilities across our strategic business verticals.

"With a strong pipeline of opportunities and a growing presence across domestic and international markets, we remain confident of creating sustainable, long-term value for all our stakeholders," CMD Shantanu Roy said.

BEML serves India's core sectors like power, infrastructure, rail, metro, defence, aerospace and mining.

IAF band to perform at Param Yodha Sthal at India Gate complex

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Air Force band (IAF) is set to perform at the Param Yodha Sthal adjoining the National War Memorial on Sunday, ahead of the 80th Independence Day.

According to officials, the "spectacular display" aims to foster national pride through public engagement while celebrating 150 years of 'Vande Mataram'.

A team of musicians comprising 32 airmen and eight Agniveervayu, including three women, will perform at the venue, the defence ministry said.

"The musicians are set to take the stage with a performance that promises to be an unforgettable experience for the audience. With a repertoire of patriotic and soulful numbers, the IAF Band is set to raise the patriotic spirit with an energetic

performance," it said.

The band is scheduled to perform for an hour at the Public Plaza, Param Yodha Sthal, in the India Gate complex on August 9 evening, the officials said.

The principal conductor of the event will be Master Warrant Officer A Srihari, who will be assisted by Junior Warrant Officer Moon Deka, Warrant Officer Abhishek Paul, and Sergeant NT Singh, they said.



India ships 18 tonnes of makhana to Australia



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has shipped 18 tonnes of Mithila *makhana* by sea route from Bihar to Australia, the commerce ministry said on Saturday.

The consignment, sourced from *makhana* growers of Darbhanga district, is expected to strengthen the international presence of Bihar's flagship GI product while creating enhanced income opportunities for farmers through

export-led market access.

Bihar accounts for nearly 85 per cent of India's Makhana production.

To further strengthen the sector, a separate HS (harmonised system) Code for *makhana* came into effect from July 2025.

During 2025-26, India exported more than 7,000 metric tonnes of *makhana* and value-added *makhana* products to over 20 international destinations, including the USA, the Middle East and Africa.



Assam forest Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah participates in the Special Rhino Protection Force (SRPF) Raising Day celebration at Bagori Range of Kaziranga National Park and also paid tribute to Late Constable Partha Morang, one of SRPF's first personnel who lost his life in the line of duty and felicitated his bereaved wife

Technology, transparency key for urban cooperative banks to stay competitive: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Union Minister Amit Shah on Saturday urged urban cooperative banks to embrace technology, ensure transparency and modernise customer services to remain competitive. Speaking at the inauguration of the new office of the National Urban Cooperative Finance and Development Corporation Limited (NUCFDC) in Mumbai, he said ensuring the prosperity of customers will help the banks achieve growth.

The Union Home and Cooperation Minister also urged all urban cooperative banks to join the NUCFDC, the

apex umbrella organisation for the sector, within a year.

The NUCFDC serves as the umbrella organisation and self-regulatory body for Urban Cooperative Banks (UCBs) in India. Approved by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and headquartered in Mumbai, it provides capital, IT infrastructure and liquidity support to strengthen the cooperative banking sector.

"Our responsibility is to ensure that all banks become members of this organisation (NUCFDC), introduce technology, bring transparency, train staff, provide modern services to customers and sustain in the competition," he said.

Shah said that of the nearly



1,400 urban cooperative banks in the country, around 690 have already become members of the organisation, and added that the remaining UCBs should also become part of it within a year. Making India prosperous requires fostering prosperity among its people, the minister said, adding that

the capital market alone cannot fulfil this objective.

"We need to create a new system of self-employment simultaneously. Urban cooperative banks can do it and it is our responsibility," he said.

Shah said the idea of "cooperation to prosperity" does not merely mean making banks

financially stronger, but ensuring that customers become prosperous as well, which in turn would help banks grow.

Speaking about the RBI's role, Shah said there was a need to bridge the perception gap between the central bank and urban cooperative banks.

"The Reserve Bank has a different outlook towards urban cooperative banks, and our urban banks also look at the RBI differently. We have to come out of it," he said.

Drawing on his five-year experience as cooperation minister, Shah said the RBI had always extended proactive support whenever the cooperation sector approached it with confidence.

No charges for UPI users, vast majority of transactions to remain free for merchants as well: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Saturday categorically stated that consumers and small merchants will continue to enjoy free Unified Payments Interface (UPI) services to allay fears regarding the levy of charges on such transactions following the passage of a Bill to amend the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007.

However, nominal Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) for merchants will be applicable as and when charges are introduced.

"They will apply only to a limited set of merchant transactions, above a certain threshold, at a nominal rate,

far lower than debit or credit card MDRs," the finance ministry said in a statement.

The statement comes two days after the Lok Sabha passed a Bill to amend the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, which authorises the government to permit banks and other service providers to levy charges on payments through UPI and other notified electronic payment modes.

"Once the Parliament passes the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which proposes to amend Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the 'UPI and Services Steering Committee' headed by NPCI will decide on the

MDR, if any," it said.

The recent amendment to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act (PSS Act) has generated a debate, with some misinterpreting it as a move to impose charges on ordinary users, it said, adding, in reality, the amendment is an enabling provision designed to ensure UPI's long-term sustainability, technological advancement, and resilience against emerging risks.

Explaining the rationale, the statement said, with exponential transaction volumes, the system requires significant and continuous upgrades in cybersecurity, fraud prevention, and infrastructure.

The statement further said



that it was required for market expansion and self-sustainability.

It is necessary to increase competition by encouraging more companies to expand their operations, which requires a self-sustaining

revenue model, it said.

Reliance on subsidies alone is not viable for the next wave of growth, it said, adding that a balanced framework is required to ensure that UPI remains robust, inclusive, and future-ready.

Addressing concerns on narratives like external influences may be driving policy changes, the statement said, this is unfounded, completely false and misleading.

If external pressure had been a factor, the government would not have introduced UPI in 2016 or made it free of charge for both merchants as well as citizens since January 2020 and ensured that it became the world's largest real time interoperable payment system, it said.

The amendment should therefore be viewed in the context of the Government's broader objective of ensuring that India's digital payment infrastructure remains sustainable, competitive, innov-

ative and capable of serving the country's rapidly expanding digital economy, it said.

UPI is India's own innovation, and the government remains committed to keeping it free for citizens while ensuring its sustainability for decades to come, it added. India now stands at the cusp of the next wave of digital payments growth, it said, adding that to expand UPI further into rural and semi-urban areas and maintain competitiveness, the UPI ecosystem must be self-sustainable and affordable.

The amendment to the PSS Act is a forward-looking step to ensure that UPI continues to thrive as a secure, affordable, inclusive, and globally recog-

nised payment system, it said.

Since its launch in 2016-17, the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) has transformed India's digital economy into one of the most inclusive and dynamic payment ecosystems in the world, it said.

What began as a bold experiment in real-time, interoperable payments has now become a global benchmark, processing billions of transactions every month and reaching deep into the fabric of everyday life, it said.

Today, it said, UPI has grown into the world's largest real-time payment system, processing 2,366 crore transactions worth ₹29.9 lakh crore in July 2026 alone.

FROM THE WORLD

COLOMBIA

President backs oil, gas sector

Colombian President Abelardo de la Espriella pledged to revive the country's oil and gas sector, restore state-owned energy company Ecopetrol and strengthen the electricity system, arguing that energy security would be a cornerstone of his administration. De la Espriella said Colombia would pursue an energy transition – a shift away from oil, gas and coal toward cleaner energy sources such as wind and solar power – but insisted it must not come at the expense of the country's oil and gas industry. "I believe in the energy transition," he said. "But that transition must be built from strength, not from weakness, from self-sufficiency and not from dependence." The remarks reinforce a sharp shift from former President Gustavo Petro, who stopped awarding new oil and gas sector.

USA

Ex-Air Force official barred

The Pentagon revoked former US Air Force Secretary Frank Kendall's "eligibility" to access classified information and barred him from holding "any sensitive position," alleging Friday that he disclosed sensitive information about Air Force One's capabilities to the media. It follows reporting last month, including from The New York Times, on security concerns over the new, Qatari-gifted Air Force One, including that it lacked the advanced antimissile capabilities of its forebear. The plane underwent a \$400 million retrofit and upgrade, has been put into service domestically and President Donald Trump also flew on it to Türkiye last month. The Times reported that the president made the switch at the urging of the Secret Service and that the newer plane lacked some of the advanced security features of the older Air Force One aircraft.

IS-linked group kills 13 in Congo

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kinshasa

Militants affiliated with the Islamic State group attacked a village in Congo near the border with Uganda early on Saturday, killing at least 13 people and burning and looting homes, a local civil society group said. The attacks occurred in the village of Banana Ecole, a suburb of the territorial capital of Mambasa. Marie-Noelle Anotane, the head of the New Civil Society of Congo/Mambasa, and Sylvain Andali, a local resident, said that the Allied Democratic Forces, or ADF, were behind the violence. Both said the militants used known ADF tactics.



"This death toll of 13 civilians is only provisional because most residents aren't responding to calls, and searches are continuing in other surrounding villages," said Anotane. The attacks forced people to choose between staying or risking travel to other parts of the province where the fastest-spreading Ebola outbreak in history rages. "I decided to leave Mambasa for Bunia because I fear repeated attacks by the

ADF," said Andali. "Many of my neighbours have already died, and I must protect my life and the lives of my family." The ADF, which has roots in Uganda and pledged allegiance to the Islamic State group in 2019, has long operated in the border region. It is one of numerous groups operating in Congo, routinely attacking civilians. In July 2025, the group killed 66 people in eastern Congo in what the United Nations called a "bloodbath." The country also faces attacks from roughly 100 other rebel groups, most prominently the Rwanda-backed M23 rebel group, which has seized key cities in the eastern region.



Participants spray water on each others during a water gun festival in Seoul, South Korea

AP

Drone explodes near gas pipeline close to Romanian border: Radev

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Sofia

A drone entered Bulgarian airspace on Saturday and exploded close to an international gas pipeline shortly after crossing the border from Romania. Bulgaria's Prime Minister Rumen Radev said the drone exploded just after 5 am about 100 metres inside Bulgarian territory. It was not detected or identified while flying through either Romanian or Bulgarian airspace. "There are no casualties or damage to buildings. The area has been cordoned off. We continue to monitor the situation," Radev said following a Government emergency meeting. Radev said the unmanned aerial vehicle exploded around 200 metres from a Romanian compressor station, and about 1 kilometre from Bulgaria's compressor station on the Trans-Balkan gas pipeline. "We will continue to monitor the situation and strengthen surveillance. Following this



Bulgaria's Prime Minister Rumen Radev

incident, we will also redeploy border police anti-drone detection and countermeasure capabilities from the border with Turkey to the border with Romania," Radev said. It was unclear where the drone had originated or whether it was linked to Russia or Ukraine. The incident would be raised at a meeting of the North Atlantic Council early next week, Bulgaria's Defence Minister Dimitar Stoyanov said.

Need for accountability if people harmed in peaceful protest in PoK: UN

YOSHITA SINGH
United Nations

Expressing concern over the security situation in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), a spokesperson for UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres has highlighted the need for accountability for actions against people engaging in peaceful protest. The Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) region has been witnessing protests for several months over 12 contentious refugee seats, triggering a crackdown by security forces. The protests intensified with elections to the so-called assembly in the region starting at the end of last month amid allegations of widespread rigging. According to the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), a collective of activist groups, more than 40 people were killed during the first phase of polls on July 27.



Besides, it claims that some 400 protesters have been killed since the first week of June. Both claims have been dismissed by the Pakistan Government. The JAAC has alleged that the establishment manoeuvres the 12 refugee seats to install a prime minister of its choosing to lead the so-called Government in PoK.

India maintains that the entire Union Territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh are its integral and inalienable parts. New Delhi also asserts that Pakistan has been in "illegal and forcible occupation" of parts of these Union Territories. "The Secretary-General supports the work of his High Commissioner, and we certainly

hope that the pleas made by Mr Turk will be listened to," Deputy Spokesman for the Secretary-General Farhan Haq said here on Friday in response to a question . The UN High Commissioner for Human Rights Volker Turk had on July 17 expressed concern about the recent developments in PoK, calling for impartial and thorough investigation into the deaths of protesters, Pakistan's ban of the JAAC and arrest of its leaders. Turk had appealed for calm in PoK amid a wave of unrest ahead of regional elections at the end of the month, a statement issued in Geneva last month had said. On whether there will be calls for accountability from the authorities on the crackdown on protestors in the PoK, Haq said on Friday, "It's important that all authorities everywhere allow for peaceful protest, and certainly that is the

case here." "If there have been people harmed for engaging in peaceful protest, there needs to be accountability for that," Haq added. Turk's statement had specifically said that dozens of people, mostly protesters but also law enforcement personnel, were reportedly killed since June ahead of the vote for the Legislative Assembly starting July 27. The High Commissioner had called for prompt, thorough and impartial investigations into all deaths that have occurred due to the unrest, both amongst protesters and members of security forces. The JAAC – a movement behind the protests comprising traders, transporters, students, lawyers, activists and others – has been banned under anti-terrorism laws for allegedly threatening public order and security. There are 53

seats in the so-called PoK legislative assembly - 45 are directly elected, while eight are reserved for women, technocrats and clerics. Elections for the 45 seats are being held in three phases, with the first phase on July 27 and the second phase on August 2 marred by violent protests. The Shehbaz Sharif Government has dismissed the JAAC claim of over 400 deaths since June first week saying the figure is "overly exaggerated." "The number of the people killed in protests is in two digits. Moreover, security personnel have also lost their lives," PM's adviser Rana Sanaullah said in a TV statement recently. India on August 4 described the so-called local body elections in PoK a "complete farce," asserting that such "hollow" exercises cannot hide the ground reality in the region.

Senators head for exits without meeting Trump's demands for voting bill

LISA MASCAROAP
Washington

Senators headed for the exits in the predawn hours Saturday, ending for now a crushing standoff over President Donald Trump's demands that they stay in session to pass a strict proof-of-citizenship voting bill before the summer recess. While they wrapped up many key priorities in the overnight votes, advancing Trump's SAVE America Act was not among them. Instead, Republican senators who had brought the chamber to a standstill spoke to Trump late in the evening about an alternative plan:



Senators Mike Lee

They would try again to approve elements of the voting bill as part of a broader GOP budget package to fund the Iran war and replenish the Pentagon when they return to work in September. "Obviously, with the president at his direction,

this is what he wants to do," said Senator Ron Johnson of Wisconsin, the GOP budget committee chairman, flanked by Senators Mike Lee, R-Utah, and Rick Scott, R-Fla., after their phone call with the president. The sudden wind-down after weeks of Trump ramping up his demands shows just how deeply the president is able to reach into the halls of Congress to set the agenda or disrupt it, the executive directing the affairs of the legislative branch. While Trump is often seen as a de facto speaker of the House, he is invariably trying his hand at mastering the Senate.

Senate approves funding bill to avoid a shutdown before election

KEVIN FREKING/LISA MASCARO
Washington

The Senate in an overnight vote on Saturday approved a short-term measure to fund federal agencies into early December and avoid a potentially chaotic Government shutdown during the middle of campaign season. The late-summer action on a funding fix is unusual. Normally, Congress waits until the final days or hours of a funding deadline to pass short-term patches, but this time senators acted nearly two months before the end of the fiscal year on September 30. The 90-6 vote showed lawmakers are still smarting from the two historic shutdowns that occurred this past year and want to avoid another before voters go to the polls. Senate Majority Leader John Thune wanted the funding dealt with before senators went home for the next five weeks to focus on their reelection campaigns and



Senate Majority Leader John Thune

other matters. It got caught up with other issues that pushed votes into the night, but the bill had broad bipartisan support. The House will also have to approve the measure when members return from their August recess before it can go to President Donald Trump's desk for his signature.

Thai high school shooting death toll rises to 8 after girl dies

JINTAMAS SAKSORNCHAI
Bangkok

A school girl died from critical wounds on Saturday after a student opened fire at a high school and his home outside Bangkok the day before, bringing the death toll from the attack to at least eight people. The 14-year-old opened fire at around 10 am Friday at Debsirin Nonthaburi School in Nonthaburi province northwest of the Thai capital before apparently taking his own life. He also appeared to have killed his two grandparents at his family home earlier in the morning, officials said. The girl, 12, died



after hospitalisation, the Health Ministry said. The school had posted a message on Facebook Friday seeking blood donations for two stu-

dents, including the girl, who was in seventh grade. Fourteen people remain hospitalised, of whom seven remain in critical condition

Saturday, according to Thailand's Health Ministry. Most of those wounded were between 12 and 14 years old. Relatives claimed the bodies of eight people from Bangkok's Institute of Forensic Medicine: five school staff, the accused shooter, and his grandparents. Emergency workers brought out a coffin and loaded it onto an ambulance, which will transport the bodies to their hometowns for funeral rites. The young girl's body is still to be released. Wiroom Supasingsiripreecha, head of the institute, said most of the victims suffered a single fatal gunshot wound to a

vital area, including the chest or head. He said the gunshot wound found on the alleged shooter was consistent with the weapon he had used. More detailed forensic findings, including toxicology results, are expected later, he said. Officials said the gun, described as small and compact, was legally registered to the boy's grandfather. There were reports that the boy, who lived with his grandparents, had shown signs of stress connected to school, although some of his relatives told Thai media that they were unaware of any troubles he might have been facing. The co-educational state school, which has about 3,000 students enrolled aged 12 to 18, said all classes would be suspended between August 10-14 and school staff were instructed to work from home during that time.

A few mourners laid flowers Saturday morning at the school's gate, where a few police officers could be seen. Charin Siriananchai brought his two sons, ages 9 and 6, to pay their respects. He said while his sons do not study here, he lives in the neighbourhood and drives past this school almost every day, often stopping to allow students to cross the road.

Pakistan-Turkiye-Saudi defence deal could reduce US role in West Asia

M ZULQERNAIN
Lahore

The trilateral defence pact signed by Pakistan, Türkiye and Saudi Arabia could significantly reduce the United States' strategic role in West Asia, according to some Pakistan-based defence analysts. The three countries on Friday signed a joint defence agreement under which an attack against one of them will be treated as an attack against all of them, amid increasing security concerns in the wake of escalating tensions in West Asia. Defence analyst Abdullah Hameed Gul, son of a former ISI chief, said the pact has emerged against the backdrop of growing doubts in the Gulf region about the United States' ability to provide security guarantees to regional allies. "The US had 27 military bases in the Gulf countries, and 17 of them were destroyed by Iran during the recent US-Iran

war. This led people in the region to question whether the Americans could actually protect them. That created the need for such an agreement," Gul said. With this pact, said Gul, America's "role in the region has been minimised — or is effectively over." "Qatar and Kuwait will soon also join similar agreements with Pakistan," said Gul, adding that Gulf countries had realised that Israel, rather than Iran, posed a greater security challenge to them. Foreign affairs expert Muhammad Mehdi said the pact has altered perceptions of Pakistan's position in the international arena. "Pakistan's standing in the world has changed. The world now sees Pakistan as having a major role to play in the Middle East and Central Asia. With Türkiye joining the three-nation arrangement, Pakistan will also be viewed differently in Europe," he said.





Satellite images show leaking tanker sinking off Oman

SARAH EL DEEB ■ Beirut

Satellite images reviewed by *The Associated Press* show that a sanctioned tanker carrying nearly a million barrels of oil appears to be increasingly submerged in water off the coast of Oman, where it has been grounded for weeks, while leaking ever more oil into the surrounding sea.

Crude oil has been leaking and spreading quickly in recent days from the tanker Caroline Bezengi, reaching the shores of Qibliyah Island off Oman's southwest coast. By August 7, the spill was covering nearly 800 square km (309 square miles), according to Wim Zwijnenburg, an environmental expert for



PAX, a Dutch organisation that tracks environment in conflicts. Greenpeace Germany has also said the

spill is drastically increasing, indicating deterioration of the vessel's condition. "Satellite imagery analysis

suggests that the oil spill covered 45 square km (17 square miles) up until July 26. By August 2, it had expanded to around 150 square km (58 square miles), and imagery from August 4 indicates that it now extends across roughly 600 square km (232 square miles)," said Nina Noelle, an environmental disaster expert at Greenpeace Germany.

The affected area is part of the Arabian Sea reserve, a marine protected area and host to wildlife, including endangered petrels and the rare Arabian Sea humpback whale.

The 247-metre (899-foot) Caroline Bezengi has been grounded off Qibliyah Island

in southwest Oman for two months. The tanker's crew reported an explosion on board on June 8, according to media reports.

It is believed to be part of Russia's "shadow fleet" and has been sanctioned by the British Government and the European Union for carrying Russian oil.

It had left the Black Sea port of Novorossiysk, in Russia, in May, according to geospatial data tracking company SynMax Maritime.

The vessel's owners are believed to be Shanghai-based, according to Greenpeace and other reports. Satellite images dated August 5 show an oil sheen trailing northeast of

the tanker, aground off the rocky coastline, and surrounding the island.

In the images, the vessel appears to be partly submerged, noticeably more so than on a photo taken on July 31. July and August are peak monsoon season in the area.

On Thursday, the Government of Oman said it was responding to the incident. It was not immediately clear if the authorities have reached the tanker and whether there are efforts to salvage it or stop the leaking crude oil. The statement published by the Oman News Agency said authorities were observing the area through satellite images, field surveys and technical models. (AP)

Gurcharan Das awarded Lifetime Libertarian Award



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

Renowned author Gurcharan Das was on Saturday awarded the prestigious Lifetime Libertarian Award for his "lasting contribution to the advancement of liberty", becoming the first Indian writer to receive the honour.

The award was presented by freedom advocacy network Liberty International at its 40th World Conference in Kathmandu, Nepal.

Accepting the award, the 82-year-old author said he was "delighted" to receive the honour and spoke about the idea of "inner freedom", which he described as "India's unique contribution to the Western idea of liberalism".

"How often does life reward you for something you believe right in your bones?" he said. The award caps a

career spent shaping India's economic and moral discourse in defence of freedom, entrepreneurship, and individual responsibility - themes that have run through Das' work for over three decades, according to a statement issued by the organisers. The cornerstone of Das' literary contribution is a quartet on the four classical Indian aims of life that he interprets as a "timeless ideal of human flourishing in the contemporary world", the statement said.

These include India Unbound, The Difficulty of Being Good, Kama: The Riddle of Desire and Another Sort of Freedom. He has also written a novel, a book of essays and an anthology of plays. Das has also edited a 17-volume economic and business history of India for Penguin.

Lebanon authorities detain Bashar Assad-era officer

BASSEM MROUE ■ Beirut

Lebanese authorities detained a former senior Syrian military officer who commanded an army division under ousted President Bashar Assad and might hand him over to Damascus on alleged crimes that he committed, Lebanese judicial and security officials said on Saturday.

After the fall of Assad's Government in December 2024 when Syrian insurgent groups captured his seat of power in Damascus, a number of military and security officers fled to neighbouring Lebanon, where some still remain.

If Major General Adel Issa is sent to his home country, it will be the first time Beirut has handed back an Assad-era official.

Since the ouster, dozens of members of Assad's security agencies blamed for atrocities have been arrested and put on trial in



Syria. The officials said Issa, who once commanded Syria's military 17th Division, went to the Syrian embassy in Beirut on Friday for some paperwork. Embassy officials

contacted Lebanon's prosecutor's office to tell them that Issa is wanted in Syria, the officials said. The Lebanese Public Prosecutor's Office dispatched a team from the Central Criminal Investigation Department and arrested Issa and transferred him to the Beirut Palace of Justice detention centre, said the officials.

The four judicial and two security officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media about the matter.

Issa told his interrogators in Beirut that he crossed to Lebanon illegally after Assad's fall but denied all accusations. The officials added that since Issa was detained on Friday, which is the weekend in Syria, Lebanese judicial authorities will wait for Syrian authorities to send his charge sheet on Monday.

The officials said Lebanese authorities will study the case and decide

on whether they will hand over Issa to Syrian authorities next week.

The Britain-based Syrian Observatory for Human Rights, a war monitor, said after commanding the Syrian army's 17th Division, Issa was moved in 2015 to command ground forces in the eastern province of Deir el-Zour that borders Iraq and that he retired in late 2016.

Syria's conflict, which began with anti-Government protests in March 2011 before turning into a civil war, left half a million people dead and over 1 million wounded. Assad and his powerful younger brother, Maher, fled to Russia following the ouster.

Assad's cousin Atef Najib, who was blamed for atrocities that helped trigger the uprising in Syria 15 years ago, was put on trial in April. The ruling in his case is expected next week. (AP)

Iran attacks vessel in Strait of Hormuz, says UAE

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

A vessel owned by Abu Dhabi's state-owned ADNOC oil and gas company was attacked while transiting the Strait of Hormuz, Emirati authorities said. The Foreign Ministry said Iran fired the missile as part of attacks on commercial shipping.

ADNOC said in a statement that there were no casualties following the attack early on Saturday. The company said over a dozen of its vessels have been attacked by missiles and drones while passing through the strait since the United States and Israel launched the war on Iran in February. One crew member has been killed and 20 others wounded, it said.

ADNOC didn't elaborate on where the attack took place or on any damage.

Later, the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Centre said a vessel east of the town of Khasab, Oman, had been struck by a projectile that caused a fire that was put out, with the vessel and crew safe. It was not immediately clear whether this was the ADNOC incident.

TWO DRONES SPOTTED FLYING OVER GERMAN MILITARY BASE

STEFANIE DAZIO ■ Berlin

Two drones were spotted flying over a German military base in the western part of the country earlier this week, just two days after a drone carrying explosives was found at a key cargo airport, the German Armed Forces said on Saturday.

Security surveillance at the Bundeswehr base in Mechernich reported seeing two drones around 10 pm on Thursday, according to a statement from the German Joint Force Command. The sightings were confirmed and military police forces deployed to the site.

The military said the Euskirchen police department has opened an investigation. The police did not immediately respond to a request for comment and the military did not release additional details.

Recently, drone sightings over civilian and cargo airports have been more widely reported. Last year, mysterious drone flights over the airspace of European Union member countries alarmed the public and authorities, and also prompted the cancellation of dozens of flights that stranded thousands of passengers. Thursday's sighting of the two drones came after a drone with explosives was found at Germany's Leipzig/Halle Airport shortly before midnight on Tuesday. The device was defused but German Interior Minister Alexander Dobrindt said the incident posed a "new quality of danger."

Leipzig/Halle is a major hub for international freight and for providing support to Ukraine. The planes that regularly use it include Ukrainian Antonov transport aircraft.

It is also home to NATO's Strategic Airlift International Solution, or SALIS, which is currently operational almost every day in delivering equipment to NATO battle groups along its eastern flank from Finland to Romania and supporting EU and alliance nation missions. (AP)



Ukraine honours collector of souls killed while recovering war dead

VOLODYMYR YURCHUK/
EFREM LUKATSKY ■ Kyiv

Ukraine paid tribute on Saturday to Oleksiy Yukov, a volunteer who spent more than two decades recovering the bodies of civilians and soldiers - many of them Russian - killed by war. He was 40.

An Orthodox Christian service was held at the Cathedral of Saint Volodymyr, in central Kyiv, where thousands of people gathered to pay their respects following his death in a landmine explosion during a recovery mission on August 5.

Yukov founded the Platsdarm ("bridgehead") organisation because he believed all the dead require a proper burial. He became known as a "collector of souls." Yukov, from the



war-torn Donbas region, was a martial arts instructor. He began recovering the dead as a teenager after encountering the remains of Soviet and Russian soldiers from World War II.

Platsdarm's volunteers go into fields and forests, among ruins and across territory, where the ground is often mined. Yukov suffered leg injuries and lost an eye in a mine blast

in 2022. Still recovering from those injuries, he returned to the fields.

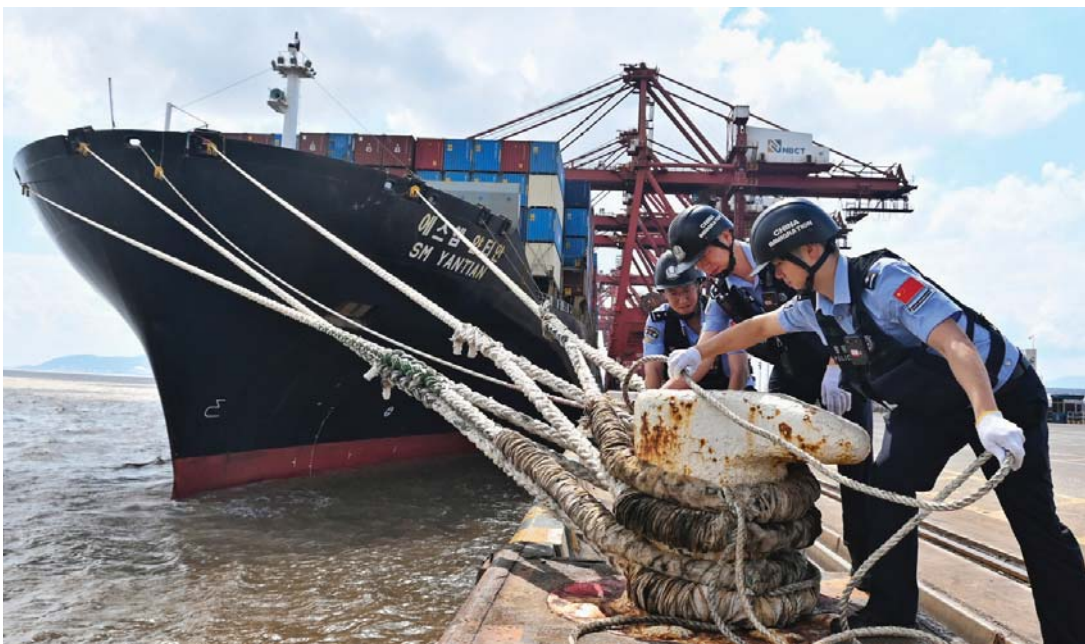
In a social media post last month, Yukov described the landscape in which he worked.

"Remote mines, shelling, drones - everything is against you. But you go and do everything to ensure that every soul returns home," he said.

He also addressed those who believed Russian bodies should simply be left behind: "When they say: 'Let them rot,' I do not agree. This is how we fight for every soul."

Yukov spoke of his work in religious terms, saying a body was a soul waiting to go home.

"This is action," he wrote. "Action every day in the fields, in the forest belts, among the ruins, where your life can end at any moment." (AP)



Police officers check the mooring lines of a vessel ahead of Typhoon Dolphin in Beilun District of Ningbo City, China

AP

US reviews proposal to end 60-day grace period for foreign workers to find new jobs

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

The US is reviewing a proposal to eliminate the 60-day window for foreign workers holding non-immigrant visas to find employment after a job loss, a move that may force them to leave the country immediately.

A proposal from the Department of Homeland Security is currently under review at the federal Office of Management and Budget (OMB), according to its website.

If finalised, the proposed regulation would eliminate the 60-day grace period accorded to certain principal non-immigrants and their dependents if the principal's employment ceases before their period of stay expires.

Further details of the proposal are not immediately known. The 60-day grace period was introduced in 2017 to allow foreign workers and their dependents to stay in the US while searching for new employment after a job loss.

Immigration consultants said the Department of Homeland Security has the discretion to



shorten or refuse the grace period, but has rarely done so. The rule applies to E-1, E-2, E-3, H-1B, H-1B1, L-1, O-1 and TN categories of non-immigrant visa holders and their dependents.

The grace period also allows US employers to more easily facilitate employment changes for existing or newly recruited non-immigrant workers. If the 60-day grace period is eliminated, foreign nationals whose employment ceases prematurely and their dependents would generally be required to depart the US immediately. (PTT)

Iran's leaders believe a victory is within reach, and that time is on their side

JOSEPH KRAUSS/
AMIR-HUSSEIN RADJY ■ Cairo

The Strait of Hormuz is, by some accounts, named for a Zoroastrian deity destined to emerge victorious after a 9,000-year standoff with an adversary.

Iran's leaders feel their own victory is at hand and won't require the same epic patience.

They are betting that military pressure will ultimately force the United States to accept their control over the crucial waterway for global energy - and that time is on their side. They know about the diminishing stockpiles of key US weapons such as advanced missile interceptors. They know the war is deeply unpopular with Americans. They know that as long as the strait is largely closed,

the price of gas and other goods will stay high ahead of US congressional elections in November. They know that trying to open it by force would be costly and may require American ground troops. They know their Houthi allies in Yemen could widen the war and disrupt another major trade route.

By that logic, US President Donald Trump has no choice but to capitulate. But Iran's strategy carries risks. Trump points to strikes that have decimated Iran's top leadership, navy and air force. He alternates between threatening escalation and saying talks are going well. Iran's own economy has been battered, in part because of a US blockade.

Iranians rose up in mass protests just months ago and could do so again. And Iran's leaders need only look to how Trump's "short-term



excursion" to the Middle East has bogged down to be reminded that wars rarely turn out as expected.

Iran says it is close to reaching a deal with Oman to manage the strait, which runs between the two countries. But it would be conditioned on the US lifting its blockade, so even if there are no direct negotiations - as Iran says - Trump would have to approve.

It's unclear whether the deal would allow Iran to charge fees. But it would formalise its control over what had been an open international waterway before the war, one that carried a fifth of the world's traded oil and gas.

Abdolreza Davari, an analyst who once advised former President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, said Iran's effective control of the strait has given it leverage with the US and

regional countries that can help guarantee its security.

"More than revenue from the strait, Iran wants to confirm its management and sovereignty over the strait," he said by phone from Tehran. Formal control over even part of the strait would be a clear win for Iran and a loss for the US, which has yet to accomplish some of its various and shifting goals in the war.

It would also deal a blow to global norms on freedom of navigation and set a precedent that much of the world would find disturbing - that nations can shut down trade choke points at will.

China, which buys oil from Iran and has influence over it, said as recently as May that "normal and safe passage" through the strait should be restored. (AP)

BRIEFLY

Brighton sends Buonanotte on loan to Spanish club Elche



Brighton midfielder Facundo Buonanotte will play for Spanish team Elche this season in what is the Argentinian playmaker's fourth loan spell since joining the Premier League club in January 2023.

The 21-year-old Buonanotte, who signed with Brighton from Rosario Central, was loaned to Leicester for the 2024-25 season and split last season between Chelsea and Leeds. Buonanotte played regularly for Leicester but had trouble getting minutes at both Chelsea and Leeds.

"Facundo is a talented young player who has continued to develop since joining the club," Brighton sporting director Mike Cave said in the team's announcement late Friday. "This loan gives him the opportunity to play regular football in one of Europe's top leagues."

Elche finished 15th in La Liga last season. "We believe this move will provide an excellent environment for him to gain further experience, and we'll continue to monitor his progress closely throughout the season," Cave said. Buonanotte made his Argentina senior team debut in 2023 against Indonesia and played again for La Albiceleste in 2024 against El Salvador. (AP)

'Ayush wanted Shi Yu Qi in World Championships draw'



Ayush Shetty's daunting World Championships opener against China's world Number1 Shi Yu Qi could work in the Indian's favour as his opponent is not currently at his best and the home crowd could give the youngster an edge, feels his coach Sagar Chopda.

Shetty, who announced himself on the big stage with a runner-up finish at the Badminton Asia Championships earlier this year, faces the toughest opening-round assignment against Shi Yu Qi, who outclassed the Indian in the continental final in straight games. "If you look at it, it's probably one of the toughest draws anybody could get. But playing Shi Yu Qi, Ayush has nothing to lose," Chopda, the head coach at the Centre for Badminton Excellence (CBE) in Bengaluru, formerly known as the Prakash Padukone Badminton Academy (PPBA), told PTI Videos. (PTI)

Davis Cup: Korea to host India on hard courts in Qualifier Round 2



South Korea have opted to host India on hard courts at the Olympic Tennis Centre in Seoul on September 18-19 in the Davis Cup Qualifiers Round 2, setting up a potentially intriguing tie between two closely matched teams.

India are currently ranked 19th and Korea 16th in the Davis Cup standings, while the Koreans hold a slender 6-5 advantage in their head-to-head record. India will pick their squad on August 10 for the crucial tie. The last meeting between the two sides came a decade ago, when India prevailed 4-1 in Chandigarh in 2016 in an Asia/Oceania Group 1 tie played on grass. Korea players are traditionally more comfortable on hard courts and that's why India had deliberately opted for grass when the teams last met. India earned their place in the second round with a dramatic 3-2 victory over the Netherlands in Bengaluru in February. Dhakshinewar Suresh was the hero, winning both his singles rubbers and partnering Yuki Bhambri to victory in the doubles. (PTI)

Former gymnasts write to ministry, seek inquiry in alleged irregularities in SOM roster

AMIT KUMAR DAS

New Delhi

Former international gymnasts, including multiple-time national champion Rakesh Patra, have urged the Sports Ministry to order an independent inquiry into alleged procedural irregularities in the Gymnastics Federation of India's preparation of the Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit (SOM) roster. In separate letters to Sports Secretary Hari Ranjan Rao on July 30, Patra and another former international gymnast made similar allegations that the federation's actions violated provisions of the National Sports Governance Act, 2025 and the

rules framed under it.

"I respectfully request the Ministry to order an independent inquiry into the process adopted by the Gymnastics Federation of India for preparation of the Roster of Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit," Patra, a multiple-time national champion who represented India at five World Championships besides the Commonwealth and Asian Games, appealed in the letter in possession of PTI. "Call for all records, including notifications, applications received, scrutiny reports, minutes of meetings, evaluation criteria and all documents relating to the preparation of the roster. "Examine whether the

Win at all costs: 1975 heroes urge to end WC wait

MONA PARTHSARATHI

New Delhi

India's 1975 World Cup heroes Ashok Kumar and Aslam Sher Khan have urged the national hockey team to put the country ahead of individual ambitions, saying an uncompromising desire to win for the nation can help end the 51-year wait for a World Cup medal.

India has won the men's World Cup only once, in Kuala Lumpur in 1975 when they defeated Pakistan 2-1 in the final. Ashok scored the winning goal in the 51st minute to script one of the most memorable moments in Indian hockey history. His message to the current side is simple. "I would say to the Indian team: keep in mind that victory or defeat will not be yours, but your country's. This will automatically inspire you. This 51-year wait has been too long, and now

we have to win a medal," Ashok said while talking to PTI. The World Cup is scheduled to be held in the Netherlands and Belgium from August 15 to 30.

Aslam, who scored the important equaliser in the semi-final against Malaysia, believes the current players need to approach the World Cup with the same sense of patriotism that drove the 1975 team. "When we entered the World Cup, our country was like our mother, and we played with that same passion. You too must enter the field with the thought that we are playing for our mother, and our passion must be such that we will win at all costs," he said.

The two former players know what it takes to recover from disappointment. Ashok and Aslam were part of the Indian teams that won bronze at the 1971 World Cup and silver in 1973.



Missing out on the title in those tournaments only intensified their hunger for gold in 1975. "When we lost the semi-final in 1971, coach Balbir Singh Sr cried so much that it was difficult to calm him down. Such was the passion to win for the country," Ashok recalled. "When we won silver in 1973, there was huge disappointment of missing out on gold. I even wondered how I would show these medals to my father and uncle. I would feel ashamed to return home

with a bronze or silver," said Ashok, son of legendary hockey player Dhyan Chand and nephew of Roop Singh.

The disappointment also created a unique atmosphere at the team's camp in Chandigarh ahead of the Kuala Lumpur tournament.

"When we were going to Kuala Lumpur, there was a camp in Chandigarh where players from all over the country were playing together for a common goal because we had missed out on gold in the previous two

ESFI announces contingent for BRICS Esports title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

The Esports Federation of India (ESFI) on Saturday announced the final contingents for the BRICS Esports Championship 2026 to be held in Moscow, and the Global Esports Games (GEG26) in Los Angeles following the conclusion of the National Esports Championships (NESC).

The National Esports Championships, which concluded on August 5, served as India's official selection tournament, bringing together the country's top esports athletes to earn the right to represent the nation at two of the world's premier multi-title esports events. For the BRICS Esports Championship, scheduled to be held from September 9-15 at the VK Play Arena in Moscow, organised by the Russian Esports Federation, India will field a two-member TEKKEN 8 contingent. National champion Arsalan Wani secured his berth after emerging victo-



rious at the NESC BRICS qualifier and will join Gurashish Singh, who was the winner of NESC 2026 (Asian Games) as part of the Team India.

Shubham finished as the first runner-up, while Ashish claimed the second runner-up position in the qualifier.

Meanwhile, India finalised its roster for the Global Esports Games 2026 in Los Angeles, organised by the Global Esports Federation (GEF). Team India will compete across multiple esports titles spanning PC, console, and mobile platforms, further strengthening

the country's presence on the global esports stage.

"The BRICS Esports Championship and the Global Esports Games are invaluable opportunities for our athletes as we build towards the Asian Games. Competing against some of the world's best players reflects the growing depth of India's esports talent while giving our athletes the exposure needed to sharpen their skills, perform under pressure and raise their competitive standards.

"These experiences will play a vital role in preparing Team India for future inter-

national competitions, including the upcoming Asian Games," said Lokesh Suji, General Secretary, Esports Federation of India and vice president, Asian Esports Federation (AESF).

At the Global Esports Games, India will compete in Counter-Strike 2, where Diamond Dogs secured the national berth after defeating Friedup Gaming in the grand final. The squad comprises Ritesh Sarda (Captain), Hrishikesh Shenoy, Gourav Panwar, Garvit Nehra and Yash Kumar Singh.

In Clash Royale (Open), Devershi Kumar Kulhara emerged champion, followed by Heer Chawda and Mohamed Rizal S, while Shagun Srivastava won the women's category ahead of Nikita S. India's NBA 2K contingent will feature Shubham Sharma (Captain), Ashutosh Kumar and Sumer Singh Sandhu, while the Rocket League team comprises Abhai Ponna (Captain), Jayanth Engineer and Aditeya Amol Srivastav.

Ashish opens India's medal account with javelin silver at World U20 Championships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Eugene (USA)

Ashish Yadav won a silver in the men's javelin throw event to open India's medal account, while national senior record holder Pooja Singh qualified for the women's high jump final at the World Athletics U20 Championships here.

Yadav's third round throw of 74.09m fetched him the silver medal while T Dharanidharan, the other Indian in the fray in the men's javelin throw finals on Friday, finished sixth with 72.35m. Yadav's effort was 40cm short of his personal best of 74.49m, which he had recorded during the Indian Open Throws Competition in Patiala in March. The 19-year-old Yadav became the second Indian, after two-time Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra, to win a silver in the event. Chopra had won gold and set the still-standing world junior record of 86.48m in the 2016 edition in Poland. The gold medal

went to South Africa's Jan-Hendrik Heymans who sent his spear to 80.50m, the season's U20 world lead, in his sixth and final attempt. Dominica's Addison James clinched the bronze medal with a throw of 73.89m.

Mohammed Ashfaq, who broke the U20 national record during the men's 400m first round heat race a day earlier with a time of 45.81 seconds, finished eighth, clocking 46.20 seconds in the finals. American Jayden Deleon won the gold with a championships record time of 44.47 seconds, while compatriot Quincy Wilson took the silver with 44.62 seconds. South Africa's Leendert Koekemoer clinched the bronze with a time of 44.96 seconds.

Pooja qualified for the final round in the women's high jump event, sailing over 1.79m on day three of the meet.

All 14 athletes across two qualification groups, who managed to clear 1.79m, were awarded places in the



final. The 19-year-old Pooja holds the national senior record of 1.93m.

In the men's long jump, both Shahnavaz Khan and Jithin Arjuna made it to the finals after the qualification round. Shahnavaz finished fourth in qualification Group A and fifth overall with a 7.73m jump in his third and final attempt. Jithin also advanced, finishing 12th overall and taking the last available spot, with his

7.57m jump in his third and final attempt.

Italy's Daniele Inzoli was the only athlete across the two qualification groups to breach the automatic qualification distance of 8m with an effort of 8.15m.

Poonam, however, failed to qualify for the women's javelin final after finishing eighth in her qualification group and 13th overall with the day's best throw of 48.81m.

World Cups," Aslam said.

There was also an unwavering belief within the squad. "We never considered ourselves inferior to anyone, whether it was Germany, Holland or Australia. This confidence is what is needed, and with this passion, no one can stop this team," said Aslam, who later represented India at the 1976 Montreal Olympics. For Aslam, the 1975 campaign was also a test of personal resilience.

Having spent most of the tournament on the sidelines, he said the frustration of not getting an opportunity became almost unbearable.

"I spent most of the time away. I sat there, and the personal agony was so intense that I would tear up every night before going to sleep for not getting a chance to play," he recalled. That frustration eventually turned into a defining moment.

"That two-week agony led me to score a goal in the last 15 minutes of the semi-final," Aslam said. Aslam, however, believes the current team must understand that success at the Olympics and the World Cup comes with different pressures. The Harmanpreet Singh-led side has won bronze medals at two successive Olympic Games, at Tokyo in 2021 and Paris in 2024. "However, the dynamics of the Olympics are different from those of the World Cup, which must be kept in mind," he said.

He also pointed out that the Tokyo Olympics were held under the shadow of the COVID-19 pandemic, but India successfully repeated its Olympic medal-winning performance in Paris. "If we can play with the same spirit as we did at the Paris Olympics, India is sure to be on the podium after 51 years," he said. (PTI)

Ashmita Chaliha reaches maiden BWF World Tour final at Korea Masters



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

Ashmita Chaliha continued her impressive run at the Korea Masters Super 300, overcoming teenage compatriot Rakshitha Ramraj 21-13 16-21 21-13 to reach her maiden BWF World Tour singles final, here on Saturday. The 26-year-old Indian, who returned to competition in May after a three-month layoff due to a medial meniscus tear in her right knee, has enjoyed a strong comeback on the BWF Tour, including a semifinal appearance at the Macau Open.

World Ranked 50 Ashmita, who trains under Park Tae-sang at the National center of excellence, Guwahati, will now battle China's Han Qianxi for the title in the second game.

The World Ranked 35 Qian Xi, seeded fourth, battled past 22-20, 18-21, 21-14 in a one-hour five-minute battle in the other semifinal.

Ashmita's run also marks back-to-back BWF World Tour finals for Indians, with Tanvi Sharma having won the Taipei Open last Sunday.

Indian shuttlers have now made finals across several events this season, with Ayush Shetty at the Asia Championships, Lakshya Sen at the All England, Devika Sihag at the Thailand Masters, Kidambi Srikanth at the US Open, Tanvi at the Taipei Open, PV Sindhu at the Japan Open, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty at the Singapore Open, and now Ashmita at the Korea Masters. Ashmita, who had stunned top seed and world Number 22 Hina Akechi of Japan in the quarterfinals, came out aggressively and quickly moved from 2-2 to 6-2 in the opening game.

She then reeled off five

straight points to establish a 13-6 lead before closing the game out 21-13.

Rakshitha, who had upset third seed and compatriot Tanvi Sharma in the quarterfinals after coming from a game down, responded strongly. The 19-year-old Pullela Gopichand Academy trainee raced to a 4-1 lead. Ashmita struggled to control the lifts and went long twice, besides finding the net, to fall 3-8 behind. Another lift going long gave Rakshitha a five-point advantage. A brutal smash at 6-12 down from the left-handed Ashmita was the first convincing shot from the Indian in the second game. Another straight smash, a return of serve going into the net and a long lift from Rakshitha meant Ashmita narrowed the gap to 12-13. Despite the Assamese shuttler finding a second wind, Rakshitha managed to keep her nose ahead at 17-13 after hurrying her opponent.

At 18-14, Rakshitha sealed another tight rally with a cross-court smash. Ashmita responded with her own jumping cross-court smash. A weak lift was dispatched with disdain by Rakshitha to grab four game points, and she converted immediately to take the match to the decider.

Back on her winning side, Ashmita made a dominant start, surging to a 9-1 lead quickly with three smashes. Rakshitha also made a few unforced errors. She made a net error next as Ashmita took an overwhelming 11-3 advantage at the final interval. The change of sides once again brought a change of fortune for Rakshitha as she started dominating the rallies and Ashmita became error-prone. The Hyderabad-based Indian narrowed the gap to 7-12 before Ashmita again found her bearings to move to 15-7.



Former international gymnasts Rakesh Patra

FILE PHOTO

process adopted by GFI is in conformity with the National Sports Governance Act, 2025 and the Rules made thereunder. Take appropriate disciplinary actions against the GFI if the process is found to be unfair and illegal," he added.

Patra also requested the Ministry to "direct the GFI to

publish all governing regulations, eligibility criteria and evaluation methodology in advance." Another former international gymnast, who requested anonymity, also submitted a similar complaint to the Ministry, bringing to its notice "irregularities and unfair practices with respect to

Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit (SOM) in violation of the National Sports Governance Act." One of the allegations related to what the complainants described as the backdating of notifications and an arbitrary extension of the application deadline.

"The President, GFI issued a first notification dated 30th April 2026 seeking candidature within 60 days ie by 29th June 2026," the former gymnasts wrote. "However just a few days before the original deadline the contents of that notification were changed with the deadline updated to 2nd July 2026 without any other changes to the letter including its date and reference number.

"This appears to be a classic case of backdating of official notifications seriously compromising the integrity of the process." GFI President Sudhir Mital said: "Because names had not come by that time and it says at least minimum 40 — 20 men, 20 women, so had extended it."

However, an email sent by GFI to its affiliated state associations on June 30 stated: "We are delighted to receive an overwhelming response to the applications, given the encouraging interest, we have decided to extend the application deadline until 2 July 2026, 10 pm (22:00 hrs), allowing more applicants the opportunity to register." Another point

raised by the complaints was "Ineligible sportspersons included in the Roaster."

According to the complaints, two athletes — Ashish Kumar and Aditya Rana — were included in the published SOM roster despite being ineligible under the National Sports Governance Rules, 2026.

The complaints said that both the gymnasts had competed in the Senior Artistic Gymnastics National Championships held in Bhubaneswar earlier this year, whereas the rules require applicants to have retired from competitive sport for at least one year before applying. Documents of the Senior Artistic Gymnastics National

Championships show that Railways' Aditya Rana and Uttar Pradesh's Ashish Kumar featured in the competition held in Bhubaneswar from April 25 to May 3 this year.

"We have asked him because he (Ashish) said that he didn't play. So, we asked him to give us a response and explain. So, we are waiting for it. And if he (Ashish) has played, then he will be out of it," GFI president Mital said.

The complaints also alleged that the federation invited applications for SOM roster without first publishing regulations or criteria governing the selection process, leaving it open to arbitrary decision-making. (PTI)

Padikkal seals spot with stylish hundred as Jaiswal, Pant fail

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Devdutt Padikkal assured his spot in India's playing eleven for the opening Test with a stylish century on the second day of the warm-up match against Sri Lanka Cricket XI, while seasoned Rishabh Pant and his understudy Dhruv Jurel failed to make the most of favourable batting conditions.

At the end of the second day, India finished its first innings at 357 for eight in 90 overs. Padikkal's artistic

unbeaten 142 and a gritty 63 (retired out) by veteran Ravindra Jadeja were the highlights, while Manav Suthar (41) also impressed with the bat on his maiden overseas international assignment.

The pitch had become much easier to bat on, and Padikkal took full advantage, hitting 18 delectable boundaries to show that he is ready to reclaim his rightful place now that first-choice Number 3 batter Sai Sudharsan has been ruled out of the series after failing to recover in time from his big-toe injury.

With Yashasvi Jaiswal (0) falling off the second delivery of the day while attempting to flash at left-arm seamer Vishwa Fernando (1/42), KL Rahul (40) and Padikkal added 96 for the second wicket. While Rahul played himself in, the sinewy Padikkal was a treat to watch, opening with a couple of cover drives off fuller deliveries before unleashing some delectable cuts both in front of and behind point. He was particularly severe on right arm pacer Ishitha Wijesundara who was hit for multiple

boundaries. Anything short from pacers or spinners was pulled with a lot of disdain. The famous 'Nataraja Shot' also came out of closet against the pacers.

The hallmark of Padikkal's batting was the extra second he almost seems to have while deciding on his execution. His defence has also got tighter and the footwork against spinners has been exemplary. A pull shot off off-spinner Ramesh Mendis brought up his ton in just 121 balls before he was asked to retire. By then, he had added

72 runs for the third wicket with Jadeja, who again showed why he is a valuable asset as a middle order batter overseas even as his spin bowling stocks have depleted quite considerably.

The biggest disappointment of the day was certainly Rishabh Pant (2) who once again played an indiscreet shot against off-spinner Mendis (2/77) trying to hit him against the turn over long-on. The leading edge flew to long-off. If Pant perished going for the offensive, Dhruv Jurel's (1) technical ineptness against

off-spinner was exposed once again after the South Africa Test series.

A forward defensive prod and the inside edge flew to short square leg fielder who caught it on second attempt. But Manav Suthar, who is impressing everyone with his heart and commitment joined Jadeja as the duo added 76 to steady the ship. Towards the end, Padikkal once again came out to bat and added four more boundaries to his quota of 14 in company of Saransh Jain (22 retired out).

BCCI secretary Saikia to visit COE to take stock of injury crisis



KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

Concerned with the spate of injuries that has rocked Indian team of late, BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia will be meeting Head Of Cricket of National Cricket Academy (NCA) VVS Laxman on Sunday to take a stock of the rehabilitation management programme at the Centre of Excellence (COE).

India will be missing the services of Jasprit Bumrah (knee swelling), B Sai Sudharsan (left foot big toe), Harshit Rana (hamstring), Nitish Kumar Reddy (hamstring) and Washington Sundar (quadriceps) due to various injuries. Akash Deep (lower back stress fracture) has been out for the longest time since Bengal's Ranji Trophy semi-final defeat.

Adding to that, white ball experts Hardik Pandya (quadriceps), Varun Chakravarthy (hamstring) and Prince Yadav (hamstring) are also at the Centre of Excellence where the Sports Science team is overworked without a figure head since the resignation of Nitin Patel in early 2025. Right now the challenge is to get all these players back on the park.

Sudharsan and Bumrah were enlisted in the squad

subject to fitness but COE's team of experts decided to exercise caution looking at the bigger picture.

"Yes, secretary Saikia will be in Bengaluru to take a stock of the situation along with VVS Laxman. There is a meeting scheduled between the two. It is not known whether head coach of national team Gautam Gambhir or chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar will join online or not.

It will be interesting if both Saikia and Laxman can front up and answer a few media queries with so many conjectures," a BCCI source in the know told PTI on conditions of anonymity. There are also rumours that COE and the current selection committee has always not been in sync with regards to the injury management timelines and some of the players being released before they ticked all the boxes. The issue of Harshit Rana reaching England after being distinctly overweight has not gone down well with the selection committee.

Similarly, the selection committee was initially made to believe that Bumrah and Sudarshan will be at least available for one of the two Test matches. (PTI)

IPL can fit into Australia's schedule, but we'll have to balance it: McDonald

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sydney

Australia head coach Andrew McDonald has said the IPL can "fit" into his team's hectic international schedule, but the demands on his Test stars mean they will have to "balance it out" with workload management, particularly for the fast bowlers.

Beginning with a two-Test home series against Bangladesh on Thursday, Australia are set to play 20 Tests and 14 white-ball matches across next 12 months, with the 2027 IPL window expected to fall between a five-Test tour of India and the World Test Championship final, before the Ashes in England.

"I know people will start talking about the IPL and filling that time and what

does that look like," McDonald told Cricinfo.

"I've said this before, the IPL is part of our management plan for a lot of our players, and to expose our best players in what I believe is the best competition in terms of T20 cricket has its performance benefits as well. You've just got to balance that out."

Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc, Josh Hazlewood, Cameron Green and Travis Head are currently on IPL lists, while Josh Inglis is also part of the Lucknow Super Giants. Australia's experience in 2023, when Cummins, Starc and Head skipped the IPL before playing key roles in the WTC final and Ashes, could influence decisions this time around. McDonald stressed that managing Australia's



fast bowlers will be a priority, with the team aiming to preserve their fitness through a gruelling run of Test cricket. "I know that people say, country versus franchise and all that, but the important part of this period is that we're allowing our fast bowlers to reset their

body, get everything in order to give themselves the best opportunity across the 20 or 21 games that everyone talks about," McDonald said.

"What I will say about our players is they make good decisions across the journey, and that's underpinned by discussions with the medical

Sai Sudharsan ruled out of Sri Lanka Test series

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

Talented top order batter B Sai Sudharsan was on Saturday ruled out of the two-Test series against Sri Lanka after failing to recover from a big toe injury sustained during the India A tour of the island nation last month. Sudharsan, who scored two tons in two 'A' Test matches, was hit during the second game against Sri Lanka 'A' and since then has been in rehabilitation at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru.

"Sai Sudharsan has been ruled out of the upcoming Test series against Sri Lanka. Doctors have advised more time for biological healing. Significant improvement, but not yet sufficient for a safe return to Test cricket," according to the update



from the Sports Science team which is monitoring the rehabilitation of the

player. The Sports Science team has informed the management and national selec-

tion committee. The medical cum fitness advice for Sudharsan reads: "Rehabilitation, strength & conditioning, and cricket-specific loads should be increased gradually and under close monitoring. The cautious approach is aimed at reducing the risk of recurrence or further complications and protecting long-term performance."

In his absence, Devdutt Padikkal, who scored a century in the practice game, will be the new number three batter. It will be interesting to see who replaces Sudharsan in the squad.

Burly Mumbai veteran Sarfaraz Khan seems to be a decent choice but an important member of the coaching staff as well as selection committee doesn't have a lot of faith in him. (PTI)

Shillong Lajong FC go top of Group E with win over Mumbai FC



TONY DAS
■ Shillong

Shillong Lajong FC cruised to a commanding 5-0 win over Mumbai FC in a Group E fixture of the 135th IndianOil Durand Cup, played here at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium on Saturday, August 8, 2026, a result that considerably brightens their prospects of reaching the quarter-finals.

Everbrighton Sana led the scoring with a brace, while Abhay Gurung, Tremiki Lamurong and Figo Syndai were also on the scoresheet as the hosts made light work of their visitors from Mumbai in front of raucous home crowd.

The result takes Shillong Lajong to the top of Group E with six points from two matches, having won both of their opening fixtures. Langsing FC sit second on four points, with Nongkseh SS&CC third on one point. Mumbai FC, without a point from their two outings so far, remain bottom of the table.

Shillong Lajong set the tone early, with Phrangki Buam and Jota causing regular problems down the flanks. The hosts' first real opportunity arrived in the seventh minute, Ephraim Lalremthuanga's free kick finding Arthur Pangaro at the far post for a thumping header that Mumbai's defence somehow scrambled clear. A similar chance went unconverted in the 14th minute, captain Kenstar Kharshong failing to make proper contact despite being unmarked from another set piece.

Mumbai struggled to find any rhythm against Lajong's relentless pressing, their first shot on target not arriving until the 23rd minute, when Mandeep Singh Multani's effort lacked the power to trouble goalkeeper Siwel Rymbai.

At the other end, Mumbai custodian Yasheel Manish Shah was called upon repeatedly, denying Sana's low drive in the 16th minute and then producing a goal-line save to keep out Arthur Pangaro's close-range effort in the 25th. Lamlallian tested him again from distance in the 36th minute, though Mumbai did threaten briefly of their own accord soon after, Mohammad

Kaif Khan failing to keep a first-time header down from a Rohit Mirza free kick. The half took difficult turn for Mumbai just before the interval. Captain and defensive Lynchpin Ahmed Faiz Khan was stretched off after twisting his ankle clearing a ball in 45th minute, and within two minutes of his departure his side's resistance had been broken.

Joedson Dos Santos's free kick picked out Sana, whose header was saved by Yasheel, only for Gurung to react quickly and finish the rebound.

Barely ninety seconds later, Lajong struck again, Tremiki collecting the ball inside the box, shifting it away from his marker and slotting a composed finish beyond Yasheel. Losing their captain and immediately conceding twice made for a bruising passage of play for Mumbai to absorb heading into the break, and the visitors would spend the rest of the evening trying to recover a foothold that had slipped away in the space of two minutes.

Lajong picked up where they left off after the restart, Gurung squandering a good early chance across the face of goal before the third arrived in the 52nd minute — Tremiki turning provider this time, splitting the Mumbai defence for Sana to rifle a first-time finish into the top corner. Sana celebrated with the trademark Cristiano Ronaldo leap and mid-air spin, and the home end roared out their own "Siuuu" in unison as he struck the pose before them.

Mumbai tried to respond, Afzar Noorani curling narrowly over from the right side of the box in the 56th minute, but any momentum was extinguished when Dhruvmil Pandya's heavy touch gifted possession back to Lajong in the 64th minute. Sana pounced without hesitation, driving into the box and finishing crisply for his second of the afternoon and his side's fourth.

Yasheel continued to stand firm where he could, denying Kharshong from close range in the 69th minute and Joedson from almost point-blank distance in the 79th, sparing his side further embarrassment on both occasions.

Arsenal lands Guimaraes from Newcastle ahead of Premier League title defense

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Arsenal completed the signing of Brazil midfielder Bruno Guimaraes from Newcastle on Saturday.

The Premier League champion paid a reported 75 million pounds (\$101 million) for Guimaraes, who signed a long-term deal at the Emirates. "I'm very excited," Guimaraes said. "I'm at the point of my life where I need a challenge like this. I want to win trophies, I want to make history and I think I'm in the right place to do it."

Newcastle did not want to



sell its captain, but the 28-year-old Guimaraes had told the club he wanted to leave.

Newcastle signed Guimaraes from Ligue 1 club Lyon in January 2022 and he swiftly established himself as a talisman for the team, as

well as one of the most influential midfielders in the Premier League.

Guimaraes helped Newcastle win the English League Cup in 2025 - the club's first major domestic trophy in 70 years - and also

played a pivotal role in the team twice qualifying for the Champions League.

He joins an Arsenal mid-field anchored by Declan Rice as the team bids for back-to-back Premier League titles. Guimaraes has made 48 appearances for Brazil, including at the recent World Cup. He won a gold medal at the 2020 Olympic Games in Tokyo. "It's massive what I have done so far, but I want more. I want to win for Arsenal. I want to win more trophies in my career, and I think I'm in the right place, at my peak at 28 years old," Guimaraes said.

Jemimah ruled out of Hundred with injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India batter Jemimah Rodrigues has been ruled out of ongoing Hundred after suffering a hamstring injury while playing for Southern Brave, putting her participation in the upcoming Women's T20 Asia Cup in doubt. Southern Brave confirmed on Saturday that Rodrigues has been replaced by Australian all-rounder Charlie Knott for the remainder of tournament.

"We can confirm that due to an injury suffered by Jemimah, we've signed Knott as our injury replacement for remainder of The Hundred. Wishing



you a speedy recovery, Jemi," Southern Brave posted on X.

The 25-year-old has scored 143 runs with a highest of 42 not out in six innings for the Brave at an average of 35.75 and a strike rate of 131.19.

The Women's T20 Asia Cup begins on August 28, with India starting their campaign against Thailand on August 30.

Jorge Messi, Lionel Messi's father and longtime agent, dies at 68

RAMIRO BARREIRO
■ Montevideo (Uruguay)

Jorge Messi, the father of soccer star and Argentina captain Lionel Messi, died Saturday at a hospital in the central Argentina city of Rosario. He was 68.

The Rosario-based Club Atletico Newell's Old Boys announced his death in a social media post that said he had undergone treatment in recent months for an unspecified illness. The post described him as "the pillar and the person who, with vision, rigor and affection, supported the career of the best player of all time, alongside his wife, Celia Cuccittini."

The South American Football Confederation, CON-

MEBOL, in a statement also offered its condolences "with respect and affection for Lionel." Messi led Argentina to a runner-up finish in this year's World Cup. In the team's first match, against Algeria, he was visibly emotional after scoring the first of his three goals. He said later that he wept for "a reason unrelated to sports."

"I went through some difficult, complicated days," he said. "I am grateful to the delegation, to all my teammates, because they were always by my side wishing me strength so that I would be OK."

Media reports at the time outraged the Messi family, which days later released a statement confirming that



"Jorge is experiencing a health issue," without specifying the nature of his condition. "A person's health and the peace of mind of their loved ones should not be the subject of speculation or irresponsible media interest," according to the statement, which also expressed "discomfort at the lack of sensitivity, respect and scru-

ples with which some people have treated a strictly private and family matter."

Jorge Messi was a chemical technician and worked as a steelworker. He played soccer as a midfielder and reached the youth ranks of Newell's Old Boys but had to abandon the sport to complete his mandatory military service in Argentina.

He played a fundamental role in his third son's career, serving as his agent and managing his business affairs. He was the one who traveled with a young Messi to Barcelona in the early 2000s for the trial that would open the doors to La Masia, the Catalan club's youth academy. Lionel Messi made his professional debut in 2005 and went on to win eight Ballon d'Or awards. He led Argentina to the 2022 World Cup title.

"My dad was always by my side," Lionel Messi said in a 2007 interview with Radio del Plata. "Sometimes I would lock myself in my room to cry when we arrived in Barcelona, or my dad would do the same without

me seeing him, or thinking I didn't see him. We pretended we were both OK, but we weren't. My dad even asked me what I wanted to do when we were feeling down, if I wanted to stay or go back, and I wanted to stay, and he stayed with me."

His father negotiated the contracts with Barca and later his transfers to Paris Saint-Germain and Inter Miami, while also managing the use of his famous son's image rights and his numerous investments in real estate, hotels, and restaurants. In 2016, father and son were convicted in the Spanish courts on tax evasion charges, but avoided prison because sentence was less than two years. (AP)

The hands behind the Tiranga

Discover the unsung heroes who weave our pride this Independence Day

SAKSHI PRIYA

Before Independence Day celebrations begin, quiet workshops echo with sewing machines. Unsung artisans ground our national pride through their sweat and devotion. Flag making is a deeply emotional legacy passed through generations. Seeing the Tiranga fly reminds us that everyday heroes wove our freedom. We shall celebrate our handloom, not just one but every time.

"We feel very proud that we make the Tiranga for our country," says Abdul Malik. His family has been turning patriotism into a physical reality since 1962. Situated right in the chaotic and bustling lanes of Sadar Bazaar is his legendary shop, **Gaffar Bhai Jhande Wale**. This spot is a landmark so iconic that locals simply ask delivery drivers to drop them at the flag maker's door. I sat down with him to uncover how a plain piece of cloth transforms into the beating heart of **140 crore Indians**. Join me as we explore the rich history and the vital importance of understanding the devoted hands that craft our ultimate symbol of freedom.



HISTORIC MILESTONES

"Earlier, ordinary people were not allowed to hoist the national flag at their homes". "After Naveen Jindal's Supreme Court case, people got permission". "We made the flag that was installed at the Supreme Court". "Later, we received an order to make a 120 foot by 90 foot national flag for the Ambala border".

A MESSAGE TO EVERY INDIAN

INDIA IS A DEMOCRATIC AND INDEPENDENT COUNTRY OF 140 CRORE PEOPLE. "I HOPE EVERYONE CONTINUES TO CELEBRATE IT TOGETHER SO THAT THE WHOLE WORLD SEES OUR UNITY". "WE FEEL VERY PROUD THAT OUR COUNTRY IS BEING SERVED BY OUR HANDS". WE SHALL CELEBRATE OUR NATION, NOT JUST ONE BUT EVERY TIME.



“THE TIRANGA SHOULD ALWAYS BE HELD HIGH AND SHOULD NEVER TOUCH THE GROUND”

THE LEGACY OF FLAG UNCLE

"The most emotional moment for me was when Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the *Har Ghar Tiranga* Abhiyan. We made 1.5 lakh flags in a single day. The Prime Minister's Office honoured my late father with the title 'Flag Uncle'. He passed away on December 29, 2025. That is a moment we will always cherish."

- Abdul Malik



Precision and Monsoon Hurdles

"To make the Tiranga, the first thing is to maintain the correct size and pay special attention to the Ashoka Chakra". "The biggest challenge is arranging the cloth". "During the rainy season, it becomes very difficult because the cloth comes from Surat, and floods affect supplies". "That is why we prepare our work five to six months in advance."

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

A night of Kuchipudi



The 30th Parampara Series opened with a beautiful Kuchipudi performance by Raja Radha Reddy Troupe

TEAM VIVA

Raja Radha Reddy and Kaushalya Reddy have been at this since 1976, nearly five decades now, building up Natya Tarangini into what it is today, a real stronghold for Indian performing art. All of those years of cultural preservation set the ideal stage for the milestone 30th Parampara Series, which just opened at Kamani Auditorium. Walking into the grand hall felt like crossing into a sacred space where cosmic cycles took shape through rhythmic footwork and expressive eyes. The Raja Radha Reddy Troupe brought the ancient essence of Kuchipudi vividly alive before the audience. We first witnessed *Mahapranadeepam — Shivam*, which explored Lord Shiva as Nataraja, the powerful creator and destroyer.

The performers physically embodied the loud, echoing strikes of Shiva's two-sided *damru*. They beautifully captured the 14 sounds associated with the Maheshwara Sutras through their precise movements. Seeing them perform live completely absorbed the entire room. Every heavy stomp on the wooden floor and wide sweeping motion of their hands drew us further into a



quiet spiritual trance.

It felt exactly like watching the actual heartbeat of the universe taking shape right in front of us.

The intense cosmic energy softened as Radha Reddy took the stage in *Muddu Krishna*, portraying the devoted Naagpatni. Her performance conveyed profound sorrow, pleading with Lord Krishna to spare her serpent husband Kaliya. You could almost feel the poisoned lake trembling as Krishna gracefully departed the serpent's hood, restoring purity to the water. Reddy ended the piece with a joyous outpouring of song and dance, radiating genuine relief.

The evening offered an unforgettable journey through Indian mythology grounded in raw human emotion that five decades of dedicated artistic practice can successfully achieve on a modern stage.

A breathtaking Kuchipudi performance that masterfully bridges cosmic mythology, deep cultural heritage, and raw emotion

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

ART CORNER

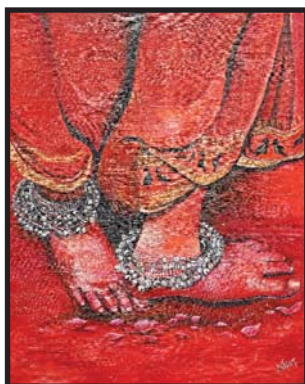
The artistic voice of freedom

An exhibition weaving heritage, imagination, and freedom through sixty-five diverse artistic voices

SAKSHI PRIYA

Art anchors human memory to the earth we walk upon while giving flight to our deepest inner thoughts. This balance between grounded heritage and boundless imagination drives *Threads of Freedom 2.0: A Journey from Soil to Soul*. Curated by Saloni Wadhwa for the Akatva Arts Foundation, the current gathering at New Delhi's Visual Art Gallery brings together over sixty-five distinct voices who have been granted absolute liberty to weave their personal and cultural narratives into vivid physical forms.

The collection presents a fascinating look at how Indian artists currently handle different materials to tell their stories. Shambhunath Goswami immediately draws the eye with *Purnima Night Puja*, a large acrylic canvas that captures the warm glow of evening riverbank rituals. Nearby, Raghu Vyas showcases classical portraiture skills in his detailed oil painting *Rembrandt*,



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR



TRUE TO YOU BUT ME CAPTURES IDENTITY, MEMORY AND EMOTION THROUGH FOUR EXPRESSIVE MIXED-MEDIA PORTRAITS, INVITING VIEWERS TO REFLECT ON THE MANY LAYERS OF SELF

creating a quiet moment that naturally makes observers pause and look more closely.

The artists manipulate their chosen materials to tell compelling contemporary stories. Kapil Kapoor shapes industrial fibre-reinforced polymer into a dynamic sculptural piece titled *Enlightenment*, complementing the traditional canvases hanging nearby. Pratibha Awasthi invites deep reflection with her lush oil composition *Beyond the Word*, standing in powerful thematic contrast to the urgent environmental commentary found in Shubhamdeep Kaur's striking piece *Exploitation of Nature*.

Bold colour palettes dominate the gallery space, especially visible in Priya Luthra's expansive acrylic piece *Life* and Zutshi's serene oil canvas *Sartal te Pamposh*.

Through these incredibly varied expressions, the exhibition succeeds as a vital cultural space where creators celebrate the enduring ties between personal identity and our shared national roots.

Beyond the label lies the loom

TEAM VIVA

Long before computers mapped the world, Indian weavers were coding complex mathematics on wooden looms. August 7th brought another National Handloom Day. People usually point to the 1905 Swadeshi movement. Let us skip the history lesson this time. We need to look at a raw and brilliant reality happening right now. Too many master creators face a forced silence today, left with almost no stage to stand on.

India holds a massive secret workforce. Over three million people weave our fabrics. Seven out of ten are women working just outside the agricultural fields. Stroll through any luxury boutique in Milan or Paris. You will see huge price tags on beautiful garments. Those shiny labels hide a deep truth. The magic did not begin in a fancy European studio. The genesis of luxury textiles finds its roots far away from glittering runways, tucked deep inside places like Kanchipuram and Bhuj.



“Sustainable brands have a responsibility to look beyond the fabric and support the people behind it. At Terra Luna, five villages in Gujarat work exclusively with us, allowing artisans to continue their ancestral craft with pride, while building more secure livelihoods and better opportunities for their families.”
— Stuti Dhanuka, Sustainable Fashion Entrepreneur & Founder, Terra Luna

Weavers from Gujarat, Tamil Nadu, Madhya Pradesh — names most buyers will never know — are the ones actually holding up the global luxury market. Their quiet, painstaking labour breathes life into the very foundation of global high fashion. These masters hold centuries of complex design blueprints strictly in their memory. They control thread counts by pure instinct to weave complex patterns. No machine on earth



DO YOU KNOW?

FRANCE AND ENGLAND ONCE TRIED TO BAN INDIAN CHINTZ

Everyone called it chintz. This incredibly soft Indian cotton burst with bright painted flowers and twisting vines. Weavers along the Coromandel Coast and across Gujarat somehow created something genuinely special. They crafted a cheap tough fabric that kept its vivid colors perfectly. By the late 1600s this exotic cloth had quietly taken over European bedrooms and stuffed their wardrobes full.

Watching their customer base vanish left traditional European textile makers deeply terrified. Panicked craftsmen forced governments to intervene. France outright banned printed cotton in 1686, while England passed the strict Calico Acts by 1721. Yet, smugglers kept chintz alive. Manufacturers copied Indian patterns, producing fabrics that echoed its iconic florals. This beautiful textile rewrote global fashion and left a legacy that outlived protectionist decrees. We shall celebrate our handloom, not just one but every time.



Chintz comes from Hindi chint, meaning spotted or variegated

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Printed and published by Kushan Mitra for and on behalf of CMYK Printech Ltd., Regd Office:- 201-205, 208-210, 2nd Floor, Pratap Bhawan 5, B.S.Z. Marg, New Delhi-110002 Phone: 011-46035729, and printed at The Indian Express Ltd., A-8, Sector 7, Dist. Gautam Budh Nagar (U.P.) Noida-201 301, Ph: 01202470700. Executive Editor Deepak Kumar Jha. AIR SURCHARGE of ₹ 2.00 East: Calcutta, North: Leh West: Mumbai & Ahmedabad South: Bangalore & Chennai. Central: Khajuraho. Lucknow Office: 4th Floor, Sahara Shopping Centre, Faizabad Road, Lucknow-226 016. Phone:- 9415089265

The Pioneer AGENDA

The only way in which a durable peace can be created is by world-wide restoration of international trade
- James Forrestal



The choke points on major maritime routes can hold the global economy hostage. India must look for alternative routes and access to other ports through multimodal transportation networks, including railways, highways and pipelines

BEYOND HORMUZ



M JAMSHED

The current geopolitical map of West Asia at war is also the epicentre of tectonic shifts in the global energy grid. To understand why, it is important to know one key statistic: nearly 80 per cent of global trade by volume moves by sea, but just about five or six choke points on major maritime routes are critical to maintaining a free flow of vessels. These chokepoints are then also the fulcrums of the free flow of international trade, logistics costs, and most importantly, the energy security of economies dependent on imports of oil and gas from specific global supply regions. Disruptions in the Persian Gulf since last February have resulted in oil and gas price increases and global shortages. According to the IMO, there have been 64 incidents impacting trading vessels in the region since the war started, and 6000 marine crews are stranded in and around the strait of Hormuz since July.

At the time this article goes to press, diplomatic negotiating rooms in Doha, Tehran, Muscat and Washington DC will be buzzing with activity to agree to draft language for a negotiated settlement for opening of the Strait of Hormuz and levy of a possible service charge or toll to be paid to Iran and Oman. This would be the first of its kind toll on an international maritime route, which except for certain eventualities is prohibited under the United Nations Conventions on the Law of the Sea. Any such toll of the Hormuz will set a precedent for other countries controlling territorial waters at narrow point (like Gibraltar and the English channel). The service charges at Malacca and the levy of toll in the Turkish straits do not often make headlines but will be examples for the new geopolitical world.

A note on the Strait of Hormuz: this small but critical route supplies over 20 per cent of the global oil and gas requirements, but does not actually have any international waters. At its narrowest point, the strait overlaps with the territorial waters of Iran and Oman. But the crisis has impacted global energy supply lines and sent economies into freefall around the world, especially those dependent on imports of gas and oil from the Persian Gulf. The International Maritime Organisation has written to the United Nations Secretary-General, raising the concern that permitting Iran and Oman to charge tolls or service fees violates international norms, have repercussions for global trade, and undermine the internationally recognised legal framework for international navigation.

The crisis has made it clear that choke points on major maritime routes cannot hold the global economy hostage and necessitate alternatives. The on-going crisis is not only impacting the flow of oil and gas from the Persian Gulf, but also movements towards Europe through the Strait of Bab al Mandeb, the Red Sea, and the Suez

Canal that provide an exit through the Mediterranean to European markets. A similar disruption at the Suez canal will put at risk significant energy flows from Asia to the rest of the world.

Major oil producing nations like Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar, Kuwait, Iraq and Iran must look for alternative routes and access to other ports through multi modal transportation networks, including land bridging by Railways, highways, and laying pipelines. The crisis has demonstrated that business as usual is not enough. The future on the other side of this crisis may not guarantee that the free flow of ships is insured for all times to come.

A few developments indicate that many countries have already started working on options for moving oil and gas that avoid Hormuz, Bab al Mandeb, and the Suez Canal. For Saudi Arabia, exit through the Persian Gulf and the red Sea are both fraught with complications. Despite the existence of a pipeline, choke points continue to impact the flow of vessels to East Asia and Europe. The Bab al Mandeb is no longer a peripheral shipping lane. It connects the

THERE HAVE BEEN 64 INCIDENTS IMPACTING TRADING VESSELS IN THE REGION SINCE THE WAR STARTED, AND 6000 MARINE CREWS ARE STRANDED

THE MAJOR OIL COMPANIES ARE LOOKING AT SHIPPING THE CRUDE OIL FROM THE PORT OF YANBU ON THE EGYPTIAN SUMED PIPELINE

Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Indian Ocean and is one of the most consequential corridors for global trade and energy shipments. Since 2023, shipping has been impacted due to attacks on the ships and the raging conflict around the strait involving Saudi Arabia, Somalia, Houthis, Israel and the USA. There are reports that the Houthis will end up in control of the state of Bab al Mandeb and impose tolls. These further strengthen the argument for alternate routes and modes of transportation for oil and global trade to be explored, worked on, and commissioned on priority.

Pipe lines are being considered in addition to roads and railways. Important crude pipe line developments in the region include an Iraq - Syria - Jordan pipe line, Saudi East West, and UAE to Oman pipeline etc. In a significant development, Iraq and Syria have decided to revive the oil pipeline between Kirkuk in Iraq to the port of Baniyas in Syria on the Mediterranean Sea. This project is likely to take about 30 months as per latest reports and would consist of two pipelines with capacity of 1.5 billion barrels per day to 2.0 billion barrels per day. The effort



Primary bottlenecks and challenges

Despite its immense economic logic, the corridor faces critical headwinds:

GEOPOLITICAL CONFLICT IN WEST ASIA: The prolonged Middle East conflict involving Israel, Gaza, and wider regional tensions has severely strained the diplomatic coordination needed for the Northern Corridor. Specifically, the planned rail link connecting Saudi Arabia through Jordan to Israel's Haifa Port remains physically and diplomatically stalled.

FUNDING GAPS: While individual countries are financing domestic parts, an overarching, multi-billion-dollar joint funding pool or unified consortium for cross-border links has yet to be finalised.

TRADE FRACTURES: Minor friction point developments, such as the imposition of sudden external tariffs or regional politics, occasionally cloud immediate construction timelines.



The crucial need for IMEC

The corridor addresses severe global vulnerabilities and reshapes transcontinental geopolitics.

CIRCUMVENTING GLOBAL TRADE CHOKEPOINTS: The protracted Red Sea crisis and Houthi militant attacks highlighted the fragility of relying entirely on the Suez Canal. By using an overland rail spine across the Arabian Peninsula, IMEC creates a vital alternative route.

DRASTIC LOGISTICS OPTIMIZATION: IMEC is projected to slash cargo transportation times by up to 40 per cent and reduce total logistics costs by nearly 30 per cent compared to traditional maritime routes.

BEYOND GOODS-ENERGY & DATA GRIDS: The project is not just for shipping containers; it is engineered to house undersea fiber-optic data pipelines to bypass data chokepoints, alongside cross-border electricity grids and green hydrogen pipelines.

COUNTERING CHINA'S BELT AND ROAD INITIATIVE (BRI): Backed strongly by India, the US, and the EU, IMEC serves as a high-standard, transparent, and democratic infrastructure alternative to China's debt-heavy BRI.

STRATEGIC ALIGNMENT: It establishes a "triangular economic architecture"-positioning India as a manufacturing hub, the Gulf as a capital and logistics engine, and Europe as a high-tech consumer market.

to rebuild the pipeline is being supported by the United States, which has already lifted sanctions from Syria. In the meantime, road transportation of oil from Iraq to the Mediterranean Port in Syria, has begun in a big way. Opening a new route avoiding passage through the State of Hormuz, Saudi pipeline line from east to west connects Egyptian pipeline to the Egyptian terminal on the Mediterranean.

Saudi Arabia, the largest oil producer in the region, is bearing the brunt of the ongoing conflict impacting movement of oil and gas through its eastern coast on the Persian gulf. Taking into account the possibility of a prolonged conflict, major Saudi oil companies have started moving

larger quantities of oil on their east west pipeline, facilitating crude oil to be delivered at their red Sea port of Yanbu for transshipment to the Egyptian pipeline. The major oil companies are looking at shipping the crude oil from the port of Yanbu on the Egyptian Sumed pipeline. The pipeline, which is an alternative to the Suez canal, connects the Egyptian terminal of Ain Sokhna on the Gulf of Suez to Sidi Keir on the Mediterranean with a capacity of approximately 2.5 million barrels per day. Once delivered to the Mediterranean terminal, the crude is shipped to Europe, avoiding the use of even the Suez Canal, which is already congested.

An Iran - China- Central Asia - Russia - Europe multimodal route involving ships, railways, roadways, and Iran's southern Chabahar port through INSTC is already commissioned. Iran is also looking at developing its major port at Chabahar for energy supplies of oil and gas to Southern Asia and the far East avoiding the port of Bandar Abbas, which is located in the Persian Gulf. Iran and Pakistan are jointly working to utilise the upcoming Gwadar port and existing Karachi port in Pakistan. Technically, the territorial waters of Iran allow it to move vessels along its entire southern length and enter territorial waters of Pakistan near Gwadar. This would also ensure the safety of the oil and gas vessels which remain restricted for their movements within its territorial waters. The UAE and other gulf countries are joining to commission the GCC rail line connecting UAE with Oman in addition to developing the crude Pipe lines to Fujairah port in Oman. Qatar and Kuwait are also looking at joining the Iraq-Syria pipe line and also utilising the UAE-Oman and Saudi East-West pipe line.

Initiative led by India and US (like IMEC) acquire greater significance now and could be a feasible alternative. However major infrastructure projects to construct missing rail links in Saudi Arabia and Jordan are now urgently needed to operationalise the corridor. Saudi Arabia and Jordan joining the Abraham Accord will enable the corridor to make use of the Israeli port of Haifa. Other developments in this region and as alternatives to choke points elsewhere include a China-Central Asia-Europe rail corridor which also connects to Tehran and the INSTC, the Thailand canal being envisaged to provide an alternative to Malacca, and the southern Mexican rail bridging to avoid the congested Panama canal.

Even as the world builds new routes and a bigger network that can absorb global shocks with its scale, only the silencing of guns over the Persian Gulf and the Red Sea and a regional security architecture can create conditions for stable growth. But while we wait, countries must act to achieve their own energy security and not depend on oil and gas imports from afar for economic sustainability and growth.

The writer is Former Member Railway Board and Senior Adviser The World Bank

India-Middle East-Europe economic corridor: Progress made so far...

Since its high-profile announcement at the G20 Summit in New Delhi in September 2023, the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) has progressed via a dual-track reality: rapid diplomatic, bilateral, and digital integration on the Eastern Corridor, contrasted against physical construction slowdowns on the Northern Corridor due to severe regional volatility.

The developmental progress achieved across different structural pillars includes the following:

Institutional and Bilateral Agreements

THE INDIA-UAE FRAMEWORK: Signed in February 2024, this serves as the primary operational blueprint for the Eastern Corridor.

It focuses on standardising customs processes and establishing data sharing protocols between South Asian and Gulf logistics networks.

DEDICATED DIPLOMATIC SPECIAL ENVOYS: Major European participants-specifically France and Italy-appointed dedicated special envoys to drive multilateral coordination and align the corridor with the European Union's Global Gateway initiative.

Physical Port & Railway Infrastructure

THE EASTERN CORRIDOR: India has fast-tracked mega deep-sea port developments, such as the Vadnavan Port in Maharashtra, to augment cargo handling capacity. Key logistical nodes like Mundra Port, Jebel Ali Port (Dubai, UAE), and Haifa Port (Israel) are already active maritime endpoints.

THE NORTHERN CORRIDOR: Broad overland construction of the trans-Arabian railway network started across specific domestic links in Saudi Arabia and the UAE. However, the critical rail link passing through the Jordan-Israel border has experienced major bottlenecks.

Digital and Virtual Integration

THE 'MAITRI' DIGITAL TRADE PLATFORM: To bypass traditional transnational bureaucracy, India and the UAE began developing a virtual trade corridor. This digital clearing ecosystem uses unified documentation systems to expedite customs and container transit times.

DATA & CLEAN ENERGY CORRIDORS: Feasibility studies advanced for laying ultra-high-capacity subsea fiber-optic cables to bypass vulnerable data chokepoints like the Bab al-Mandab. Technical planning has also been initiated to connect electricity grids and green hydrogen pipelines across the Arabian Peninsula.

Recent Structural Adaptations (2026)

Due to prolonged geopolitical friction stakeholders have expanded the initial blueprint into a more resilient "network of corridors".

OMAN INTEGRATION: Oman is increasingly treated as an active maritime gateway to allow cargo ships to bypass the volatile Strait of Hormuz entirely.

RED SEA AND MEDITERRANEAN DIVERSIFICATION: Alternative exits are being evaluated, leveraging Saudi Arabia's Red Sea ports (Jeddah and Neom) as well as newly expanded Mediterranean port configurations to preserve the corridor's viability.

“OBSERVE GOOD FAITH AND JUSTICE
TOWARD ALL NATIONS. CULTIVATE PEACE
AND HARMONY WITH ALL.”
— GEORGE WASHINGTON

The grammar of civilisational diplomacy



MALIKA PANDEY



diplomatic relations remained stable, the relationship lacked strategic momentum.

The past decade marks a clear departure. Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has increasingly aligned its civilisational confidence with strategic policy. Indonesia has emerged as one of the strongest examples of this approach, where historical familiarity now reinforces cooperation across defence, maritime security, technology, connectivity and economic engagement. Rather than treating history as ceremonial diplomacy, the relationship has begun to use it as a foundation for contemporary cooperation.

President Prabowo Subianto's remarks during his visit to India captured this transformation. His admiration for Prime Minister Modi's leadership and governance model was notable. Even more striking was his observation that he carried 'Indian DNA.' The remark reflected the confidence of the President of the world's largest muslim-majority nation in acknowledging that Indonesia's historical identity cannot be understood without recognising India's enduring civilisational imprint. Equally significant was his willingness to publicly speak of learning from India's developmental experience. Few diplomatic statements combine historical memory with contemporary political admiration so naturally.

The growing partnership is visible in substance as much as symbolism. Defence coop-

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eration through BrahMos has understandably attracted attention, but the relationship today extends well beyond military ties. Agreements on digital public infrastructure, Unified Payments Interface connectivity, maritime cooperation, higher education, resilient supply chains and critical minerals reflect an increasingly comprehensive partnership. Together, they demonstrate that civilisational familiarity is now being translated into practical cooperation.

One agreement deserves particular attention. India and Indonesia have agreed to strengthen cooperation between their Election Commissions, including collaboration on electoral management and Electronic Voting Machines. The irony is difficult to overlook. At a time when sections of India's political opposition continue to question the credibility of EVMs, another democracy responsible for conducting one of the world's largest elections has chosen to deepen institutional cooperation with India. Democracies rarely seek to learn from institutions they fundamentally distrust. International

confidence does not settle domestic political debates, but it does demonstrate that India's democratic institutions continue to command credibility well beyond its borders.

There is another remarkable convergence. Indonesia's Emas Vision 2045 and India's Viksit Bharat 2047 articulate similar ambitions of transforming large, diverse democracies into developed economies within the same historical generation. Their Independence Days fall just two days apart. India celebrates on August 15 and Indonesia on August 17. These parallels do not determine foreign policy, but they reinforce a shared vocabulary of national renewal and long-term development.

The significance of the India-Indonesia relationship, therefore, extends beyond trade figures or defence agreements. It illustrates how civilisational memory can strengthen contemporary diplomacy without becoming captive to nostalgia. Strategic interests will always drive foreign policy, but they are often easier to pursue when reinforced by a deeper reservoir of historical trust. In an increasingly transactional international order, that may prove to be India's distinctive advantage. Civilisations do not replace strategy. They make strategy more durable. The relationship between India and Indonesia suggests that history is most valuable not when it is commemorated, but when it quietly enables the future. That, perhaps, is the true grammar of civilisational diplomacy.

The writer is a public policy expert with years of experience working across key ministries of the Govt of India



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Walking towards the Goddess

SUMIT SETH

On a brief visit home to India in the last week of April, Ritu Sharma handed me a signed copy of Shakti: Tales of Power and Promise. It travelled back with me to Panama and waited, as books often do, for the right weekend. When I finally opened it, I read it with genuine pleasure. By the end, I was convinced that the author has written a book more intimate, thoughtful and enduring than its genre usually permits.

Ritu and I have known each other for many years. We trained together for about three and a half months in Mussoorie before our professional paths diverged: hers into the Indian Revenue Service, mine into the Foreign Service. Since then, I have followed her journey from a series of postings that has now brought me to Panama, about as far from a Himalayan shrine as one can reasonably be. That a book about the goddess should reach me here, across oceans, felt in itself like a small reminder of how far these old energies travel.

Shakti is a pilgrimage, though it does not sit neatly within either travel writing or religious study. The author travels across Shakti Peeths, not as an academic cataloguing temple architecture, nor as a tourist collecting impressions, but as a seeker trying to understand what remains alive in these places. That distinction gives the book its quiet

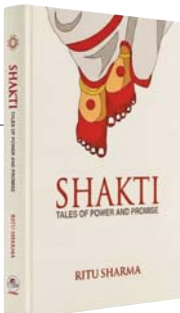
strength. Much of its appeal comes from the person doing the looking. Ritu Sharma is a serving IRS officer, a Chevening Fellow, and a public servant with two decades of experience in government. The administrator and the devotee often appear together in her sentences. One notices the discipline of observation, but also the willingness to be moved. It is this tension that keeps the goddess from becoming abstract.

The journey moves from Vaishno Devi in the northern mountains to Chamundeshwari in the south and Kamakhya in the east. Each chapter reads less like a formal essay than a conversation. The author does not offer a dry history of the shrines. She brings the reader close enough to sit beside her. One of the most memorable passages is her descent into the cave at Kamakhya, where water moves through a fissure in

the rock. She allows the sacred strangeness of the place to work on her instead of reducing it to explanation, and the scene stays with the reader.

Her prose is clear, unhurried and accessible. It carries the weight of Indian mythology lightly enough for newcomers, while remaining respectful of those who approach these shrines with devotion. Even the cover, with the adorned feet of the deity, establishes a note of reverence that the book gradually earns. The author's larger suggestion is made without sermonising: the divine feminine is not merely an inheritance to be preserved, but a reservoir of courage, memory and renewal. In her telling, power and promise are not separate ideas; they flow into one another.

The book is not without its limits. Its warmth sometimes avoids harder questions that could have deepened the inquiry, and readers looking for rigorous comparative scholarship may need to look elsewhere. But that is not the book the author sets out to write. What she offers instead is a way of carrying the sacred forward, not as nostalgia, but as a living presence. Reading her in Panama, far from any shrine, I found that presence unexpectedly persuasive. For a book of this kind, that is no small feat.



Author: Ritu Sharma
Publisher: Kitabwale
Price: ₹450

The book reviewer is a member of Indian Foreign Service and has served as Ambassador of India in Panama

Insider's reckoning with the Indian state

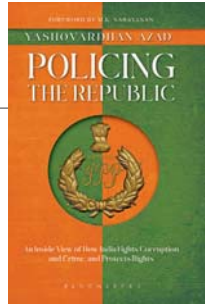
TEAM AGENDA

India's police still function under a law written for a colonial power to control its subjects, not a republic to serve its citizens. The Police Act of 1861, drafted in the aftermath of the 1857 uprising, remains in force in large parts of the country. In 2006, the Supreme Court, ruling on a petition filed a decade earlier by former Uttar Pradesh DGP Prakash Singh, issued seven binding directives ordering every state to insulate its police from political interference - fixed tenures for top officers, security commissions to buffer the force from the government of the day, and a clear separation between investigation and law-and-order duties. Nearly two decades on, compliance across

most states remains cosmetic at best. It is against this backdrop of a reform that never quite arrived that Yashovardhan Azad's new book, Policing the Republic, lands with particular weight.

Published by Bloomsbury India and priced at ₹699. Its subtitle -

gathering, and the broader question of how India's internal security architecture has evolved - and where it has stalled. Azad is billed as making the case that political interference and systemic weakness inside these institutions have eroded the guarantees the Constitution makes to citizens.



Author: Yashovardhan Azad
Publisher: Bloomsbury
Price: ₹699

WEEKLY MOON SIGN FORECAST | 9-15 AUGUST

Thoughtful Conversations, Emotional
Reset & Renewed Confidence

Dr Shanker Adawal
Astrologer, Author & Researcher

This forecast is based on your Moon Sign (Janma Rashi), which often reflects day-to-day emotional and instinctive patterns more closely than general Sun-sign readings.

Moon Watch

This week carries a clear turning point around the midweek Amavasya. What begins with discussion may need quiet reflection before action. As the new lunar cycle opens, confidence returns and priorities become easier to see.

Weekly Overview

The week opens with the Moon in Gemini, keeping conversations, planning and movement active. As it enters Cancer, emotions turn inward and home or family matters may need greater attention. Midweek Amavasya favours a pause, review and emotional reset.



Aries (Mesh): Conversations, short journeys or pending discussions may keep the opening days active. Useful information could arrive through an ordinary exchange, so listen before deciding. Midweek turns attention towards home and family, where emotions may run a little deeper. As the weekend approaches, confidence improves and creative plans regain momentum. A lighter approach may solve what pressure could not.



Taurus (Vrishabh): Money matters, family priorities or an important conversation may need practical handling early in the week. Be careful with words, especially if expectations differ. The Cancer Moon then encourages movement, meetings and reconnecting with people. By the weekend, attention settles closer to home. Small improvements in your surroundings or family routine may bring more satisfaction than a major change.



Gemini (Mithun): With the Moon beginning the week in Gemini, ideas move quickly and you may feel ready to address matters that have waited long enough. Avoid promising more than time allows. Midweek brings finances, family responsibilities and personal values into sharper focus. The weekend becomes more active again, supporting communication, short travel and useful contacts. Clear words will save unnecessary explanations later.



Cancer (Karka): The opening days may feel quieter, making rest, unfinished work or private concerns more important than outside activity. Once the Moon enters Cancer, emotional awareness increases and personal priorities become clearer. Midweek Amavasya is better for reassessment than hurried decisions. By the weekend, attention shifts towards finances and family responsibilities. Simpler choices may bring greater peace of mind.



Leo (Simha): Friends, professional networks or future plans may offer useful support early in the week. Midweek becomes more inward-looking, and you may prefer some distance from unnecessary noise. This quieter phase can help settle unfinished thoughts. As the Moon enters Leo towards the weekend, energy and confidence rise noticeably. Use the renewed momentum for what genuinely matters rather than seeking attention everywhere.



Virgo (Kanya): Professional responsibilities remain important during the opening phase, and communication with senior people may require clarity. As the week progresses, friends, colleagues or wider networks can provide useful support. Midweek also favours reviewing longer-term goals. By the weekend, the pace softens and some private time may be necessary. Not every productive week needs a visible result.



Libra (Tula): Learning, travel plans or a broader professional question may occupy your thoughts early in the week. Midweek shifts attention towards career responsibilities and decisions that need both sensitivity and practical judgement. Recognition may come quietly rather than dramatically. By the weekend, friends and professional contacts become more active. A useful connection could develop simply through staying available and open-minded.



Scorpio (Vrishchik): Shared responsibilities, financial commitments or a sensitive personal matter may need careful handling during the opening days. Avoid reaching conclusions before the full picture appears. As the Moon enters Cancer, perspective broadens and learning or travel-related matters feel easier. The weekend brings greater professional focus and visibility. Quiet preparation earlier in the week may prove more valuable than expected.



Sagittarius (Dhanu): Relationships and one-to-one discussions take centre stage early in the week. A direct conversation can be useful, provided both sides are willing to listen. Midweek turns attention towards shared finances, trust or responsibilities that cannot be avoided. By the weekend, the mood becomes lighter and perspective widens. Learning, travel or future planning may restore enthusiasm and direction.



Capricorn (Makar): Routine work, health priorities and practical responsibilities may keep you occupied during the first part of the week. Small corrections will work better than trying to change everything at once. Midweek places greater emphasis on partnerships and cooperation. By the weekend, financial commitments or shared responsibilities deserve closer attention. Keep arrangements clear, especially where more than one person is involved.



Aquarius (Kumbh): Creative interests, children, personal projects or lighter social moments may bring welcome energy early in the week. Midweek turns practical as work routines and health priorities demand better organisation. Do not ignore small tasks simply because larger ideas appear more interesting. By the weekend, relationships come into stronger focus. Cooperation becomes easier when expectations are expressed without unnecessary complications.



Pisces (Meen): Home, family or personal comfort may matter more than usual at the beginning of the week. Some conversations could help settle an old concern. As the Moon moves through Cancer, creativity and emotional warmth increase, making personal connections easier. The weekend shifts attention towards work, routines and health.

“START WITH CHANGING UNHEALTHY
EATING HABITS TO HEALTHY ONES AND
MAKE THEM YOUR FAVORITES”
— SAHARA SANDERS

SHEETALA ASHTAMI

Where devotion rests upon a cool platter



ANIL
RAJPUT

There are Indian festivals in which the kitchen announces celebration through the hiss of hot ghee, the rhythm of grinding stones and the fragrance of food rising from an active stove. Sheetalashtami begins with the opposite sound: silence. The fire that normally sustains the household is allowed to rest, the cooking vessels have already completed their work, and the meal is served cool. Known widely as Basoda or Basora, the observance transforms food prepared on the previous day into an offering of devotion. What might appear to be a simple practice of eating yesterday's food is, in fact, a carefully ordered culinary tradition built around restraint, seasonal transition, maternal care and remembrance.

Sheetalashtami was observed on Wednesday, 11 March, on the Ashtami tithi of the Krishna Paksha in Chaitra. Since the festival follows Holi, it arrives as winter recedes and the first warmth of summer enters northern and western India. The principal cooking is completed on the preceding day, commonly associated with Sheetalasaptami, after which the hearth is cleaned and left unlit. Regional calendars differ, and some families worship on Saptami or another locally prescribed day after Holi, but the central practice remains the preparation of food in advance and its offering in a cooled state.

The festival is dedicated to Sheetalashtami, whose very name comes from the idea of sheetal, or coolness. This is more than a description of the goddess, for cooling provides the organising principle of the entire observance. Historically, Sheetalashtami was invoked particularly in relation to fever, eruptive illnesses and smallpox, a disease characterised by high fever followed by painful skin eruptions. If illness was experienced as dangerous heat within the body, Sheetalashtami represented its opposite. Soothing, cooling and relief. Her traditional imagery reinforces this association through the vessel she carries, together with the broom and neem leaves that came to signify cleansing and protection. The household translates this symbolism into ritual action. Its greatest source of heat, the cooking fire, is extinguished; freshly cooked dishes give way to food that has rested; curd and cool water assume particular importance; and the meal offered to the goddess is itself consumed cool. In symbolic terms, Sheetalashtami cools the body, the hearth and the household together. Historically, her worship offered communities a religious language through which the fear of epidemic disease, particularly smallpox, could be understood and endured.

This history also explains why the idea extends beyond a single festival name or region. Basoda or Sheetalashtami is especially prominent in Rajasthan, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh, but Gujarat preserves an especially close parallel through Randhan Chhath and Shitala Satam. Randhan Chhath is the cooking day, when food is prepared in advance, while on Shitala Satam the stove remains unlit and the previous day's food is offered and eaten. Further south, the practice is not identical, but an interesting echo appears in the worship of Mariamman in Tamil Nadu, another protective goddess historically associated with heat, illness and eruptive disease. At some Mariamman festivals, cooling preparations such as koozh, a porridge traditionally made using millet, form part of the offering. These traditions should not be treated as interchangeable, but together they reveal a wider Indian cultural vocabulary in which protective

goddesses, bodily heat and cooling foods repeatedly intersect.

The name Basoda is commonly associated with baasi bhojan, but translating this simply as "stale food" misses the ritual meaning. The meal is deliberately prepared on the previous day, allowed to cool, stored and then offered without lighting the hearth again. The act of cooling is itself devotional. On most festive days, sacred food is created through the transformational power of fire. Basoda reverses that relationship. Fire has already completed its work, and abstaining from fresh cooking becomes part of the offering. The timing after Holi also places the festival at a seasonal threshold, when northern India begins moving towards greater warmth. Traditional ideas of cooling the body, reducing excess heat and favouring foods that could be eaten without further cooking therefore sit naturally within both the religious symbolism and the changing season.

Among the most distinctive preparations is Meetha Oliya, particularly cherished in Rajasthani and Marwari homes. Cooked rice is cooled before being folded into smoothly whisked yoghurt with sugar, milk, cardamom and, in richer versions, saffron and nuts. Its gentle sweetness and cool texture embody the character of Sheetalashtami worship more precisely than almost any other dish. The rice softens further as it rests, while the yoghurt carries the fragrance of cardamom through the mixture. It may be offered during the morning puja and later served as part of the family meal, occupying a space between dessert, prasada and cooling nourishment.

The same idea appears in Namkeen Oliya, the savoury counterpart in which cooled rice and yoghurt are combined with salt and lightly crushed cumin. Some families add black pepper, mustard powder, raisins or dried fruit, creating an unusual balance of tartness, spice and sweetness. Unlike curd rice that receives a hot tempering in many southern traditions, Oliya is often kept free of any fresh sizzling tadka on the day of worship. Its preparation demonstrates how Basoda cuisine creates flavour without depending upon last-minute heat.

From the coolness of Oliya, the meal moves towards the dry, durable foods of Rajasthan. Pachkuta brings together preserved desert ingredients such as ker, sangri, kumath, gunda and dried mango. These are soaked, boiled where required and cooked with oil, asafoetida, cumin, coriander, chilli and amchur until intensely flavoured but relatively dry. Its presence links Basoda with Rajasthan's ecological intelligence, where communities learned to turn hardy berries, pods and stored produce into food capable of surviving scarcity and heat. When prepared on Saptami, Pachkuta develops greater depth overnight and can be eaten without reheating.

In homes that do not make the complete mixture, Ker Sangri may appear independently. The desert berries and beans are soaked to remove excess sharpness, then cooked with spices, yoghurt or dried mango according to household practice. Beside it, Kairi ki Launji provides a glossy, sweet-sour accompaniment made by cooking raw mango with jaggery or sugar, fennel, nigella, cumin and chilli. Because launji keeps well, it is particu-



larly suited to a festival that prohibits fresh cooking. Its sourness also cuts through fried breads and sweets. Rajasthan's official tourism material identifies ker and sangri as characteristic ingredients of the state's arid landscape and cuisine.

Gram flour contributes another set of preparations that remain satisfying after cooling. Sukhe Gatte are made by kneading besan with yoghurt, oil and spices, shaping the dough into cylinders, boiling them and cutting them into pieces. Instead of returning them to a gravy, they are tossed into a dry masala of cumin, coriander, chilli and amchur. Besan ki Roti, kneaded with spices and sometimes ghee, offers a firm bread to accompany Pachkuta or launji. In millet-eating households, Bajre ka Sogra, a thick pearl millet roti shaped by hand, may be cooked the previous day and eaten with curd, jaggery or preserved vegetables.

The fried savouries of Basoda are selected for their ability to hold their texture. Moong Dal Kachori encloses a filling of coarsely ground lentils, fennel, asafoetida, coriander and chilli within a crisp flour shell. The filling is cooked until dry so that the kachori remains stable overnight. Mathri, made from stiff dough enriched with ghee or oil and seasoned with ajwain, cumin or black pepper, becomes even crisper as it cools. Khichia or Papad, roasted or fried on the preparation day, adds a brittle contrast to yoghurt and rice. Together these foods turn the absence of freshly cooked food into a meal of deliberate contrasts.

Yoghurt returns through Dahi Bade, in which lentil dumplings are fried, soaked in water, gently pressed and placed in seasoned curd before the festival morning. As they rest, they absorb moisture and become soft enough to break with a spoon. Roasted cumin, black salt, red chilli and a little sweet chutney may be added before the hearth rests. In some parts of northern and western India, Kanji Vade provide a sharper variation. Small lentil dumplings are immersed in water fermented with ground mustard, salt and chilli, producing a tangy preparation associated with the

period around Holi. Its sourness, created through time rather than last-minute cooking, fits naturally into Basoda's cuisine.

A simpler but meaningful offering is Sukha Kala Chana. The chickpeas are soaked, boiled and tossed with cumin, asafoetida, coriander and dried mango until the moisture has evaporated. Served with breads and launji, they add substance without requiring a gravy and may also be distributed in small portions as prasada. The dish reflects an important feature of Basoda food: ingredients are often cooked fully and kept drier than they would be for an everyday meal.

Sweetness is equally important, and Meethe Chawal often form one of the central offerings. Rice is cooked with sugar or jaggery, cardamom, saffron, cloves, raisins and nuts until each grain is perfumed and lightly glazed. When cooled overnight, the flavours settle and the rice becomes firmer, making it easy to portion during worship. The dish sits comfortably beside Oliya because the two use the same staple in very different ways, one creamy and tart, the other fragrant and jewel-like.

Fried sweets provide some of the festival's most recognisable aromas on the day before worship. Pua is made from a batter of wheat flour, milk or water, sugar or jaggery, fennel and cardamom, then fried into small, soft-edged rounds. Gulgule use a thicker jaggery-sweetened wheat batter and are dropped into hot oil as irregular dumplings. Both remain pleasant after cooling, but their textures differ: pua is flatter and tender, while gulgule are plumper and chewier. Prepared in generous batches, they are offered to the goddess, shared with children and carried to neighbours.

Grain takes a richer form in Lapsi, where broken wheat is roasted in ghee and cooked with jaggery or sugar until the grains swell but retain a slight bite. Cardamom, raisins and nuts may be added, though many households prefer its rustic simplicity. Churma begins with wheat or millet dough shaped into thick breads or dumplings, cooked, cooled and crushed with ghee and jaggery. The two dishes express contrasting uses of grain: Lapsi preserves each granule, while Churma deliberately breaks the bread into a fragrant, crumbly sweet. For a more luxurious offering, some families

prepare Moong Dal Halwa, slowly roasting ground soaked lentils in ghee until their raw aroma gives way to deep nuttiness, then adding sugar syrup, cardamom and nuts. Because it requires patience, its preparation on Saptami becomes an act of devotion. Rabri offers a cooler richness. Milk is simmered as layers of cream are gathered and returned to the reduced liquid, which is sweetened and flavoured with cardamom or saffron. Once chilled, it may be offered in small bowls with pua, gulgule or crisp Shakkarpore, whose fried flour pieces are coated in sugar or made from sweetened dough.

Beverages are less uniformly prescribed than the foods, yet they complete the cooled meal in many homes. Chaas, whisked from curd and water with roasted cumin and salt, lightens the richer fried dishes. Meethi Lassi or Namkeen Lassi may be prepared before the cooking restriction begins and kept chilled. Thandai, still seasonally familiar after Holi, may appear with milk, fennel, pepper, cardamom, nuts and rose. The liquid from Kanji can itself be sipped as a sour fermented drink, while cool water offered to Sheetalashtami remains the simplest and most symbolic refreshment.

Sheetalashtami also carries a lesson that feels increasingly relevant in an age of food waste. For younger generations accustomed to associating freshness only with food cooked at that moment, the festival offers a different understanding. Food prepared the previous day is not automatically inferior or unwanted. When cooked thoughtfully, stored safely and consumed appropriately, it can remain nourishing while also carrying memory, ritual and meaning. Sheetalashtami therefore encourages a more respectful relationship with food, one that values preservation over waste and continuity over constant replacement. The dishes prepared for the festival were chosen precisely because they could rest, retain their flavour and still be shared the following day. Passing this knowledge forward can help younger generations understand that sustainability is not always a new idea. Indian culinary traditions have long contained practices of careful storage, preservation and respect for every ingredient. On Sheetalashtami, yesterday's food is not treated as a compromise. It becomes prasada, and in doing so reminds us that valuing food is itself a form of responsibility.

Sheetalashtami ultimately asks a household to recognise that care can be expressed not only through abundance and activity, but also through restraint. For one day, the stove falls silent, yet the kitchen continues to speak through rice softened in yoghurt, desert berries preserved against scarcity, grain roasted in ghee, lentil dumplings transformed through time and sweets prepared for sharing. Its history also reminds us how food once helped communities respond culturally and emotionally to illness, long before diseases such as smallpox could be defeated through modern medicine. The ritual did not cure the disease, but it gave cooling, care and protection a language that families could understand and practise together. To carry Basoda forward, future generations must therefore inherit more than the instruction to eat food prepared the previous day. They must learn why the hearth rests, why Sheetalashtami came to represent relief from burning illness, how Oliya differs from an ordinary bowl of curd and rice, why Pachkuta belongs to Rajasthan's ecology, how Gujarat carries a related tradition through Shitala Satam, and why the first portion becomes prasada before it becomes a meal.

When the methods, meanings and memories behind these foods are passed forward together, Basoda ceases to be merely a custom from another age. It remains what it has long been: a living conversation between food and faith, heat and coolness, health and hope, and one generation and the next.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)



Tricolour-themed popsicle add a festive touch to the streets as Independence Day approaches, bringing flavours and the colours of the national flag



Plating the colours of courage and peace

Food remains our favourite way to show national pride on August 15. Whether we crave nostalgic schoolyard snacks or share vibrant feasts with neighbors, eating together perfectly celebrates our freedom

TEAM AGENDA

August brings a long line of holidays, but the fifteenth always takes older generations right back to their early school days. You remember the drill. Waking up at dawn, wrestling into a stiff uniform, and standing in the assembly ground while the principal hoisted the flag. We sang the anthem with full throats, though half our minds were fixated on the reward waiting at the end.

That treat was usually the classic yellow paper packet. Finding a warm samosa, a sweet laddoo, and a cold

fruit drink inside felt like hitting the jackpot. Sometimes a lucky few got a bigger cardboard box filled with kachoris, sandwiches, and extra sweets. Entire generations grew up linking national pride with those simple snacks, creating a tradition people still crave decades later.

Families can bring that exact feeling back today by planning a menu around the Indian flag. Saffron, white, and green carry deep historical meaning, standing for bravery, peace, and progress. Bringing these specific shades to the dining table feels right and gives the day a wonderful festive spirit.

Planning this kind of menu takes a little imagination. Home cooks can start the morning with hot tricolour idlis coloured with carrot and spinach



puree, or serve soft and layered dhoklas. For lunch, they can transition to colourful dumplings in the national shades, along with traditional dishes like saffron |sweet rice, rich palak paneer, and plain white raita. By late afternoon, local bakeries start displaying tricolour cakes and tidy stacks of ribbon sandwiches. Round off the day by handing out pistachio-and-saffron kulfi to the children on your street — it turns the national holiday into a true neighbourhood celebration. Which school memory will you bring back to the table this Independence Day?



These golden laddoos remain the absolute heart of Independence Day, bringing back our favourite childhood schoolyard flag memories

Images are for representational purposes only

Uttar Dakshin: When North meets South

GYANESHWAR DAYAL

Uttar Dakshin, a unique 'sangam' of northern and southern dishes, sets the smoky, robust flavours of the north against the fiery, coconut-and-curry-leaf soul of the south. The festival's real achievement is restraint. Rather than a scattergun tour of "Indian cuisine", it plays two established culinary idioms against each other, dish by dish.

The vegetarian spread does this well: the Mathania Mirch Paneer Tikka carries its Rajasthani heat with confidence, while Kuzhi Paniyaram, dusted with milagai podi, brings a properly Tamil bite to the same table. A curry-leaf-tempered Hari Mirch Aloo and the Lucknowi Kathal Biryani sit a few feet apart, each unmistakably from its own region.

Non-vegetarian offerings lean on TGKF's real strength - the tandoor. The Malabari Spiced Kalmi Kabab and Khijra Murgh Boti Kabab carry coastal spice into the grill, while Meen Varuval and Andhra Masala Prawns keep the south's fire honest. Hyderabad's Kachhe Gosht ki Biryani anchors the meal's centre, and a slow-cooked Dak Bungalow Chicken Curry adds old-



world comfort. The cleverest handshake, though, is the



UTTAR DAKSHIN CELEBRATES INDIA'S UNITY THROUGH A VIBRANT CULINARY JOURNEY BLENDING THE DISTINCTIVE FLAVOURS OF NORTH AND SOUTH INDIA



Amritsari Fish — a Punjabi classic dusted with a gunpowder spice mix borrowed from further south.

Desserts close on the right note. A Pineapple Jalebi with Kesar Rabdi and a Mysore Pak Brownie make the same point as the mains, more gently: that fusion, done with intent, doesn't need to feel forced.

TGKF's format does the concept a favour. Kebabs are cooked using seven traditional methods, from tandoor and sigri to kadhai and stone grill, backed by a recipe bank of over 450 dishes. With unlimited servings, the menu changes daily while the standard remains. And for the Lucknow versus Hyderabad biryani debate, the answer is simple: order both. Both are Indian flavours.

Restoring the Rhythm of the Universe

AMMA (SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI DEVI)

A king once went hunting in the forest in disguise. In the course of the hunt he was separated from his companions and lost his way, and at last, worn out and hungry, he came upon a small hut. The forest-dwellers who lived there did not know him, and they gave him some fruits to eat.

He bit into one and said, "But this is bitter." They sighed. "What can be done? The king who rules this land is utterly selfish, given to pleasure, and cruel. He wrings heavy taxes from the poor, and those who cannot pay he puts to death. It is because of his unrighteous ways that even fruits that are sweet by nature have turned bitter."

Back in his palace, the king could not forget what he had seen in the forest. "It is because of me that my people suffer so," he thought, and was filled with remorse. He resolved to give the rest of his life to their good. He cut the taxes deeply, and began to give in charity and to help his people in their need.

After some time he again went hunting in disguise, and visited that same hut. The family gladly gave him fruits. When he tasted them, each and every one was sweet.

When he asked the reason for the change, they said, "Our king has wholly changed. He rules now with great goodness, and all his subjects are happy and content. Because of his good deeds, a positive change has come over nature as well, and that is why these fruits are sweet."

What is the heart of this story? In this universe everything has its rhythm. The wind and the rain, the sea and its waves, our own breath and the beating of our hearts — each keeps its own measure.

There is an undeniable relationship between all of creation and every being in it, both living and non-living. This cosmos is like a vast interconnected



In this universe everything has its rhythm. The wind and the rain, the sea and its waves, our own breath and the beating of our hearts — each keeps its own measure

orchestra. Suppose one instrument is out of tune. Even just one phrase from it is heard and felt by all the musicians.

Similarly, whether we are aware of it or not, all of our actions reverberate throughout creation, whether performed as an individual or as a group. We are not individual islands but links of a common chain.

For the health and long life of body and mind, that harmony must be preserved. It is our thoughts and deeds that become the music of our lives. When the rhythm of our minds goes offbeat, it echoes in our actions. The result is discordant noise that affects everything around us.

Mother Earth then responds to the behaviour of Her children. When our

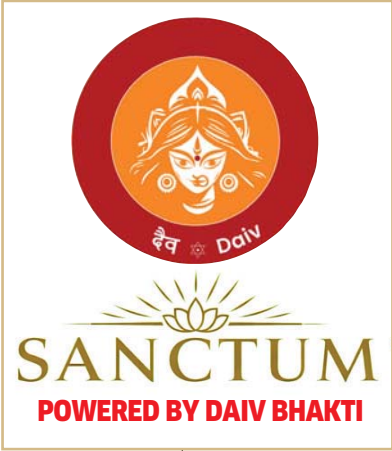
deeds are out of alignment with the music of the universe, Her cadence is thrown into disorder; when we tune in, She answers in kind, and our lives become beautiful music for others.

Today, we exploit the environment beyond all measure, and the balance of our world has been thrown awry; the selfish deeds of humankind rebound upon all that surrounds us. Behind dis-

asters such as tsunamis, landslides and earthquakes resounds, above all, nature's broken rhythm.

So each of us must take care to mend our ways. When the greater part of humanity turns to good deeds, our collective rhythm will be restored. Peace and prosperity will prevail upon the Earth, and the music of love and compassion will bring joy to the very heart of creation.

(Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, known simply as Amma, is a spiritual master and humanitarian who has given her darshan in the form of a motherly embrace to more than 4 crore people. Listening to the cries of the suffering, Amma leads an NGO that reaches across more than 50 countries, working in the areas of healthcare, disaster relief, education, gender equality, and environmental restoration)



The Most Important Thing in Life to Fulfill Your Potential

SADHGURU

#1 Reflect on what is around you

Your inner world, if you want to call it that, should only be a reflection of what is around you. This may be diametrically opposite to some moral theories that say the outer and the inner should not touch each other, otherwise you would immediately get corrupted by everything around you. That is not true. You get corrupted by what is around you only when you have opinions about everything.

You look at one thing as good, something else as bad. You get attached to what you consider as good. You desperately try to avoid what you consider as bad, and of course that will rule you from inside. This is not the way to

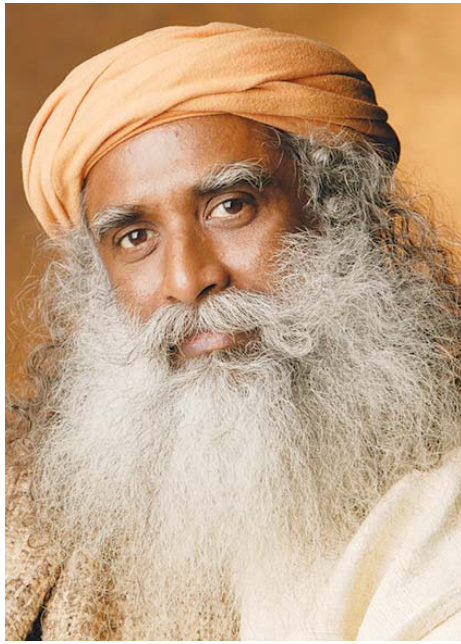
be. Seeing everything just the way it is — that is the way to be within. If you see something other than what is there, it means you are contaminating the world with your opinions and prejudices.

Creation is made so that you see it the way it is, not to make it the way you want to make it. This is an obscenity that humanity is committing upon the Creator's creation. Such a magnificent creation — what is there for you to do? Absorb it, if you can — nothing more — and even that is not simple because creation is phenomenally multi-tiered. There are not just things; so many phenomena are happening right here — one inside the other, all in one space, all in one time.

Everything that you think is past, everything that you think will be future is right here. If you see everything the way it is, if the whole creation reflects within you, if you can contain creation the way it is within you, you become the very source of creation. That is the way to be, inside and outside.

#2 Don't be a psychological case

Either you exist here as a piece of creation, which is pretty good, or you become like the very source of creation, which is fantastic. But being a psycho-



unfortunate that most people cannot think beyond food, education, and things like that.

Suppose the country or the world was doing really well — everyone had enough to eat, everyone was well educated, everything was happening well — what meaning would it have to start an Isha Vidhya school and to give a midday meal? Right now, when the children have not eaten properly, the midday meal seems like a great blessing. It is a blessing only because of the cruelty of poverty. It is not a true blessing. Only because we created human beings without having the necessary food for them, serving them a meal feels like a great thing. I don't think it is. It is unfortunate that such things are still needed in the world.

Even if everyone had eaten well and they had everything they wanted, enhancing the experience of life to its ultimate possibility would still always be relevant. Ultimately, this is the purpose of all life — to blossom to its fullest potential. Whether it is a little plant, a tree, an elephant, an ant, a man, or a woman — the ultimate goal is to become a full-fledged life.

But being in the world, we have to play some game. Let us play a game that is of maximum usefulness and meaning to everyone around us. If you reflect creation just the way it is, there is no personal need to play a game and no compulsion to be a part of any game. Whether you withdraw into a cave or plunge into the marketplace, it is still a game. The only way to not be part of any game is to dissolve. That is a great thing to do, but when human beings attain to a certain clarity within themselves, they are of immense value to everyone around, so it is good if they hang around for a while and bring a little more clarity to others.

(Ranked amongst the fifty most influential people in India, Sadhguru is a Yogi, mystic, visionary and a New York Times bestselling author. Sadhguru has been conferred the Padma Vibhushan by the Government of India in 2017, the highest annual civilian award, accorded for exceptional and distinguished service. He is also the founder of the world's largest people's movement, Conscious Planet-Save Soil, which has touched over 4 billion people)

Nilkanth Varni: A Beacon of Universal Values

Bhagwan Nilkanth Varni's historic journey across India embodied the universal values of compassion, courage, service, and unity, inspiring millions across generations to transform themselves and the world around them



DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

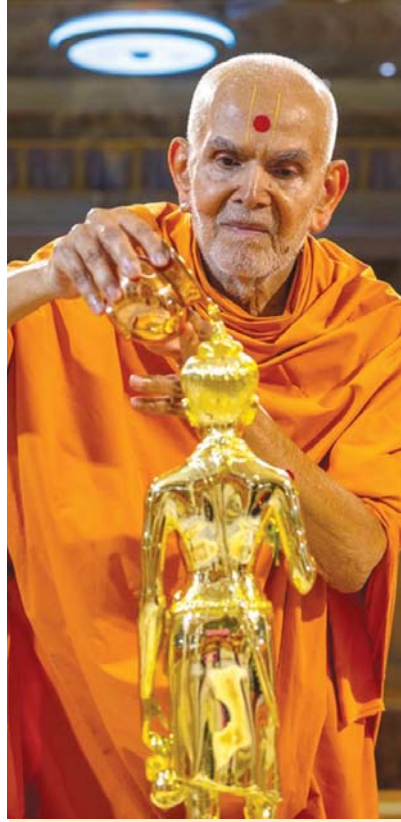
Two hundred and thirty years ago, after long wanderings, Bhagwan Nilkanth Varni once arrived at a city called Bansi (UP). At some distance from the town flowed a river where he bathed daily, absorbed in divine remembrance. One day, while bathing in its calm waters, he witnessed a painful sight. Two royal hunters struck down a rare and beautiful bird. The wounded creature cried out in unbearable agony before falling lifeless. That cry pierced twelve-year-old Varni's compassionate heart. Deeply moved, tears of empathy flowed within him.

Unable to bear the sorrow, he fasted that day and avoided entering the city. He spent the night alone in the forest, yet the pain in his heart did not lessen. Around midnight, overwhelmed by grief at the cruelty he had witnessed, words escaped from him: "Hell with this city." Such was the power of his words that the utterance immediately manifested. Flames engulfed the city.

The city started to burn. Everyone was running here and there in search of their life. Seeing them, Varni was filled with intense remorse. "I have come to remove suffering, not to cause it," he thought. With urgency and compassion, he rushed to the river, plunged into the waters, and cried aloud, "Cool down, cool down!" Instantly, the flames subsided.

Yet he felt no peace. Reflecting deeply, he resolved that even unintended words should never bring harm. In a rare act of spiritual mastery, he cursed his own speech: "Let my words become fruitless when they may cause pain to others." Such was the immense and unparalleled compassion of Nilkanth Varni. It was not only for humanity but for all beings.

Born as Ghanshyam in the small village of Chhapaiya, Uttar Pradesh, on Chaitra Shukla Navami (31/4/1781), Nilkanth's childhood itself bore unmistakable signs of divinity. Wisdom flowed naturally from him, compassion radiated effortlessly, and spiritual depth manifested spontaneously. Yet, what makes his life profoundly stirring is not merely his divine identity, but the path he chose to reveal it. At an age when the world still clings to comfort and affection, Nilkanth Varni renounced everything. At just eleven years old, with no possessions and no companions, he stepped



BHAGWAN NILKANTH VARNI ONCE ARRIVED AT A CITY CALLED BANSI (UP). AT SOME DISTANCE FROM THE TOWN FLOWED A RIVER WHERE HE BATHED DAILY, ABSORBED IN DIVINE REMEMBRANCE

into the unknown, not as a helpless child, but as a fearless divine Yogi, beginning a journey that would become one of the most extraordinary spiritual pilgrimages in history.

Barefoot and unprotected, he traversed the length and breadth of India for seven long years. Through the icy silence of the Himalayas, the dense forests echoing with unseen dangers, the flowing rivers, and the scorching plains, he walked more than 12000 KM with unshaken composure. This was not merely physical endurance; it was the living expression of absolute detachment and unwavering purpose. Hunger did not disturb him, harsh climates did not weaken him, and solitude did not

burden him. In every step, there was a quiet proclamation: that one who is anchored in the divine remains untouched by the fluctuations of the world.

Yet his journey was not one of isolation; it was one of deep engagement with humanity. His solo mission was to help humanity. So, wherever he went, he encountered seekers, scholars, ascetics, and ordinary villagers. He did not merely observe; he questioned, guided, and transformed. His inquiries into the nature of the soul, the supremacy of God, and the path to liberation were not intellectual exercises; they were divine revelations disguised as dialogue. Many who considered themselves learned found their understanding reshaped in his presence. Others, burdened by suffering or confusion, found clarity and peace.

What makes Nilkanth Varni a beacon of universal values is the seamless way in which his life embodied the highest ideals. Fearlessness was not a virtue he taught; it was the way he lived. Walking alone through perilous terrains, he demonstrated that true courage arises from faith, not from physical strength. Compassion was not selective in him; it flowed equally towards all beings, transcending boundaries of caste, creed, or status. His renunciation was not rejection but realization, that the transient can never satisfy the eternal within. His discipline was not imposed; it was the natural rhythm of a mind established in purity. And his wisdom was not acquired; it was innate, flowing from the very source of truth.

At a time when spirituality had become burdened with empty rituals and forgotten values, Nilkanth Varni emerged as a silent reformer. He did not reject tradition; he restored its true purpose. He taught that genuine religion is not about outward display but inner transformation, not mechanical rituals but heartfelt devotion, and not division but seeing God in all.

When his spiritual journey led him to Gujarat, Nilkanth Varni became known to the world as Bhagwan Swaminarayan. The universal values he lived and taught continue to inspire millions and are beautifully exemplified today in the life and teachings of Mahant Swami Maharaj.

(Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Joy is found only in the present moment. Yet usually we find the mind swinging back and forth between the past and the future. The final-year school kids are anxious about what to do after graduation. At the start of their career, people worry about achieving career goals. Professionally settled people want to purchase a new house, find a good life partner, and get married. After getting married, people want to have children. When they become parents, they wait for their children to settle down. It is like you prepared the bed to sleep all night without sleeping at all!

We keep postponing our happiness and peace of mind. We imagine life is about securing a job, building a bank balance, and creating the perfect family. One desire gives rise to another, and the race never ends. In the process, we become miserable. And when misery takes over, we lose our health, our peace, our relationships, and even our reputation.

Life is a celebration. Life is commitment. Life is wisdom. Life is seva-selfless service. We are here on this planet for only a short while. So why suffer, and why make others suffer? Who said what, when, or why-how long can you hold on to these things?

When life revolves around commitment, care, service, celebration, attainment of wisdom, and upliftment of the human spirit, grace replaces misery. And when life becomes a celebration, then money, reputation, relationships, and health all come back to us. It is ironic because what we spent our lives chasing was always with us.

We are here for a very short period of time on this planet. Have you noticed how most of us spend our time here? Suppose we live for 80 years. In those 80 years, we spend around 26 years and 8 months sleeping. Each day, we spend 2.5 hours on food and nearly 6 years and 8 months just eating over an 80-year lifetime. Similarly, we spend 2.5 years in the toilet. If we live in a big city like New York or Mumbai, we spend nearly 3 to 5 years in traffic. We hardly get around 30 years to do something productive. This is the time when we truly live our lives.

Let us observe our mind. We spend an enormous amount of time thinking about the past. Yet the past is past. It is gone, finished. Why should we waste time thinking about something unalterable? The same holds for worrying about the future. We postpone our happiness until some future date, but it never arrives. If we live life now, tomorrow



row will take care of itself.

We must remember that every season in our life has had an impact on us. It has made us grow, given us strength. Rain brings mud, but it has also brought rainbows, and rainbows have brought colors into our lives. Peacocks wait for the rain. When they see dark clouds gathering in the sky, they open their colorful feathers. And when it rains, they dance so beautifully!

Similarly, when darkness comes in our lives, it doesn't forebode the end. The phases of darkness also pass away with time. There are 2 ways to go through the dark phases: we either cry, complain, and blame, or we sing and dance through it. And when we sing and dance in the rain, we get soaked in joy.

So, let us cultivate the habit of being happy. Only we can do this for ourselves. Nobody else can do this for us.

The strength of our happiness is measured by the number of adverse situations we can smile through. It is easy to be happy when life is smooth. But if we can smile through all kinds of opposing situations that life brings, then we have grown. Let's tell ourselves, 'Whatever happens, I am not going to be unhappy.' This inner strength and 'santosh' (contentment) are qualities we must develop. And I tell you, this can definitely be done. It is possible.

There is a famous Mullah Nasreddin story around this. Mullah Nasreddin used to grumble all the time. He was a farmer, and he would grumble about the shortfall of rain, 'Oh, there is no rain, and no crops are growing.' Next year, there was abundant rainfall, and Mullah had a bumper harvest. People thought, 'This year Nasreddin wouldn't grumble.' So people went to greet him, 'Oh, Mullah! How are you? You seem to be doing very well. Mother Nature has bestowed you with a bountiful harvest

of crops. The lush green crops look so amazing.' But Mullah wore the same grumpy look. He said, 'Yes, the yield is great but now I will have to do more work in the fields!' In all these dry years, I didn't have to do anything. But now with so much produce, I have to harvest and sell it in the market. It is a big headache.' Whether there were crops or not, Mullah continued to grumble.

The same is true in our lives. We are unhappy about what we don't have and we are unhappy with what is there already. Those who don't own a car are unhappy, while those who do often worry about high maintenance costs, traffic congestion, parking scarcity, rising fuel prices, and insurance and taxes.

One needs to develop the habit of being happy. We have to take responsibility for our happiness. If our happiness depends on a person, a thing, a situation, or time, it will only be temporary. Somebody once asked me, "What was the happiest time of your life?" I said, 'What? The happiest time of my life? Why do you connect 'time' with 'happiness'? I am happiness!'

The nature of time is that it is always changing. Life is a mix of good times and bad times. If we connect our 'happiness' to 'time', our state of being happy also changes with time. When we have this conviction that happiness has nothing to do with time, we can be happy forever. And this is the wisdom of life. All we need to do is disassociate our joy from people, places, situations, or time and realize that our innate nature is happiness. This is the highest knowledge of life. It may sound like a very difficult state of mind to attain, but it isn't. Any fool can be unhappy when things aren't okay. But it takes courage to be happy even when things are falling apart. And we all are courageous and strong.